AI Automation Playbook

for SMEs

12 Step-by-Step Playbooks to Automate
Your Business Processes with AI

50 Ready-to-Use Prompt Templates | Tool Comparison Matrix
Project Tracker | Implementation Guides

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Chapter 1

How to Think About Automation

Stop Thinking "Replace Humans" — Start Thinking "Layers"

Most business owners hear "AI automation" and imagine one of two extremes: either a robot completely running their business, or a fancy chatbot that's more trouble than it's worth. The reality is neither.

The most successful businesses don't automate everything at once. They think in layers — gradually moving tasks from fully manual to AI-assisted, and eventually to fully automated. This chapter gives you the mental model to make smart automation decisions instead of expensive mistakes.

The 3-Layer Automation Model

Think of every business task as sitting on one of three levels:

Layer 1: Manual (Human Does Everything)

This is where most small businesses start — and where many stay longer than they need to. Someone on your team does the task from start to finish using their brain, their time, and their judgment.

Examples:

- Reading every customer email and typing a reply from scratch
- Manually entering invoice data into a spreadsheet
- Attending meetings and writing notes by hand afterward
- Reviewing every lead that comes in and deciding who to call

When this is fine:

- The task is rare (happens once a month or less)
- It requires deep expertise or nuanced judgment every single time
- The consequences of getting it wrong are severe (legal, financial, reputational)
-

You're still figuring out the process itself

The cost of staying here too long: Your most expensive resource — human attention — gets burned on repetitive work. A €50,000/year employee spending 5 hours a week on email responses is spending ~€3,000/year on work AI could assist with.

Layer 2: AI-Assisted (Human + AI Together)

This is the sweet spot for most SMEs right now. AI does the heavy lifting — drafting, sorting, extracting, summarizing — and a human reviews, edits, and approves.

Examples:

- AI drafts email responses; a team member reviews and sends
- AI extracts data from invoices; someone verifies the numbers
- AI transcribes meetings and generates action items; the manager checks and assigns
- AI scores leads; a salesperson reviews the top-scored ones

When this makes sense:

- The task is repetitive but needs some human judgment
- Getting it 80-90% right automatically is good enough (human catches the rest)
- You want to save time without losing quality
- You're not ready to fully trust AI with the process yet

Why this layer is powerful: You get 60-80% of the time savings of full automation with almost none of the risk. The human is still in the loop, catching mistakes and handling edge cases.

Layer 3: Fully Automated (AI Does Everything)

AI handles the entire task from trigger to completion, with no human involvement. Humans only step in when something breaks or for periodic quality reviews.

Examples:

- Chatbot handles common customer questions 24/7, only escalating unusual ones
- Invoices are automatically scanned, categorized, and entered into accounting software
- Meeting recordings are auto-transcribed and action items are posted to your project management tool
- Basic lead scoring happens automatically; only qualified leads reach a human

When this makes sense:

- The task is highly repetitive and predictable
- Error tolerance is moderate (small mistakes don't cause major harm)
- You've already tested the AI-assisted version and it works well
- The volume justifies the setup effort

The trap to avoid: Jumping straight to full automation without testing AI-assisted first. That's how you end up with an AI chatbot insulting customers or auto-approving fraudulent invoices.

The Golden Rule: Move One Layer at a Time

Here's the single most important principle in this entire playbook:

Never skip a layer.

If a task is currently manual, move it to AI-assisted first. Run it that way for 2-4 weeks. Fix the problems. Tune the prompts. Build confidence. Then decide if it's worth moving to fully automated.

Companies that try to jump from Layer 1 to Layer 3 almost always:

1. Spend too much money on tools they don't need yet
2. Create automations that produce garbage output
3. Lose trust in AI entirely and go back to manual
4. Waste months instead of saving hours

The incremental approach is faster in the long run because you learn what works before you commit.

Real-World Example: Customer Support Emails

Let's see how this plays out with a real process:

Layer 1 (Manual): Sarah reads every email. She types every reply. She handles 30 emails/day, spending about 3 minutes each. That's 1.5 hours of her day, every day.

Layer 2 (AI-Assisted): Sarah copies the customer email into ChatGPT with a prompt template.

AI drafts a reply in 10 seconds. Sarah reviews it, makes small edits (30 seconds), and sends. Time per email drops from 3 minutes to 1 minute. She saves 1 hour per day.

Layer 3 (Fully Automated): Common email categories (shipping questions, return requests, password resets) are auto-replied by AI integrated with the helpdesk. Sarah only handles complex or sensitive emails. Her email time drops to 20 minutes/day for the exceptions. She saves 1 hour 10 minutes per day.

Notice how Layer 2 alone saved the majority of the time. Layer 3 added more savings, but it also required more setup (integration with helpdesk software, building category rules, testing edge cases). Many businesses would be perfectly happy staying at Layer 2.

The Decision Framework: Should You Automate This?

Before automating any task, ask these five questions:

1. How often does this happen?

- Daily or multiple times per day → Strong candidate
- Weekly → Good candidate
- Monthly or less → Probably not worth automating yet

2. How repetitive is it?

- Same basic process every time → Strong candidate
- Similar but with frequent variations → AI-assisted is good; full automation is risky
- Completely different every time → Keep it manual

3. What happens if AI gets it wrong?

- Minor inconvenience (can be easily corrected) → Safe to automate
- Moderate impact (annoyed customer, wrong data) → Use AI-assisted with human review
- Severe consequences (legal issues, lost money, damaged reputation) → Keep heavy human oversight

4. How much time does it consume?

-

5+ hours per week → High-priority automation target
- 1-5 hours per week → Worth automating if it's straightforward
- Less than 1 hour per week → Probably not worth the setup effort

5. Do you understand the process well?

- Yes, it's well-documented and predictable → Ready to automate
- Sort of, but there are lots of judgment calls → AI-assisted only
- No, it's in someone's head → Document it first, automate later

Quick decision: If a task scores "strong candidate" on at least 3 out of 5 questions, it's worth trying AI-assisted automation. Start there.

What NOT to Automate (Yet)

Some things aren't ready for automation, no matter how much time they take:

- Relationship-building conversations — AI can draft follow-ups, but genuine connection needs a human
- Strategic decisions — AI can provide analysis, but choosing your company's direction is yours
- Creative work that defines your brand — AI can help, but your unique voice comes from you
- Processes you don't understand yet — Automating chaos just creates faster chaos
- One-time or rare tasks — The setup time won't pay off

Your Starting Mindset

Going into the rest of this playbook, keep these principles in mind:

1. Start with AI-assisted, not full automation. Every playbook in this book will show you the assisted version first.
2. Think in hours saved, not perfection achieved. Saving 5 hours a week with 90% accuracy beats spending months chasing 100%.
3. One process at a time. Pick the highest-impact task, automate it, stabilize it, then move to the next.

4. Your team's trust matters. If your employees fear AI will replace them, they'll sabotage it. Position AI as their assistant, not their replacement.
5. Budget is not the bottleneck. Most of the playbooks in this book can be started with free tools. Time and attention are the real costs.

What's Next

In Chapter 2, you'll learn a simple scoring system to decide which tasks to automate first — so you get the biggest wins fastest. Then from Chapter 3 onward, we'll dive into specific playbooks you can implement this week.

Let's figure out your priorities.

Chapter 2

Choosing What to Automate First

The Biggest Mistake: Automating the Wrong Thing

You're excited about AI automation. You've read Chapter 1. You understand the layers. Now comes the question that makes or breaks your automation journey:

Which task do you automate first?

Get this right, and you'll save real time within a week, build confidence, and gain momentum. Get it wrong, and you'll spend two weeks on something that saves 15 minutes a month — and wonder why everyone says AI is overhyped.

This chapter gives you a dead-simple scoring system to find your best automation candidates, plus the common mistakes that trip up first-timers.

The Effort/Impact/Risk (EIR) Scoring System

Every task you're considering automating can be scored on three dimensions:

Impact: How Much Time and Value Will This Save?

Score from 1 to 5:

Score	Meaning	Example
1	Saves less than 30 minutes per week	Formatting a single weekly report
2	Saves 30 min–1 hour per week	Sorting incoming emails into folders
3	Saves 1–3 hours per week	Drafting responses to common customer questions
4	Saves 3–5 hours per week	Processing invoices and entering data
5	Saves 5+ hours per week OR unlocks new capability	Qualifying all inbound leads automatically

Don't just count hours. A task that saves 1 hour but eliminates a constant source of frustration for your

team might deserve a higher impact score. A task that currently doesn't get done at all (like following up with every lead) gets a high score because automation enables something new.

Effort: How Hard Is It to Set Up?

Score from 1 to 5 (here, lower is better — less effort is more attractive):

Score	Meaning	Example
1	Under 1 hour, free tools, copy-paste prompts	Using ChatGPT to draft email replies
2	1–3 hours, free tools, some configuration	Building a FAQ from existing documents
3	3–8 hours, might need a paid tool, some integration	Setting up Otter.ai for meeting transcription
4	1–2 days, paid tools required, workflow changes	Connecting invoice scanning to accounting software
5	Multiple days, custom development or complex integration	Building a custom AI chatbot on your website

Risk: What Happens If the AI Gets It Wrong?

Score from 1 to 5 (again, lower is better — less risk is more attractive):

Score	Meaning	Example
1	No real consequences, easily caught and fixed	Internal meeting summary has a typo
2	Minor inconvenience, quick to correct	Draft email needs editing before sending
3	Could annoy a customer or cause rework	Wrong category on an invoice
4	Could lose money or damage a relationship	Incorrect lead score causes bad follow-up
5	Legal, financial, or reputational harm	Auto-approved contract with bad terms

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How to Calculate Your Priority Score

For each task, calculate:

Priority Score = Impact − (Effort × 0.5) − (Risk × 0.5)

The higher the score, the better the candidate for your first automation.

Why the formula works:

- High impact pushes the score up (you want big wins)
- High effort pulls it down (you want quick wins)
-

High risk pulls it down (you want safe wins)

- Effort and risk are weighted at 0.5 because a very impactful task can justify some effort and some risk

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Scoring Template

Copy this template and fill it in for your top 5-10 repetitive tasks:

```
AUTOMATION PRIORITY SCORECARD
============================

Task: ________________________________
Who does it now: ______________________
How often: ____________________________
Time spent per week: ________________

SCORING (circle one for each):

Impact (1-5):      1    2    3    4    5
Effort (1-5):      1    2    3    4    5
Risk (1-5):        1    2    3    4    5

Priority Score = Impact - (Effort × 0.5) - (Risk × 0.5)
= ____ - (____ × 0.5) - (____ × 0.5)
= ________

NOTES:
- Current pain point: ________________________
- What would AI-assisted version look like: _________________________
- First step to test: _________________________
```

Worked Example: Scoring Four Tasks

Let's say you run a 15-person services company and you're considering automating these tasks:

Task 1: Customer Email Responses

- Impact: 4 (saves 3-5 hours/week across the team)
-

Effort: 1 (copy-paste prompts into ChatGPT, under an hour to set up)
- Risk: 2 (human reviews before sending)
- Priority Score: 4 − 0.5 − 1.0 = 2.5 ✅ Great candidate

Task 2: Meeting Notes & Action Items

- Impact: 3 (saves 1-2 hours/week, reduces forgotten action items)
- Effort: 2 (need to set up a transcription tool, train the team)
- Risk: 1 (internal use only, mistakes are harmless)
- Priority Score: 3 − 1.0 − 0.5 = 1.5 ✅ Good candidate

Task 3: Invoice Processing

- Impact: 3 (saves 2-3 hours/week)
- Effort: 4 (need paid tools, accounting software integration)
- Risk: 3 (wrong numbers could cause accounting errors)
- Priority Score: 3 − 2.0 − 1.5 = −0.5 ⚠ Not a great first project

Task 4: Website Chatbot

- Impact: 3 (could handle after-hours inquiries)
- Effort: 5 (custom development, needs training data, ongoing maintenance)
- Risk: 4 (customer-facing with no human review)
- Priority Score: 3 − 2.5 − 2.0 = −1.5 ⚠ Save this for later

Winner: Customer email responses — highest score, lowest effort, manageable risk with human review.

How to Prioritize: The 4-Step Process

Step 1: Brain Dump (15 minutes)

Write down every repetitive task in your business. Don't filter — just list. Ask your team:

- "What task do you dread most?"
- "What do you spend time on that feels like it could be automated?"
- "What falls through the cracks because nobody has time?"

Aim for 10-20 tasks. Here are common categories to prompt your thinking:

- Email and communication
- Data entry and processing
- Scheduling and follow-ups
- Report creation
- Research and information gathering
- Customer support
- Content creation
- Document handling

Step 2: Score Each Task (20 minutes)

Use the EIR scoring template for each task. Be honest — don't inflate impact scores because you're excited about a particular automation.

Step 3: Rank by Priority Score (5 minutes)

Sort your tasks from highest to lowest priority score. Your first automation project is the task at the top of the list.

Step 4: Start with ONE (important!)

Pick the single highest-scoring task and commit to implementing it this week. Do not start three automations simultaneously. Here's why:

- You need to learn the rhythm of testing and refining prompts
- Your team needs to adjust to working with AI on one process before adding more
- If something goes wrong, you want to know which automation caused it
- Quick wins build momentum; juggling multiple projects builds frustration

After you've had your first automation running smoothly for 2-3 weeks, move to the next one on your list.

Common Mistakes When Choosing What to Automate

Mistake 1: Automating What's Exciting Instead of What's Impactful

"Let's build an AI chatbot on our website!" sounds cool. But if your team spends 4 hours a day on email and your website gets 20 visitors a day, the chatbot is a vanity project. Automate email first.

Fix: Always start with the EIR score, not your gut feeling.

Mistake 2: Starting with the Hardest Task

Some business owners think "If AI can handle the hard stuff, it can handle everything." So they try to automate their most complex process first, fail, and conclude AI doesn't work.

Fix: Start with something simple. Your first win should be easy to achieve. Build from there.

Mistake 3: Automating a Broken Process

If your current process is chaotic, inconsistent, or undocumented, automating it will just create automated chaos. AI is excellent at doing predictable things faster — it's terrible at fixing your broken workflows.

Fix: If you can't write down the steps for a process on one page, document and simplify it first, then automate.

Mistake 4: Ignoring the "Who Does This Now?" Question

If only one person does a task and they're fine with it, automating might create resistance instead of relief. If a task is spread across the team and everyone hates it, automation will be welcomed with open arms.

Fix: Talk to the people who do the work. Their buy-in matters more than your spreadsheet says.

Mistake 5: Optimizing for Full Automation Too Early

The goal of your first project is NOT full automation. It's AI-assisted automation — saving time while keeping a human in the loop. Full automation is Layer 3. You're building to Layer 2.

Fix: Re-read Chapter 1. Move one layer at a time.

Mistake 6: Not Tracking Time Before and After

If you don't know how long a task takes now, you can't prove your automation saved time. Without proof, it's hard to justify expanding to more automations.

Fix: Before you automate anything, have the person doing the task track their time for one week. After automation, track again. Simple before/after comparison.

Your Action Plan

Before moving to the playbook chapters, do this:

1. Spend 15 minutes listing every repetitive task in your business
2. Score your top 10 using the EIR template
3. Pick #1 — the highest-scoring task
4. Flip to the matching playbook chapter and implement it this week

If your top-scoring task matches one of our playbooks (Chapters 3-7), you're in luck — we've done the work of writing step-by-step instructions for you. If it doesn't match exactly, the framework still applies: start with AI-assisted, use the prompts as templates, and iterate.

Quick Reference: Which Playbook Chapter to Use

Your Top Task	Go To
Responding to customer emails	Chapter 3
Building a FAQ or knowledge base	Chapter 4
Qualifying or scoring leads	Chapter 5
Meeting notes and action items	Chapter 6
Processing invoices, receipts, or contracts	Chapter 7

Let's get to the playbooks.

Chapter 3

Playbook: Customer Email Response

What This Playbook Does

This playbook shows you how to use AI to draft responses to customer emails — cutting the time per email from 3-5 minutes of writing to 30-60 seconds of reviewing and editing.

You'll still send every email yourself (or your team will). AI writes the first draft; humans polish and send. This is Layer 2 automation — AI-assisted with human review.

Estimated implementation time: 2-4 hours

Expected time savings: 3-5 hours per week (for a team handling 20+ emails/day)

Difficulty: Beginner

Tools You'll Need

Free Options

- ChatGPT (free tier) — paste emails in, get draft replies
- Claude (free tier at claude.ai) — excellent at matching tone and handling nuance
- Google Gemini (free at gemini.google.com) — integrates with Gmail

Paid Options (for higher volume or integration)

- ChatGPT Plus ($20/month) — faster, smarter model, no usage limits during peak times
- Zendesk AI (from $55/agent/month) — built-in AI reply suggestions within your helpdesk
- Freshdesk Freddy AI (from $29/agent/month) — AI-powered response drafts in your ticketing system
- Front (from $19/seat/month) — shared inbox with AI draft features

Start with the free option. You can always upgrade later once you see results.

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Gather Your Reference Material (30 minutes)

Before AI can write replies that sound like your company, it needs context. Collect:

1. Your 20 most common customer questions — Ask your team: "What emails do you answer over and over?" Common categories include:

- Shipping and delivery status
- Return/refund requests
- Product questions
- Pricing inquiries
- Account/login issues
- Complaint handling
- General information requests

2. 5-10 example replies you're happy with — Actual emails your team has sent that represent how you want to communicate. These teach AI your tone.

3. Basic company info — Return policy, shipping times, pricing, business hours, contact details. AI needs facts to give accurate answers.

Save all of this in a single document. This becomes your "company context" that you'll include in your prompts.

Step 2: Create Your Company Context Block (20 minutes)

Write a block of text that describes how your company communicates. You'll paste this at the top of your AI prompts. Here's a template:

> Company Context Prompt Template:

>

> You are a customer service assistant for [Company Name]. We are a [brief description — e.g., "small e-commerce company selling handmade candles"].

>

> Our communication style is: [friendly and warm / professional and concise / casual and approachable — pick one].

>

> Key policies:

- Returns: [your policy, e.g., "30-day returns, customer pays return shipping"]

- Returns: [your policy, e.g., "30-day returns, customer pays return shipping"]

> - Shipping: [your info, e.g., "Standard shipping 3-5 business days, express 1-2 days"]
>
> - Business hours: [your hours, e.g., "Mon-Fri 9-5 CET"]
>
> - Refunds: [your policy, e.g., "Full refund within 14 days of return receipt"]

>

> Important rules for replies:
>
> - Always address the customer by name if they provided it
>
> - Never promise something we can't deliver
>
> - If you're unsure about something, say "Let me check with our team and get back to you" instead of guessing
>
> - Keep replies concise — 3-5 sentences for simple questions, more for complex issues
>
> - Sign off as [name/team name]

Step 3: Build Your Reply Prompt Template (30 minutes)

This is the prompt you (or your team) will use every time a customer email comes in. Test it a few times and adjust until you like the output.

> Email Reply Prompt:

>

> [Paste your Company Context block from Step 2 here]

>

> A customer has sent the following email:

>

> ---
>
> [Paste the customer's email here]
>
> ---

>

> Write a reply that:
>
> 1. Acknowledges their concern or question
>
> 2. Provides a clear, helpful answer based on our policies
>
> 3. Offers a next step if applicable
>
> 4. Maintains our brand tone

>

> Keep the reply concise and professional. Do not include a subject line.

Step 4: Test with 10 Real Emails (1 hour)

Take 10 recent customer emails and run them through your prompt. For each one:

1. Paste the customer email into ChatGPT or Claude with your prompt
2. Read the AI's draft reply
3. Note what's good and what needs editing
4. Track how long the review/edit takes vs. writing from scratch

What to look for:

- Does the tone match your brand?
- Are the facts correct?
- Is the response the right length?
- Does it miss anything the customer asked?

Step 5: Refine Your Prompt (30 minutes)

Based on your test results, adjust the prompt. Common refinements:

If replies are too long:

Add to your prompt: "Keep the reply under 100 words."

If the tone is too formal:

Add: "Write in a casual, friendly tone. Use contractions (we're, you'll, etc.)."

If AI is making up policies:

Add: "Only reference the policies listed above. If the customer's question isn't covered by these policies, say: 'I'll check with our team on this and get back to you within 24 hours.'"

If AI misses parts of the customer's email:

Add: "Before writing the reply, list all questions or concerns the customer raised. Address each one."

Step 6: Create Category-Specific Prompts (30 minutes)

Once your general prompt works, create specialized prompts for your most common categories. These produce better results than a one-size-fits-all prompt.

Refund Request Prompt:

Refund Request Prompt:

>

> [Company Context]

>

> A customer is requesting a refund. Their email:

>

> ---
>
> [Customer email]
>
> ---

>

> Write a reply that:
>
> 1. Empathizes with their situation
>
> 2. Confirms our refund policy (30-day window, original payment method, 5-7 business days processing)

> 3. Asks for their order number if they didn't provide it
>
> 4. Provides clear next steps
>
> 5. Reassures them we want to make it right

> Shipping Status Prompt:

>

> [Company Context]

>

> A customer is asking about their order/shipping status. Their email:

>

> ---
>
> [Customer email]
>
> ---

>

> Write a reply that:
>
> 1. Thanks them for their order
>
> 2. Explains our standard shipping timeline (3-5 business days)
>
> 3. Asks for their order number if they didn't provide it (so we can look up tracking)
>
> 4. Provides the tracking link format if available: [your tracking URL format]
>
> 5. Offers to escalate if the order is significantly delayed

Complaint Handling Prompt:

Complaint Handling Prompt:

>

> [Company Context]

>

> A customer is unhappy and has written a complaint. Their email:

>

> ---
>
> [Customer email]
>
> ---

>

> Write a reply that:
>
> 1. Leads with a genuine apology — acknowledge what went wrong
> 2. Does NOT make excuses
> 3. Offers a specific resolution (refund, replacement, discount — choose the most appropriate based on the complaint)
> 4. Provides a clear timeline for resolution
> 5. Invites them to reach out if they need anything else
> 6. Tone should be humble and solution-focused

Step 7: Roll Out to Your Team (30 minutes)

Share the prompts with your team. Here's how to make adoption smooth:

1. Create a shared document with all your prompts (Google Doc, Notion page, or even a simple text file)
2. Demo it live — show the team how you use it on a real email
3. Set the expectation: "AI writes the draft, you own the send button. Always read before sending."
4. Make it easy — bookmark ChatGPT/Claude, have the prompts one click away

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Example: Before and After

Customer's Email:

Hi, I ordered the vanilla candle set last Tuesday and I haven't received any shipping confirmation. Can you tell me what's going on? I need these for a party on Saturday.

> Hi, I ordered the vanilla candle set last Tuesday and I haven't received any shipping confirmation. Can you tell me what's going on? I need these for a party on Saturday.

Without AI (Manual — 3-4 minutes to write):

The team member reads, thinks, types, reviews, sends.

With AI (AI-Assisted — 30-60 seconds to review):

AI draft output:

> Hi [Customer Name],
>
> Thank you for your order! I'm sorry you haven't received a shipping confirmation yet — I understand that's frustrating, especially with your party coming up.
>
> Our standard processing time is 1-2 business days, so your order should have shipped by now. Could you share your order number? I'll look into the status right away and make sure we get it to you as fast as possible.
>
> If it turns out we can't meet your Saturday deadline with standard shipping, I'll explore express options for you.
>
> Thanks for your patience — I'll get back to you quickly!
>
> [Team Name]

The team member reads this, maybe adjusts a line, and sends. Done in under a minute.

Expected Results

Metric	Before	After
Time per email	3-5 minutes	30-60 seconds
Emails handled per hour	12-20	40-60
Time spent on email per day (20 emails)	60-100 minutes	10-20 minutes
Weekly time savings	—	3-5+ hours

Response quality	Varies by team member	Consistent tone and accuracy

Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

Pitfall 1: Sending Without Reading

It will happen. Someone will copy the AI draft, hit send, and not notice the AI hallucinated a policy that doesn't exist. Prevention: Make "read before send" a non-negotiable rule. Consider requiring a senior team member to spot-check 10% of AI-drafted replies for the first month.

Pitfall 2: AI Gets Facts Wrong

AI sometimes invents details — wrong shipping times, non-existent product features. Prevention: Your Company Context block should contain all the facts AI needs. If AI still makes things up, add this line to your prompt: "Only include factual claims that are explicitly stated in the company context above."

Pitfall 3: Over-Relying on One Prompt

Using the same generic prompt for every type of email produces mediocre results. Prevention: Build category-specific prompts (Step 6). It takes 30 minutes and dramatically improves output quality.

Pitfall 4: Team Resistance

"I can write faster than editing an AI draft." Some team members will resist. Usually this changes after they see how much time others save. Prevention: Don't mandate it — make it available. The people drowning in email will adopt it immediately. The skeptics will follow.

Pitfall 5: Not Updating Prompts When Policies Change

If you change your return window from 30 to 14 days but don't update your prompts, AI will give customers wrong information. Prevention: Add "Update AI prompts" to your policy change checklist. Assign one person to own the prompt documents.

Scaling Up: From AI-Assisted to Fully Automated

Once you've been running AI-assisted email responses for a month and you're confident in the quality, you might consider moving toward Layer 3:

- Zendesk AI or Freshdesk Freddy can auto-suggest replies within your helpdesk — no copy-pasting needed
- Gmail + Google Gemini can draft replies right in your inbox
- For common categories (shipping status, password reset), you might set up auto-replies that go out without human review — but only for categories where accuracy is consistently 95%+

Don't rush this. AI-assisted with human review already saves most of the time. Full automation adds risk for marginal additional savings.

Quick-Start Checklist

- [ ] List your 20 most common customer email types
- [ ] Collect 5-10 example replies that represent your ideal tone
- [ ] Write your Company Context block
- [ ] Build your general reply prompt
- [ ] Test with 10 real emails
- [ ] Refine the prompt based on results
- [ ] Create 3-5 category-specific prompts
- [ ] Share with your team and demo it live
- [ ] Track time savings for the first week
- [ ] Review and update prompts monthly

Chapter 4

Playbook: FAQ & Knowledge Base Builder

What This Playbook Does

Every company has "tribal knowledge" — the stuff that lives in people's heads, old email threads, and scattered documents. When someone leaves or is on vacation, that knowledge disappears.

This playbook shows you how to use AI to extract that tribal knowledge and turn it into a structured FAQ or knowledge base that your team (and optionally your customers) can search and use. Instead of spending days writing documentation from scratch, you'll use AI to do the heavy lifting while you review and organize.

Estimated implementation time: 4-6 hours (spread across a few days)

Expected time savings: 2-4 hours per week (fewer repeated questions, faster onboarding)

Difficulty: Beginner to Intermediate

Tools You'll Need

Free Options

- ChatGPT or Claude — for transforming raw information into clean FAQ entries
- Google Docs or Notion (free tier) — for hosting and organizing the knowledge base
- A simple spreadsheet — for tracking question categories

Paid Options (for a more polished, searchable experience)

- Notion AI ($10/member/month) — AI-powered search and auto-suggestions within your knowledge base
- Slite (from $8/member/month) — designed for internal knowledge bases with AI search
- Helpjuice (from $120/month) — customer-facing knowledge base with analytics
- Guru (from $15/user/month) — knowledge management with AI-powered answers
-

GitBook (free for personal use, from $8/month for teams) — clean documentation with AI search

Start free. A well-organized Google Doc or Notion page beats an expensive tool with no content.

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Identify Your Knowledge Sources (30 minutes)

Before building anything, figure out where your tribal knowledge currently lives. Common sources:

- People's heads — The most common and most dangerous source. Key employees who "just know" how things work.
- Email threads — Past customer questions and answers that were never documented.
- Slack/Teams messages — Answers buried in chat history.
- Old documents — SOPs, training manuals, product specs that exist but are outdated or hard to find.
- Customer support tickets — Patterns in what customers ask repeatedly.
- Meeting notes — Decisions and explanations from past meetings.

Make a list of your sources. For each one, note:

- What type of knowledge it contains
- How accessible it is (easy to export? need to ask someone?)
- How current it is

Step 2: Collect the Raw Material (1-2 hours)

Now gather the actual content. You don't need to organize it yet — just collect.

For knowledge in people's heads:

Record a 15-20 minute "knowledge dump" conversation with each key person. You can use your phone's voice recorder or a tool like Otter.ai. Ask them:

> Knowledge Dump Interview Questions:

>

1. What are the top 10 questions you get asked by [customers/new employees/teammates]?

> 1. What are the top 10 questions you get asked by [customers/new employees/teammates]?
>
> 2. For each question, what's your standard answer?
>
> 3. What do people get wrong most often?
>
> 4. What's the process for [key workflow]? Walk me through it step by step.
>
> 5. Are there any unwritten rules or "gotchas" that people need to know?
>
> 6. What do you wish someone had told you when you started?

For email/chat/ticket sources:

Export or copy-paste the most relevant conversations. Focus on:

- Questions that come up at least monthly
- Answers that take more than 2 minutes to explain
- Anything where the answer has changed recently

For existing documents:

Gather them in one folder. Don't worry if they're outdated — we'll have AI help identify what needs updating.

Step 3: Use AI to Generate FAQ Entries (1-2 hours)

Now take your raw material and feed it to AI to create structured FAQ entries. This is where the magic happens — AI is exceptionally good at turning messy notes into clean, organized answers.

> FAQ Generation Prompt:

>

> I'm building a knowledge base for my company. Below is raw information from [source — e.g., "an interview with our operations manager" / "customer support emails" / "our old policy documents"].

>

> Please:
>
> 1. Identify all distinct questions that this content answers (or implies)
>
> 2. For each question, write a clear, concise answer (3-7 sentences)
>
> 3. Group related questions into categories
>
> 4. Flag any information that seems contradictory or outdated
>
> 5. Write in plain language that a [new employee / customer — pick one] would understand

>

> Raw content:

> [Paste your raw notes, transcript, or document here]
>
> ---

For large documents that won't fit in one prompt:

> Chunked FAQ Prompt:

>

> I'm building a knowledge base. I'll share content in chunks. For this chunk, extract all FAQ-worthy questions and answers. Format each as:

>

> Q: [Question]
>
> A: [Answer in 3-7 sentences]
>
> Category: [Suggested category]

>

> Content chunk [X of Y]:
>
> ---
>
> [Paste chunk here]
>
> ---

Step 4: Review and Edit the AI Output (1 hour)

AI will produce draft FAQ entries. Now you need to review them for:

Accuracy: Is the information correct? AI might misinterpret something from the raw material.

Completeness: Did it miss any important questions? Add ones you know are frequently asked.

Tone: Does it match how your company communicates? If it's too formal or too casual, adjust.

Currency: Is the information up to date? Mark anything that needs verification.

> FAQ Review Prompt:

>

> Here are draft FAQ entries for my company's knowledge base. Please review them and:

>

> 1. Identify any answers that sound vague or incomplete
>
> 2. Suggest additional questions that are commonly related to these topics

3. Simplify any answers that are longer than necessary

> 3. Simplify any answers that are longer than necessary
> 4. Point out any potential contradictions between entries
>
> [Paste your FAQ entries]

Step 5: Organize into Categories (30 minutes)

Group your FAQ entries into logical categories. Common structures:

For an internal knowledge base (employee-facing):

- Getting Started / Onboarding
- Products & Services
- Policies & Procedures
- Tools & Systems
- Customer Handling
- Troubleshooting

For a customer-facing FAQ:

- Orders & Shipping
- Returns & Refunds
- Product Information
- Account & Billing
- Technical Support
- General Questions

Create your structure first, then slot each FAQ entry into the right category. If an entry fits multiple categories, put it in the most intuitive one and add a cross-reference.

Step 6: Build the Knowledge Base (30-60 minutes)

Now put it all together in your chosen tool.

If using Google Docs (simplest):

- Create one document per category
- Use headings for each question (makes them searchable with Ctrl+F)
- Add a "Table of Contents" document that links to each category
- Share with your team via a shared drive

If using Notion (recommended for growing teams):

- Create a "Knowledge Base" page
- Use Notion's toggle blocks for Q&A format (question as toggle header, answer inside)
- Use Notion's database feature if you want to tag entries and filter by category
- Enable Notion AI search so team members can ask questions in natural language

If using a dedicated tool (Slite, Helpjuice, etc.):

- Follow the tool's setup wizard
- Import your organized content
- Configure search and navigation
- Set up access permissions

Step 7: Fill Gaps with AI (30 minutes)

Look at your knowledge base and identify gaps. Use AI to help draft entries for missing topics:

> Gap-Filling Prompt:

>

> My company's knowledge base covers these categories: [list categories]

>

> For the category "[category name]", we currently have answers for:
>
> [List existing questions]

>

> What other questions would [employees / customers] commonly have in this category? For each suggested question, write a clear answer based on this context about our company:

>

> [Brief company description and relevant policies]

Step 8: Set Up a Maintenance Routine (15 minutes)

A knowledge base that isn't updated becomes dangerous — people trust outdated information. Set up a simple maintenance process:

1. Assign an owner — one person responsible for the knowledge base (even if others contribute)
2. Monthly review — spend 30 minutes each month checking for outdated entries
3. Feedback channel — create a simple way for people to flag incorrect or missing

information (a Slack channel, an email alias, or a form)

4. Update trigger — whenever a policy, process, or product changes, update the knowledge base as part of the change process

> Monthly Review Prompt:
>
> Here are our current knowledge base entries for [category]. Our company has recently [describe any changes — new policies, products, tools, etc.].
>
> Please review these entries and:
>
> 1. Flag any that might be outdated based on the changes described
> 2. Suggest updates to affected entries
> 3. Identify any new questions that should be added given the changes
>
> Current entries:
>
> [Paste entries]

Example: Before and After

Before (Tribal Knowledge Scattered):

- New employee asks "What's our return policy?" — has to find someone who knows
- Customer emails asking about bulk orders — gets forwarded between 3 people before someone answers
- Operations manager goes on vacation — nobody knows the supplier reorder process
- Same questions get asked and answered weekly in Slack

After (AI-Built Knowledge Base):

- New employee searches the knowledge base → finds the answer in 30 seconds
- Customer-facing FAQ handles 60% of common questions before they become emails
- Supplier process is documented step-by-step → anyone can follow it
- Slack question → "Check the knowledge base" → answer found → 2 minutes instead of 20

Expected Results

Metric	Before	After
Time to answer a common internal question	5-15 minutes (find the right person, ask, wait)	1-2 minutes (search the knowledge base)
New employee onboarding time	Days of shadowing and asking questions	Hours of reading + targeted questions only
Repeated questions in Slack/email per week	10-20	2-5 (for things not yet documented)
Risk of knowledge loss when someone leaves	High	Low
Weekly time savings	—	2-4 hours across the team

Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

Pitfall 1: Building It and Not Telling Anyone

The best knowledge base is useless if people don't know it exists. Prevention: Announce it. Demo it in a team meeting. Pin the link in Slack. Make it the first thing new employees see. When someone asks a question that's in the KB, reply with the link.

Pitfall 2: Trying to Document Everything at Once

You don't need 200 entries on day one. Prevention: Start with your top 20-30 questions. Add more over time as gaps become obvious.

Pitfall 3: AI-Generated Content That Nobody Verified

AI drafts are good starting points, but they might contain inaccuracies. Prevention: Have the subject matter expert review every entry before it goes live. Mark unverified entries clearly.

Pitfall 4: The Knowledge Base Gets Stale

Within 3 months, some information will be outdated. Prevention: Monthly review routine (Step 8). Consider adding a "Last verified" date to each entry.

Pitfall 5: Making It Too Formal or Complex

If the language is too corporate or the structure too complex, people won't use it. Prevention: Write like you talk. Use the same terminology your team uses. Keep answers short and scannable.

Scaling Up: AI-Powered Search and Chatbot

Once your knowledge base has 50+ entries and is being actively used, consider these upgrades:

- Notion AI — lets team members type questions in natural language and get answers from your KB content
- Custom ChatGPT GPT — upload your KB as a file and create a custom GPT that answers questions based solely on your documentation
- Intercom or Zendesk AI — customer-facing chatbot that answers questions from your KB before routing to a human

> Custom GPT Setup Prompt:

>

> You are a knowledge base assistant for [Company Name]. Answer questions using ONLY the information in the uploaded document. If the answer isn't in the document, say "I don't have that information in our knowledge base — please contact [person/team] at [email]."

>

> Be concise. Quote relevant sections when helpful. If a question is ambiguous, ask for clarification.

Quick-Start Checklist

- [ ] List all sources of tribal knowledge in your company
- [ ] Schedule 2-3 "knowledge dump" interviews with key people
- [ ] Collect raw material (transcripts, emails, documents)
- [ ] Use AI to generate draft FAQ entries
- [ ] Review and verify all entries for accuracy
- [ ] Organize into categories
- [ ] Build the knowledge base in your chosen tool
- [ ] Fill gaps with AI-assisted drafting
- [ ] Share with your team and demonstrate how to use it
- [ ] Set up a monthly review routine
- [ ] Track reduction in repeated questions

Chapter 5

Playbook: Lead Qualification & Scoring

What This Playbook Does

Every business gets leads — inquiries, form submissions, cold emails, social media messages. The problem isn't getting leads; it's knowing which ones deserve your time right now and which can wait.

Most small businesses treat every lead equally: whoever emailed first gets called first. This means your sales team spends as much time on a "just browsing" inquiry as on a "ready to buy" hot lead.

This playbook shows you how to use AI to score and qualify leads automatically, so your team focuses on the ones most likely to convert. AI reads the lead's information, compares it to your ideal customer profile, and gives you a priority score — all in seconds.

Estimated implementation time: 3-5 hours

Expected time savings: 3-6 hours per week (less time on bad leads, faster response to good ones)

Difficulty: Intermediate

Tools You'll Need

Free Options

- ChatGPT or Claude — for analyzing leads and assigning scores based on your criteria
- A spreadsheet (Google Sheets or Excel) — for tracking leads and scores
- Your existing lead sources — contact forms, email, social media DMs

Paid Options (for automation and CRM integration)

- HubSpot CRM (free CRM + paid AI features from $20/month) — built-in lead scoring with AI
- Pipedrive (from $14/seat/month) — CRM with AI-powered lead scoring
- Apollo.io (free tier available) — lead enrichment + scoring
-

Clay (from $149/month) — AI-powered lead research and enrichment
- Zapier ($20/month) — connect your lead sources to AI scoring automatically

Start free. Even a manual ChatGPT-based scoring process will save significant time if you're currently scoring leads in your head.

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Define Your Ideal Customer Profile (30 minutes)

Before AI can score leads, you need to tell it what a good lead looks like. Answer these questions:

Company characteristics (for B2B):

- What industry/industries do your best customers come from?
- What company size (employees or revenue) is your sweet spot?
- What geography do you serve?
- Are there any disqualifying factors? (too small, wrong industry, etc.)

Individual characteristics (for B2B or B2C):

- What role/title does your buyer typically have?
- What's their typical budget range?
- What pain point drives them to you?

Behavioral signals:

- How do good leads typically find you? (referral, search, social media)
- What do they usually say in their first message?
- What actions indicate high intent? (requesting a demo, asking about pricing, mentioning a timeline)

Write this up as your Ideal Customer Profile (ICP). Here's a template:

> Ideal Customer Profile Template:

>

> Our best customers are typically:
>
> - Industry: [e.g., professional services, e-commerce, manufacturing]

- Company size: [e.g., 10-100 employees, €500K-€5M revenue]

- Company size: [e.g., 10-100 employees, €500K-€5M revenue]

> - Location: [e.g., Benelux region, EU, global]
> - Decision maker: [e.g., owner, operations manager, IT director]
> - Budget: [e.g., €5K-€50K per project]
> - Key pain point: [e.g., spending too much time on manual processes]

>

> High-intent signals:
> - Mentions a specific timeline or deadline
> - Asks about pricing or implementation
> - References a competitor or existing solution they want to replace
> - Was referred by an existing customer
> - Visited our pricing page (if trackable)

>

> Disqualifiers:
> - [e.g., looking for free solutions only]
> - [e.g., outside our service area]
> - [e.g., company too small to afford our minimum engagement]

Step 2: Create Your Scoring Criteria (30 minutes)

Turn your ICP into a scoring rubric. Each lead will be scored on multiple factors that add up to a total score.

Suggested scoring model (out of 100 points):

Factor	Points	How to Score
Industry fit	0-20	20 = perfect fit, 10 = adjacent, 0 = no fit
Company size	0-15	15 = sweet spot, 10 = workable, 0 = too small/larg
Decision-maker level	0-15	15 = owner/C-level, 10 = manager, 5 = individual c
Budget indicators	0-15	15 = mentions budget in range, 10 = no budget me
Intent signals	0-20	20 = asks about pricing/timeline, 10 = general inq
Source quality	0-15	15 = referral, 10 = organic search, 5 = social med

Score interpretation:

- 80-100: Hot lead — respond within 1 hour
- 60-79: Warm lead — respond within 24 hours
-

40-59: Cool lead — add to nurture sequence, respond within 48 hours
- 0-39: Cold lead — add to mailing list, don't prioritize

Customize these factors for your business. The specific numbers matter less than having a consistent framework.

Step 3: Build Your Lead Scoring Prompt (30 minutes)

This is the prompt you'll use to score each lead:

> Lead Scoring Prompt:
>
> You are a lead qualification assistant for [Company Name]. We are a [brief description].
>
> Our Ideal Customer Profile:
>
> [Paste your ICP from Step 1]
>
> Scoring criteria (total 100 points):
>
> - Industry fit (0-20)
>
> - Company size (0-15)
>
> - Decision-maker level (0-15)
>
> - Budget indicators (0-15)
>
> - Intent signals (0-20)
>
> - Source quality (0-15)
>
> Score interpretation:
>
> - 80-100: Hot — respond within 1 hour
>
> - 60-79: Warm — respond within 24 hours
>
> - 40-59: Cool — nurture sequence
>
> - 0-39: Cold — mailing list only
>
> Here is the lead information:
>
> ---
>
> [Paste all available lead info: name, company, email, form submission, initial message, source]
>
> ---

>

> Please provide:
>
> 1. Score for each criterion with a brief justification
> 2. Total score and category (Hot/Warm/Cool/Cold)
> 3. Key missing information we should try to gather
> 4. Suggested first response approach (what to say, what to ask)
> 5. Any red flags or concerns

Step 4: Enrich Leads Before Scoring (Optional — 15 minutes setup)

You can improve scoring accuracy by giving AI more context about each lead. Before scoring, do a quick research step:

> Lead Enrichment Prompt:

>

> I received a lead from: [Name], [Company], [Email]

>

> Based on their email domain and any available public information, please provide:
>
> 1. Company description and industry
> 2. Approximate company size (if findable)
> 3. The person's likely role/seniority
> 4. Any recent news about the company
> 5. How this maps to our ideal customer profile: [brief ICP summary]

>

> Note: Only include information you're confident about. If you can't find information, say so rather than guessing.

Important: This works best with paid AI tools that have web access (ChatGPT Plus with browsing, or Claude Pro). With free tools, AI will work from the information you provide plus general knowledge about well-known companies.

Step 5: Process Your First Batch (1-2 hours)

Take your last 20 leads and score them using your prompt. For each lead:

1. Gather all available information (name, company, email, form data, initial message)
2. Optionally run the enrichment prompt

3. Run the scoring prompt
4. Record the score in your spreadsheet

Spreadsheet columns:

- Date received
- Name
- Company
- Source
- AI Score (0-100)
- Category (Hot/Warm/Cool/Cold)
- Key notes from AI
- Status (New/Contacted/Meeting/Won/Lost)

Step 6: Validate Against Reality (30 minutes)

Compare AI scores against what actually happened with those leads:

- Did the "Hot" leads actually convert at a higher rate?
- Were there any "Cold" leads that turned out to be great customers?
- Did the scoring miss any important signals?

Use the results to refine your scoring criteria. This is crucial — your first scoring model won't be perfect, and that's fine. Adjust weights and factors based on real outcomes.

> Scoring Refinement Prompt:
>
> I've been using an AI lead scoring system for my business. Here are the results from our last 20 leads:
>
> [Paste a summary: lead, AI score, actual outcome]
>
> Based on these results:
>
> 1. Which scoring factors seem most predictive of actual conversion?
> 2. Which factors seem least useful?
> 3. Are there patterns in the misscored leads that suggest a new factor we should add?
> 4. Suggest an updated scoring rubric with adjusted weights.

Step 7: Create a Batch Scoring Workflow (30 minutes)

Once your scoring model is refined, set up a daily or twice-daily routine:

Daily lead scoring routine (15 minutes):

1. Open your lead inbox (email, CRM, form submissions)
2. Copy all new lead information
3. Paste into AI with your scoring prompt
4. Record scores in your spreadsheet
5. Hot leads → respond immediately
6. Warm leads → schedule follow-up today
7. Cool leads → add to nurture sequence
8. Cold leads → add to mailing list

For batch processing multiple leads at once:

> Batch Scoring Prompt:
>
> Score each of the following leads using our criteria. For each lead, provide: Total Score, Category (Hot/Warm/Cool/Cold), Top 2 reasons for the score, and Suggested next action.
>
> [Paste your ICP and scoring criteria]
>
> Lead 1:
>
> [Info]
>
> Lead 2:
>
> [Info]
>
> Lead 3:
>
> [Info]
>
> Format the output as a table for easy scanning.

Example: Before and After

Before (No Scoring):

Monday morning. 12 new leads from the weekend. Sales rep starts at the top of the inbox and works down. Spends 20 minutes researching and calling a lead that turns out to be a student doing research. Meanwhile, a hot lead from a perfect-fit company waits 3 days for a response and signs with a competitor.

After (AI-Scored):

Monday morning. 12 new leads scored in 10 minutes. Three are Hot (80+): a referral from an existing customer, a company in the sweet spot asking about pricing, and an ops manager mentioning a Q2 deadline. Sales rep calls those three first. The student inquiry scores 15 and goes to the mailing list automatically. Hot leads get a response within an hour.

Expected Results

Metric	Before	After
Time to qualify a lead	5-15 minutes	1-2 minutes
Response time for hot leads	1-3 days	Under 2 hours
Time spent on unqualified leads per week	3-5 hours	Under 1 hour
Conversion rate (leads → customers)	Baseline	+20-40% improvement
Weekly time savings	—	3-6 hours

Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

Pitfall 1: Scoring Based on Gut Instead of Data

AI is only as good as your criteria. If your ICP is based on assumptions rather than actual customer data, your scores will be off. Prevention: Look at your last 20 customers. What do they have in common? Build your ICP from reality, not theory.

Pitfall 2: Treating AI Scores as Gospel

A lead with a score of 35 might still become your biggest customer. Scores are guides, not guarantees. Prevention: Always respond to every lead (even cold ones get a polite acknowledgment). Scores

determine priority and speed of response, not whether to respond.

Pitfall 3: Never Updating the Model

Your business evolves. Your ideal customer changes. Your scoring model should too. Prevention: Review scores vs. outcomes quarterly. Adjust criteria and weights based on what's actually converting.

Pitfall 4: Over-Complicating the Score

Some businesses create scoring systems with 20+ factors. This makes the scores harder to understand and harder to act on. Prevention: Start with 5-6 factors. Only add more if you find clear signals you're missing.

Pitfall 5: Scoring Without Acting

Scoring leads is useless if you don't change your behavior based on the scores. Prevention: Define clear actions for each category (Hot = call within 1 hour, Warm = email within 24 hours, etc.) and hold your team to them.

Scaling Up: CRM Integration and Automation

Once manual AI scoring is working, consider these upgrades:

- HubSpot + AI scoring — automatic lead scoring within your CRM, integrated with your pipeline
- Zapier workflow — new form submission → AI scoring via API → score logged in CRM → notification sent to sales rep for hot leads
- Apollo.io or Clay — automatic enrichment + scoring on inbound leads

> Zapier Workflow Example:

>

> Trigger: New form submission (Typeform, Google Forms, etc.)
>
> Step 1: Send lead info to ChatGPT API with your scoring prompt
>
> Step 2: Parse the score from ChatGPT's response
>
> Step 3: Create/update contact in HubSpot with the score
>
> Step 4: If score ≥ 80, send Slack notification to sales channel
>
> Step 5: If score < 40, add to "nurture" email sequence

Quick-Start Checklist

- [ ] Define your Ideal Customer Profile based on actual past customers
- [ ] Create a scoring rubric with 5-6 factors (100-point scale)
- [ ] Build your lead scoring prompt
- [ ] Test with your last 20 leads
- [ ] Compare AI scores with actual outcomes
- [ ] Refine the scoring model based on results
- [ ] Set up a daily scoring routine (15 minutes/day)
- [ ] Define response actions for each score category
- [ ] Train your team on the new prioritization system
- [ ] Review and adjust scores quarterly

Chapter 6

Playbook: Meeting Notes & Action Items

What This Playbook Does

You finish a meeting. Everyone agrees on next steps. Then... nothing happens. Three days later, someone asks "Wait, who was supposed to do that?" Sound familiar?

This playbook shows you how to use AI to automatically transcribe meetings, generate clear summaries, and extract specific action items with owners and deadlines. Instead of someone furiously taking notes (and missing half the conversation), AI handles the documentation so your team can focus on the actual discussion.

Estimated implementation time: 2-3 hours

Expected time savings: 2-4 hours per week (plus fewer dropped action items)

Difficulty: Beginner

Tools You'll Need

Free Options

- Otter.ai (free tier — 300 minutes/month) — records and transcribes meetings, works with Zoom/Teams/Meet
- Google Docs voice typing — basic transcription for in-person meetings
- ChatGPT or Claude — for summarizing transcripts and extracting action items
- Phone voice recorder — as a backup for in-person meetings

Paid Options (for better accuracy and integration)

- Otter.ai Pro ($17/month) — more minutes, better accuracy, auto-join virtual meetings
- Fireflies.ai (from $18/month) — transcription + AI summary + CRM integration
- Granola (free tier available) — AI meeting notepad, works alongside your meeting app
-

Read.ai (from $20/month) — transcription, summaries, meeting analytics
- Microsoft Copilot (included in Microsoft 365 Copilot, $30/user/month) — transcription and notes built into Teams
- tl;dv (free tier available) — records Google Meet/Zoom calls, AI summaries

Recommendation: Start with Otter.ai free tier or tl;dv. Both auto-join virtual meetings and provide transcripts you can then process with ChatGPT/Claude.

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Choose Your Recording Method (15 minutes)

For virtual meetings (Zoom, Teams, Google Meet):

- Sign up for Otter.ai, Fireflies.ai, or tl;dv
- Connect it to your calendar
- The tool will auto-join meetings as a "participant" and record/transcribe
- Make sure to inform attendees about the recording (legal requirement in most places)

For in-person meetings:

- Use your phone's voice recorder app
- Place the phone in the center of the table
- After the meeting, upload the audio file to Otter.ai for transcription or use the manual transcript method below

For hybrid meetings:

- Use the virtual meeting tool's built-in recording plus Otter.ai/Fireflies for transcription

Step 2: Create Your Meeting Summary Prompt (20 minutes)

After getting a transcript (either from your transcription tool or by hand), use this prompt to generate a structured summary:

> Meeting Summary Prompt:

>

> Below is a transcript from a meeting. Please create a structured meeting summary with these

sections:

>

> 1. Meeting Overview
>
> - Date: [date]
> - Attendees: [list everyone who spoke]
> - Duration: approximately [X] minutes
> - Purpose: [one-sentence summary of why the meeting happened]

>

> 2. Key Discussion Points
>
> - Summarize each major topic discussed in 2-3 sentences
> - Note any decisions that were made
> - Note any disagreements or open questions

>

> 3. Action Items
>
> For each action item, provide:
>
> - [ ] Task: [specific task description]
> - Owner: [person responsible]
> - Deadline: [date or timeframe mentioned — if none mentioned, write "TBD"]
> - Context: [one sentence on why this matters]

>

> 4. Decisions Made
>
> - List each decision clearly, including who made it

>

> 5. Open Questions / Parking Lot
>
> - List any unresolved topics that need follow-up

>

> 6. Next Meeting
>
> - Date/time if scheduled, or note "to be scheduled"
> - Agenda items for next meeting if mentioned

>

> Transcript:
>
> ---
>
> [Paste the transcript here]
>
> ---

Step 3: Handle Meetings Without a Transcript (Alternative)

If you can't record a meeting (sensitive topic, client preference, or technical issues), you can still use AI with manual notes:

> Notes-to-Summary Prompt:
>
> I just attended a meeting and took rough notes. Please organize these into a structured meeting summary with clear action items.
>
> Meeting context: [What was the meeting about? Who attended?]
>
> My rough notes:
>
> ---
>
> [Paste your shorthand notes here — bullet points, fragments, whatever you jotted down]
>
> ---
>
> Please:
>
> 1. Create a clean summary organized by topic
> 2. Extract all action items with owners (based on the names mentioned)
> 3. List any decisions that were made
> 4. Identify anything that seems unresolved
> 5. Fill in any obvious gaps if the notes are incomplete (mark these as "[inferred]")

Step 4: Set Up Your Distribution Workflow (30 minutes)

A meeting summary is only useful if people see it. Set up a consistent process:

Option A — Email (simplest):

After each meeting, email the summary to all attendees within 1 hour.

Option B — Shared workspace:

Post summaries to a dedicated Notion page, Google Drive folder, or Slack channel.

Option C — Project management integration:

Copy action items directly into your project management tool (Asana, Trello, Monday.com, etc.) as tasks

assigned to the right people.

> Action Items Extraction Prompt (for project management tools):

>

> From this meeting summary, extract just the action items in this format:

>

> Task: [specific task]
>
> Assignee: [person]
>
> Due: [date or "TBD"]
>
> Priority: [High/Medium/Low based on the discussion context]

>

> [Paste the meeting summary]

Step 5: Test with Three Real Meetings (1-2 hours total)

Run the system for your next three meetings:

1. Record/transcribe the meeting
2. Run the transcript through your summary prompt
3. Review the AI summary for accuracy
4. Send to attendees and ask: "Does this capture everything? Any corrections?"
5. Note what AI got right, what it missed, and what it got wrong

Common feedback to expect:

- "It missed the discussion about X" → the transcript might have been unclear; refine prompts
- "The action item should be assigned to Y, not Z" → AI sometimes mixes up who volunteered for what
- "The tone is too formal" → add "Write in a casual, direct tone" to your prompt
- "The summary is too long" → add "Keep each section concise. Total summary should be under 500 words."

Step 6: Refine Based on Feedback (20 minutes)

Common refinements:

If summaries are too long:

Add: "Keep the summary concise. Key discussion points should be 1-2 sentences each. Total summary

should fit on one page."

Add: "Keep the summary concise. Key discussion points should be 1-2 sentences each. Total summary

should fit on one page."

If action items are vague:

> Add: "Each action item must be specific enough that the owner knows exactly what to do without re-reading the transcript. Bad: 'Follow up on proposal.' Good: 'Send revised pricing proposal to ABC Corp including the 15% volume discount discussed.'"

If AI misattributes actions:

> Add: "When extracting action items, only assign ownership when someone explicitly volunteered or was asked to do it. If ownership is unclear, mark the owner as 'TBD — needs clarification.'"

If decisions aren't captured well:

> Add: "For each decision, include: what was decided, who made the call, and the reasoning if it was discussed."

Step 7: Build the Habit (Ongoing)

The hardest part isn't the technology — it's making it a consistent practice. Here's how:

1. Make recording automatic — set Otter.ai/Fireflies to auto-join all calendar events
2. Assign the "note sender" role — one person per meeting runs the transcript through AI and sends the summary
3. Set a time rule — summaries must be sent within 2 hours of meeting end
4. Start meetings with a reminder — "This meeting will be recorded and AI-summarized. Action items will be sent to everyone afterward."
5. End meetings with a check — "Let's quickly confirm: who's doing what by when?" This gives AI cleaner data to work with.

Example: Before and After

Before (Manual Notes):

45-minute team meeting. Project manager tries to take notes while participating. Misses a key discussion while writing. After the meeting, spends 20 minutes cleaning up notes. Emails them the next day (because they ran out of time). Two of four action items are vague. By the following week, one item was forgotten entirely.

After (AI-Assisted):

Same 45-minute meeting. Otter.ai records and transcribes automatically. Project manager fully participates in the discussion. After the meeting, they paste the transcript into Claude (2 minutes). Review the AI summary (3 minutes). Send to all attendees with action items clearly listed (1 minute). Total post-meeting time: 6 minutes instead of 20+. All four action items are specific with owners and deadlines.

Expected Results

Metric	Before	After
Time spent on meeting notes	15-30 min per meeting	5-8 min per meeting
Time until notes are distributed	Same day to next day	Within 1-2 hours
Action items captured	60-70% (human note-taker misses some)	90-95% (transcript captures everything)
Action items completed on time	~50%	~80% (clear owners and deadlines help)
Weekly time savings (5 meetings/week)	—	2-4 hours

Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

Pitfall 1: Forgetting to Inform Attendees About Recording

Recording without consent can be illegal and will definitely damage trust. Prevention: Always announce at the start: "This meeting is being recorded for note-taking purposes." Add it to your meeting invite template.

Pitfall 2: Transcription Errors Causing Wrong Action Items

Transcription tools sometimes mishear words, especially names, technical terms, or accented speech. Prevention: Always review the AI summary before distributing. Correct any misheard names or terms.

Pitfall 3: Death by Documentation

Not every meeting needs full documentation. A casual 5-minute check-in doesn't need a structured summary. Prevention: Only apply the full process to substantive meetings (30+ minutes, multiple participants, decisions being made).

Pitfall 4: Action Items Without Follow-Up

Extracting action items is step one. Following up on them is where the real value is. Prevention: Start your next meeting by reviewing last meeting's action items. Or set up a weekly action item review.

Pitfall 5: Sensitive Meeting Content in AI Tools

If you're discussing confidential information (HR issues, legal matters, financials), think twice before sending the transcript to a cloud AI tool. Prevention: For sensitive meetings, use the manual notes approach (Step 3) and only share non-sensitive details with AI.

Advanced: Recurring Meeting Templates

For meetings that happen weekly with a similar structure, create a specialized prompt:

> Weekly Team Meeting Summary Prompt:
>
> This is our weekly team meeting (held every [day]). Please summarize using our standard format:
>
> Status Updates: What did each person report on?
>
> Blockers: What obstacles were raised?
>
> Decisions: What was decided?
>
> Action Items: Who committed to what, by when?
>
> Metrics Mentioned: Any numbers or KPIs discussed?
>
> Kudos: Any wins or recognition mentioned?
>
> Transcript:
>
> [Paste here]

Quick-Start Checklist

- [ ] Sign up for a transcription tool (Otter.ai, tl;dv, or Fireflies.ai)
-

[ ] Connect to your calendar for auto-join

- [ ] Create your meeting summary prompt
- [ ] Inform your team about the new recording + summary process
- [ ] Test with your next 3 meetings
- [ ] Gather feedback from attendees
- [ ] Refine the prompt based on feedback
- [ ] Set up your distribution workflow (email, Slack, Notion, etc.)
- [ ] Create the "action item review" habit in your next meetings
- [ ] Track time savings and action item completion rates

Chapter 7

Playbook: Document Processing Pipeline

What This Playbook Does

Invoices. Receipts. Contracts. Purchase orders. Every business drowns in documents that need to be read, understood, and entered somewhere else — a spreadsheet, an accounting tool, a CRM, a filing system.

This playbook shows you how to use AI to extract structured data from unstructured documents. Instead of manually reading each invoice and typing numbers into a spreadsheet, you'll photograph or upload the document, let AI extract the key information, and review the results. What takes 5-10 minutes per document manually takes 30-60 seconds with AI.

Estimated implementation time: 3-5 hours

Expected time savings: 3-8 hours per week (depending on document volume)

Difficulty: Intermediate

Tools You'll Need

Free Options

- ChatGPT Plus with image upload ($20/month — technically paid, but the most accessible option for document processing)
- Claude with file upload (free tier handles PDFs and images)
- Google Docs — for OCR (upload an image of a document; Google converts it to editable text)
- A phone camera — to photograph physical documents

Paid Options (for higher volume and automation)

- Nanonets (from $49/month) — AI document processing, extracts data from invoices/receipts automatically
-

Rossum (custom pricing) — enterprise-level AI document extraction
- Dext (formerly Receipt Bank) (from $24/month) — receipt and invoice scanning for accounting
- Mindee (free tier available) — API-based document parsing
- Microsoft Power Automate + AI Builder (included in some Microsoft 365 plans) — document processing workflows

Recommended starting point: ChatGPT Plus or Claude with file/image upload. You can process most document types by simply uploading a photo or PDF.

Step-by-Step Setup

Step 1: Identify Your Document Types (20 minutes)

List every type of document your business processes regularly:

Document Type	Volume per Week	Who Processes It	Where Does Data Go
Supplier invoices	~15	Office manager	Accounting software
Expense receipts	~20	Various staff	Expense spreadsheet
Customer contracts	~3	Sales team	CRM
Purchase orders	~8	Operations	Inventory system
Delivery notes	~10	Warehouse	Spreadsheet

Focus on the document types with the highest volume first — that's where you'll save the most time.

Step 2: Define What Data You Need to Extract (20 minutes)

For each document type, list exactly what information you need. Be specific:

For invoices:

- Supplier name
- Invoice number
- Invoice date
- Due date
- Line items (description, quantity, unit price, total)
- Subtotal, tax amount, total
-

Payment details (bank account, reference)
- Currency

For receipts:

- Vendor name
- Date
- Items purchased (description and price)
- Total amount
- Payment method
- Tax amount
- Category (office supplies, travel, meals, etc.)

For contracts:

- Parties involved
- Effective date and end date
- Key terms and obligations
- Payment terms
- Termination clauses
- Renewal terms
- Notable restrictions or conditions

Step 3: Create Your Extraction Prompts (30 minutes)

Build a prompt for each document type. Here's the key: tell AI exactly what format you want the output in, so you can paste it directly into your spreadsheet or system.

> Invoice Extraction Prompt:

>

> I'm uploading an invoice. Please extract the following information and format it exactly as shown:

>

> `
>
> Supplier: [company name]
>
> Invoice Number: [number]
>
> Invoice Date: [DD/MM/YYYY]
>
> Due Date: [DD/MM/YYYY]
>
> Currency: [EUR/USD/GBP etc.]

>

> Line Items:
>
> 1. [Description] | Qty: [X] | Unit Price: [X.XX] | Total: [X.XX]
>
> 2. [Description] | Qty: [X] | Unit Price: [X.XX] | Total: [X.XX]
>
> [continue for all items]

>

> Subtotal: [X.XX]
>
> Tax ([X]%): [X.XX]
>
> Total: [X.XX]

>

> Payment Details:
>
> Bank: [name]
>
> Account/IBAN: [number]
>
> Reference: [payment reference]
>
> `

>

> Rules:
>
> - If a field is not visible on the invoice, write "NOT FOUND"
>
> - Use the date format DD/MM/YYYY
>
> - Include the currency symbol with all amounts
>
> - If there are multiple tax rates, list each separately
>
> - Double-check that line item totals add up to the subtotal

> Receipt Extraction Prompt:

>

> I'm uploading a receipt or expense document. Please extract:

>

> `
>
> Vendor: [name]
>
> Date: [DD/MM/YYYY]
>
> Category: [suggest one: Office Supplies / Travel / Meals & Entertainment / Software / Equipment / Marketing / Other]

>

> Items:

1. [Description] — [amount]

1. [Description] — [amount]

> 2. [Description] — [amount]

>

> Subtotal: [X.XX]
>
> Tax: [X.XX]
>
> Total: [X.XX]
>
> Payment Method: [Cash/Card/Bank Transfer — if visible]
>
> `

>

> If the receipt is partially unreadable, extract what you can and mark unclear items as "[UNCLEAR]".

> Contract Review Prompt:

>

> I'm uploading a contract. Please provide a structured summary:

>

> `
>
> PARTIES:
>
> Party A: [name and role]
>
> Party B: [name and role]

>

> KEY DATES:
>
> Effective Date: [date]
>
> End Date: [date]
>
> Renewal: [auto-renew / manual / N/A — with terms]

>

> FINANCIAL TERMS:
>
> Total Value: [amount]
>
> Payment Schedule: [terms]
>
> Late Payment: [penalties if mentioned]

>

> KEY OBLIGATIONS:
>
> Party A must: [list]
>
> Party B must: [list]

>

TERMINATION:

TERMINATION:

> Notice Period: [X days/months]
>
> Termination Conditions: [list]
>
> Early Termination Penalties: [if any]

>

> RED FLAGS / NOTABLE CLAUSES:
>
> - [List anything unusual, one-sided, or that needs attention]

>

> MISSING / UNCLEAR:
>
> - [List any expected clauses that are missing or ambiguous]
>
> `

>

> Important: You are helping me understand this contract. This is NOT legal advice. Flag anything significant, but remind me to consult a lawyer for anything I plan to act on.

Step 4: Process Your First Batch (1-2 hours)

Take 10 documents and process them through your prompts:

For photos/scans:

1. Take a clear photo of the document (good lighting, no shadows, all text visible)
2. Upload to ChatGPT or Claude
3. Paste your extraction prompt
4. Review the output
5. Copy data to your spreadsheet/system

For PDF documents:

1. Upload the PDF directly to ChatGPT or Claude
2. Paste your extraction prompt
3. Review and transfer

For each document, track:

- Processing time (AI extraction + your review)
- Accuracy (did it get the numbers right?)
- Issues (what did it miss or get wrong?)

Step 5: Create a Spreadsheet-Ready Output Format (30 minutes)

If you're entering data into a spreadsheet, have AI output in a format you can paste directly:

> Spreadsheet-Ready Invoice Prompt:
>
> I'm uploading an invoice. Extract the data and format it as a single tab-separated row that I can paste into a spreadsheet with these columns:
>
> Date | Supplier | Invoice# | Description | Subtotal | Tax | Total | Due Date | Status
>
> Use tab characters between fields. Date format: DD/MM/YYYY. Use "Unpaid" for status.
>
> If there are multiple line items, create one row per line item with the invoice details repeated.

This lets you literally copy the AI output and paste it into your spreadsheet — no manual data entry at all.

Step 6: Build Your Processing Routine (20 minutes)

Set up a regular cadence for document processing:

Daily routine (for high-volume businesses):

- Collect all documents received today (email attachments, physical mail scanned, receipts from team)
- Process in a batch: upload all to AI, extract data, review
- Enter into your systems
- File the originals (digital or physical)

Weekly routine (for lower volume):

- Designate one time per week for document processing (e.g., Friday afternoon)
- Process the week's accumulated documents in one batch
- Enter data and file

The physical document workflow:

1. Receive document
2. Photograph or scan immediately (don't let them pile up)
3. Drop into a "To Process" folder (Google Drive, Dropbox, or physical inbox)

4. During processing time, run through AI extraction
5. Move to "Processed" folder after data entry

Step 7: Verify and Build Confidence (Ongoing)

For the first month, verify every AI extraction against the source document. Track accuracy:

- Invoice amounts: Does the AI total match the actual total?
- Dates: Are dates correctly extracted (watch for US vs. EU date formats)?
- Names: Are company names spelled correctly?
- Line items: Are all items captured?

Most users find AI achieves 90-95% accuracy on clean, clear documents. The remaining 5-10% usually involves:

- Handwritten text
- Poor image quality
- Unusual document layouts
- Multiple languages on one document

After a month of verification, you'll know which document types AI handles well (reduce your review time) and which need more careful checking.

Example: Before and After

Before (Manual Processing):

Office manager receives 15 supplier invoices per week by email. Opens each PDF, reads the details, types them into accounting software. Each invoice takes 5-8 minutes. Total: ~2 hours per week. Often makes typos that cause reconciliation issues later.

After (AI-Assisted Processing):

Office manager downloads all 15 PDFs. Uploads them to ChatGPT one by one with the extraction prompt. Reviews each extraction (30-60 seconds per invoice — just checking the numbers match). Copies the formatted data into accounting software. Total: ~30-40 minutes per week. Fewer data entry errors.

Expected Results

Metric	Before	After
Time per invoice/receipt	5-8 minutes	1-2 minutes
Time per contract review	30-60 minutes	10-15 minutes
Data entry errors	2-5%	Under 1%
Weekly time savings (15 invoices + 20 receipts)	—	3-5 hours
Document processing backlog	Growing	Cleared weekly

Common Pitfalls and How to Avoid Them

Pitfall 1: Poor Image Quality Ruins Extraction

A blurry, dark, or partially cut-off photo will produce garbage output. Prevention: Take photos in good lighting, straight-on (not at an angle), with all text visible. For important documents, use a scanner app like Adobe Scan or Microsoft Lens — these auto-correct perspective and enhance contrast.

Pitfall 2: Trusting Numbers Without Verification

AI is good at reading documents, but it's not infallible. A misread "8" as "3" on an invoice could cost you money. Prevention: Always verify totals for the first month. After that, spot-check 20% of documents. For high-value documents (over €1,000), always verify.

Pitfall 3: Using AI for Legally Sensitive Documents Without Professional Review

AI can summarize contracts and flag unusual clauses, but it's not a lawyer. Prevention: Use AI to create a first-pass summary that saves time, but have a real lawyer review anything you plan to sign. Add a note to your contract prompt: "This is for understanding purposes only — not legal advice."

Pitfall 4: Not Standardizing Your Output Format

If every extraction looks different, you'll spend time reformatting instead of saving time. Prevention: Define your output format precisely in the prompt (Step 3 and Step 5). Use the same format every time.

Pitfall 5: Processing One Document at a Time When You Could Batch

Uploading one document, extracting, then uploading the next is slow. Prevention: Some AI tools let you

process multiple pages in one session. Upload all invoices at once and say "Process all invoices on the following pages, providing the extraction for each one separately."

Handling Different Document Languages

If your business receives documents in multiple languages (common in the EU), AI handles this well:

> Multi-Language Extraction Prompt:

>

> I'm uploading a document that may be in [Dutch/French/German/English]. Please:
>
> 1. Identify the language of the document
> 2. Extract all data fields into English
> 3. Keep proper nouns (company names, addresses) in their original language
> 4. Convert any dates to DD/MM/YYYY format
> 5. Keep amounts in their original currency

Scaling Up: Automated Document Processing

Once manual AI-assisted processing is working, consider these next steps:

- Email forwarding rule — automatically forward invoices from known suppliers to a processing inbox
- Zapier + AI — new email attachment → AI extraction → data added to spreadsheet/accounting tool
- Dext or Nanonets — dedicated document processing that connects to accounting software (Xero, QuickBooks, etc.)
- Custom automation — for high volume, build a simple script that processes a folder of PDFs through an AI API

> Automation Architecture Example:

>

> 1. Supplier sends invoice by email
> 2. Email rule forwards to "invoices@yourcompany.com"

3. Zapier triggers on new email

3. Zapier triggers on new email
4. Attachment is uploaded to AI extraction (via API)
5. Extracted data is added to a Google Sheet
6. Office manager reviews the sheet once daily
7. Approved entries are synced to accounting software

This turns a 2-hour weekly task into a 15-minute daily review.

Quick-Start Checklist

- [ ] List all document types you process regularly
- [ ] Define exactly what data you need from each type
- [ ] Create extraction prompts for your top 2-3 document types
- [ ] Process 10 documents as a test
- [ ] Verify accuracy against source documents
- [ ] Create spreadsheet-ready output formats
- [ ] Set up a processing routine (daily or weekly)
- [ ] Train anyone who handles documents on the new process
- [ ] Track time savings for the first month
- [ ] After 1 month, reduce verification to spot-checks for high-accuracy document types
- [ ] Consider scaling to automated processing if volume justifies it

Chapter 8

Playbook: SOP Generator

What This Playbook Does

Every business runs on unwritten rules. The way Sarah handles returns. The exact steps Marco follows when onboarding a new client. The workaround Dave uses when the inventory system glitches. This knowledge lives in people's heads — and when those people go on holiday, call in sick, or leave the company, the knowledge walks out the door with them.

This playbook shows you how to capture those informal processes and use AI to transform them into clean, professional Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) that anyone on your team can follow.

Time to implement: 2–4 hours for your first SOP, then 30–60 minutes each after that.

Expected time savings: 3–5 hours per SOP (compared to writing them manually from scratch).

Tools needed:

- Any voice recording app (free — your phone's built-in recorder works)
- A transcription tool: Otter.ai (free tier), Google Docs voice typing (free), or Whisper (free, open source)
- An AI assistant: ChatGPT (free tier works), Claude, or any capable LLM
- A document editor: Google Docs, Word, or Notion (all have free options)

Why Most SOPs Never Get Written

Let's be honest: nobody enjoys writing SOPs. The people who know the process are too busy doing it. The people who could write it up don't understand the process deeply enough. And the result is either:

1. No documentation at all (most common)
2. A document written once and never updated
3. A 47-page manual nobody reads

AI changes this equation completely. Instead of sitting down and writing from scratch, you simply talk through what you do and let AI structure it into a professional SOP. The bottleneck — turning messy knowledge into clean documentation — is exactly what AI excels at.

Step-by-Step Process

Step 1: Identify Your Most Critical Undocumented Process (15 minutes)

Don't try to document everything at once. Start with the process that causes the most pain when the person who knows it is unavailable.

Ask yourself:

- Which process would grind to a halt if one specific person were out for a week?
- What do new hires struggle with most in their first month?
- Which task generates the most "how do I do this again?" questions?
- Where do mistakes happen most often?

Pick one. Write down its name and who currently owns it.

Step 2: Record the Process Owner Talking Through It (15–30 minutes)

This is the most important step, and it's deliberately low-effort. Don't ask anyone to write anything. Just ask them to talk.

Set up the recording:

Open your phone's voice recorder (or Otter.ai for automatic transcription). Tell the process owner:

> "I'm going to ask you to walk me through [process name] as if you're training someone brand new. Don't worry about being organized or polished — just explain it the way you'd explain it to a new hire sitting next to you. I'll record it so we don't have to do this again."

Guide the conversation with these prompts:

1. "What triggers this process? How do you know it's time to start?"
2. "Walk me through it from the very first step."
3. "What tools or systems do you use?"

4. "What do you do when [common problem] happens?"
5. "What mistakes do people usually make?"
6. "Is there anything you check or double-check before you consider it done?"
7. "How long does this usually take?"
8. "Is there anything you wish you'd known when you first learned this?"

Pro tip: Record screen shares when the process involves software. Tools like Loom (free tier) or your OS's built-in screen recorder capture both voice and visual steps.

Step 3: Get a Transcript (5–15 minutes)

If you used Otter.ai, you already have one. Otherwise:

Option A — Google Docs (free):

Open a new Google Doc → Tools → Voice Typing → play the recording near your microphone. Not perfect, but workable.

Option B — Whisper (free, more accurate):

If you're slightly technical, OpenAI's Whisper gives excellent results. Many free web interfaces exist (search "whisper transcription free online").

Option C — Paid transcription:

Rev.com, Descript, or Otter.ai's paid tier all produce high-quality transcripts for $0.10–$0.25/minute.

Don't worry about transcript quality. Typos and odd formatting are fine — AI handles messy input well.

Step 4: Feed the Transcript to AI and Generate a Draft SOP (10 minutes)

This is where the magic happens. Use this prompt:

> Prompt — SOP Generator (First Draft)

>

> You are a technical writer specializing in creating Standard Operating Procedures for small businesses.

>

> Below is a transcript of an employee describing how they perform [PROCESS NAME]. Please transform this into a professional SOP document with the following structure:

>

1. Title — Clear name for the procedure

> 1. Title — Clear name for the procedure
> 2. Purpose — One paragraph explaining why this process exists and what it achieves
> 3. Scope — Who this applies to and when
> 4. Prerequisites — What's needed before starting (tools, access, information)
> 5. Definitions — Any terms or jargon that need explanation
> 6. Step-by-Step Procedure — Numbered steps, written as clear instructions. Each step should start with an action verb. Include sub-steps where needed. Note any decision points ("If X, do Y. If Z, do W.")
> 7. Common Issues & Troubleshooting — Problems that come up and how to handle them
> 8. Quality Checks — How to verify the process was completed correctly
> 9. Time Estimate — How long this typically takes
> 10. Related Processes — Any connected procedures

>

> Write at a level that a new employee with no prior experience could follow. Be specific — include exact button names, menu paths, and field names where mentioned. Flag any steps that seem unclear or where the transcript was ambiguous with [NEEDS CLARIFICATION].

>

> Here is the transcript:
>
> [PASTE TRANSCRIPT]

Step 5: Review and Refine with AI (15–30 minutes)

The first draft will be 70–80% there. Now refine it:

Fill in the gaps:

> Prompt — Gap Analysis

>

> Review the SOP you just created. List any steps that might be confusing to a brand-new employee, any missing context, or any places where you had to guess what the speaker meant. Format as a numbered list of questions I should ask the process owner.

Take those questions back to the process owner. This usually takes 5 minutes — much easier than asking them to review a whole document.

Add warnings and tips:

> Prompt — Add Practical Warnings

>

> Review this SOP and add:
>
> - WARNING boxes before any step where a mistake could cause data loss, financial impact, or customer issues
> - TIP boxes where there's a faster way to do something or a helpful shortcut
> - CHECKPOINT boxes at natural pause points where the user should verify they're on track before continuing

>

> [PASTE CURRENT SOP]

Simplify the language:

> Prompt — Readability Check

>

> Rewrite this SOP so it scores below grade 8 on the Flesch-Kincaid readability scale. Replace any jargon with plain language. Keep all technical terms that are necessary but add brief definitions in parentheses.

>

> [PASTE CURRENT SOP]

Step 6: Have Someone Test It (30–60 minutes)

This step is non-negotiable. Find someone who has never performed the process and ask them to follow the SOP step by step. Sit nearby (or have them share their screen) and note:

- Where they hesitate
- Where they ask questions
- Where they make a wrong turn
- Where they skip ahead because a step seems obvious

Every hesitation is a gap in your SOP. Feed the notes back to AI:

> Prompt — Incorporate Tester Feedback

>

> A new employee tested this SOP. Here are the issues they encountered:

>

> [LIST ISSUES]

>

Please update the SOP to address each issue. Add clarifying details, reorder steps if needed, and make sure the problem areas are crystal clear.

> Please update the SOP to address each issue. Add clarifying details, reorder steps if needed, and make sure the problem areas are crystal clear.

>

> [PASTE CURRENT SOP]

Step 7: Format and Publish (15 minutes)

Your SOP is now solid. Add final formatting:

> Prompt — Final Formatting

>

> Format this SOP for professional use with the following metadata header:

>

> - Document ID: [DEPARTMENT]-SOP-[NUMBER]
> - Version: 1.0
> - Created: [TODAY'S DATE]
> - Last Reviewed: [TODAY'S DATE]
> - Next Review: [DATE + 6 MONTHS]
> - Owner: [PROCESS OWNER NAME]
> - Approved By: [YOUR NAME]

>

> Also add a version history table at the bottom.

>

> [PASTE FINAL SOP]

Save it wherever your team can access it — Google Drive, Notion, SharePoint, or even a shared folder.

Scaling Up: Building Your SOP Library

Once you've done one, the process gets much faster. Here's how to build momentum:

Week 1: Document 1 critical process (the one causing the most pain)

Week 2–3: Document 2 more processes, one per week

Month 2: Aim for 1–2 SOPs per week

Quarter 1 goal: 10–15 core processes documented

Batch recording tip: Schedule a "Process Documentation Hour" where you interview 2–3 people back-to-back. Record all conversations, then process the transcripts with AI afterward. This is far more efficient than scheduling individual sessions.

The SOP-from-Screen-Recording Shortcut

For software-based processes, this alternative approach is even faster:

1. Ask the process owner to record their screen while performing the task (using Loom, OBS, or built-in screen recording)
2. Get the video transcribed (Loom does this automatically)
3. Use this specialized prompt:

> Prompt — SOP from Screen Recording
>
> Below is a transcript from a screen recording of an employee performing [PROCESS NAME] in [SOFTWARE NAME]. The transcript includes their verbal narration as they click through the process.
>
> Create a detailed SOP that includes:
>
> - Exact navigation paths (e.g., "Click Settings → Users → Add New")
>
> - Field names and what to enter in each
>
> - Screenshots descriptions (describe what the screen should look like at each major step, so we can add screenshots later)
>
> - Decision points and what determines each path
>
> Format each step as: [Step Number]. [Action] — [Expected Result]
>
> [PASTE TRANSCRIPT]

Common Pitfalls

Trying to document everything at once. Start with 1 process. Get the rhythm down. Then scale.

Making it too detailed. If a step is truly obvious ("Open your web browser"), skip it. SOPs should respect

the reader's intelligence while catching the non-obvious stuff.

Never updating them. Set calendar reminders for 6-month reviews. Processes change. SOPs should change with them.

Skipping the test step. An SOP that hasn't been tested by someone new is just a rough draft. The 30 minutes you spend testing saves hours of confusion later.

Making them hard to find. The best SOP in the world is useless if nobody can find it. Create a simple index document or use a tool like Notion with a searchable database.

Real-World Example

Process: Handling a customer refund request

Recording excerpt (messy, natural speech):

"So when someone emails in wanting a refund, first thing I do is check if it's within 30 days, because that's our policy. I go into Stripe, search their email, find the charge. If it's under 30 days I just process it right there. Over 30 days, I have to check with Maria first. Oh, and if it's over €500 I always check with management regardless of the timeframe. Then I send them the confirmation email — there's a template in the shared drive somewhere, I think it's called refund-confirmation or something..."

AI output (clean SOP excerpt):

> Step 3: Determine Refund Eligibility
>
> 3.1. Calculate the number of days between the purchase date and today.
>
> 3.2. Apply the following decision rules:
>
> | Condition | Action |
> |---|---|
> | Within 30 days AND under €500 | Proceed to Step 4 (Process Refund) |
> | Within 30 days AND €500 or over | Email management for approval, then proceed to Step 4 |
> | Over 30 days (any amount) | Email Maria (maria@company.com) for approval before proceeding |
>

WARNING: Never process a refund over €500 without written management approval. Save the approval email for records.

> WARNING: Never process a refund over €500 without written management approval. Save the approval email for records.

See the difference? Same information, but now anyone on the team can handle it correctly.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should have:

- A clear, tested SOP for your most critical process
- A repeatable system for documenting any future process in under an hour
- Reduced dependency on specific team members
- Faster onboarding for new hires
- Fewer "how do I do this?" interruptions

The real ROI: Every time a new hire learns a process from your SOP instead of shadowing someone for a day, you've saved two people's time — the new hire's and the trainer's. For a process that takes 2 hours to learn by shadowing, a good SOP pays for itself the first time it's used.

Chapter 9

Playbook: Content Repurposing Engine

What This Playbook Does

You wrote a great blog post. Or you gave a talk. Or you recorded a video explaining something you know well. That one piece of content represents hours of thinking, writing, and refining — and most businesses use it exactly once, in exactly one format.

This playbook shows you how to take any single piece of quality content and systematically transform it into 10+ different formats across multiple platforms. One hour of AI-assisted work can generate a week's worth of content across every channel your audience uses.

Time to implement: 1–2 hours per content piece (after initial setup of your prompts).

Expected time savings: 8–12 hours per content piece (compared to creating each format from scratch).

Tools needed:

- An AI assistant: ChatGPT, Claude, or any capable LLM (free tiers work)
- A text editor or Google Doc for your source content
- Canva (free tier) for visual formats
- A scheduling tool: Buffer, Hootsuite, or Later (free tiers available)
- Optional: Descript or CapCut for video/audio editing (free tiers available)

The Content Repurposing Framework

Think of your content as a tree. The trunk is your original, long-form piece. The branches are medium-form adaptations. The leaves are short-form snippets. And the roots are the research and data that support everything.

```
[Original Content — Blog/Video/Talk]
│
┌──────────────────┼──────────────────┐
```

```
|                 |                 |
[Medium-form]   [Medium-form]    [Medium-form]
Newsletter      LinkedIn Article  Podcast Script
|                 |                 |
┌────┼────┐      ┌────┼────┐      ┌────┼────┐
[Short] [Short] [Short] [Short] [Short] [Short]
Tweet   Carousel  Quote   Reel   Thread  Audiogram
```

You're not just copy-pasting — each format is adapted for its platform's audience, tone, and constraints.

Step-by-Step Process

Step 1: Choose Your Source Content (5 minutes)

Your source material should be:

- Substantial — at least 800 words or 5 minutes of audio/video
- Valuable — teaches something, shares an insight, or solves a problem
- Evergreen-ish — still relevant for at least a few months

Good candidates:

- Blog posts or articles you've written
- Talks or presentations you've given
- Podcast episodes or interviews
- Long email responses where you explained something well
- Internal training materials
- Customer case studies

If your source is audio or video, get it transcribed first (see Chapter 8 for transcription options).

Step 2: Extract the Core Elements (10 minutes)

Before generating any formats, have AI analyze your source content for reusable elements:

> Prompt — Content Analysis

>

> Analyze the following content and extract:

>

1. Core thesis — The single main argument or insight, in one sentence

1. Core thesis — The single main argument or insight, in one sentence

> 2. Key points — 3-5 supporting points or takeaways
>
> 3. Quotable lines — 3-5 sentences that stand alone as powerful statements
>
> 4. Data/statistics — Any numbers, percentages, or concrete results mentioned
>
> 5. Stories/examples — Any anecdotes or case studies included
>
> 6. Actionable advice — Specific steps readers can take
>
> 7. Contrarian or surprising elements — Anything that challenges conventional thinking
>
> 8. Target audience — Who would benefit most from this content

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE YOUR CONTENT]

Save this analysis. It's the foundation for everything that follows.

Step 3: Generate All 10 Formats

Now the fun part. Work through each format using the prompts below. You can do them in any order, but I've arranged them from highest effort to lowest.

Format 1: Newsletter Email

Best for: nurturing your email list, driving traffic back to the original

> Prompt — Newsletter Adaptation

>

> Transform this content into a newsletter email (400-600 words). The tone should be conversational and personal, as if writing to a friend who's interested in [YOUR INDUSTRY].

>

> Structure:
>
> - Hook: Open with a question, surprising fact, or brief story (2-3 sentences)
>
> - Value: Share the key insight and 2-3 most actionable points
>
> - Story: Include one specific example or case study
>
> - CTA: End with a single clear call-to-action (read the full article / reply with their experience / try one tip this week)

>

Do NOT just summarize — rewrite it in a more personal, email-friendly voice. Use "you" frequently. Keep

paragraphs to 1-3 sentences.

Do NOT just summarize — rewrite it in a more personal, email-friendly voice. Use "you" frequently.

Keep paragraphs to 1-3 sentences.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

>

> Brand voice notes: [e.g., "Professional but warm. We use occasional humor. Never corporate-speak."]

Format 2: LinkedIn Article / Post (Long-form)

Best for: establishing thought leadership, reaching professional audience

> Prompt — LinkedIn Long-Form Post

>

> Transform this content into a LinkedIn post (800-1,200 words). LinkedIn's algorithm favors:
>
> - Strong opening hook (first 2 lines must make people click "see more")
> - Personal perspective and experience
> - Specific, actionable advice
> - Line breaks between short paragraphs (1-2 sentences each)
> - A question at the end to drive comments

>

> Structure:
>
> - Hook (1-2 lines that create curiosity or state something bold)
> - Personal context (why you care about this topic)
> - Core insight with 3-5 supporting points
> - Specific example or story
> - Actionable takeaway
> - Closing question

>

> Use "I" and "you" language. No bullet-point lists longer than 5 items. Include 3-5 relevant hashtags at the end.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Format 3: Twitter/X Thread

Best for: viral potential, reaching new audiences, bite-sized education

> Prompt — Twitter/X Thread

>

> Transform this content into a Twitter/X thread of 7-12 tweets.

>

> Rules:
>
> - Tweet 1 (hook): Must be attention-grabbing and self-contained. End with "" or "A thread:"
>
> - Each tweet: 240 characters max (leave room for engagement). Must make sense on its own AND flow as part of the thread
>
> - Use concrete numbers and specifics over vague claims
>
> - Include one tweet that's a counterintuitive or surprising insight
>
> - Tweet before last: Summarize the key takeaway
>
> - Final tweet: CTA (follow for more, link to full article, or ask a question)

>

> Format each tweet on its own line, numbered 1/ through N/

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Format 4: Instagram/LinkedIn Carousel

Best for: visual learners, high save/share rates, educational content

> Prompt — Carousel Script

>

> Transform this content into a 7-10 slide carousel for Instagram/LinkedIn.

>

> For each slide, provide:
>
> - Slide number
>
> - Headline (5-8 words, large text)
>
> - Body text (15-25 words max — this is overlay text on an image)
>
> - Visual suggestion (what the background or graphic should convey)

>

> Slide structure:
>
> - Slide 1: Bold hook/title (must stop the scroll)
> - Slides 2-3: The problem or context
> - Slides 4-7: The solution, one point per slide
> - Slide 8-9: Summary or key takeaway
> - Final slide: CTA (save this, follow for more, link in bio)

>

> Keep text minimal — carousels are visual. Each slide should be understandable in 3 seconds.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Implementation tip: Take the carousel script into Canva. Use a consistent template. Creating 10 slides takes about 15 minutes once you have the text.

Format 5: Short-Form Video Script (Reels/TikTok/Shorts)

Best for: reaching younger audiences, algorithm-friendly format, high engagement

> Prompt — Short Video Script

>

> Transform this content into a 60-90 second video script for Instagram Reels / TikTok / YouTube Shorts.

>

> Structure:
>
> - Hook (0-3 seconds): Start mid-thought with something surprising. No intros, no "hey guys." Example patterns: "The biggest mistake...", "Nobody tells you that...", "Here's what [result] actually looks like..."
>
> - Problem (3-15 seconds): Briefly state the pain point your audience has
> - Solution (15-50 seconds): Share 2-3 specific, actionable tips. Be concrete.
> - Proof (50-60 seconds): Quick result, example, or social proof
> - CTA (60-70 seconds): "Follow for more" or "Save this for later"

>

> Write it as a spoken script — conversational, short sentences. Include [VISUAL CUE] notes for what to show on screen.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Format 6: Podcast Talking Points / Solo Episode Script

Best for: audio-first audiences, in-depth discussion, personal connection

> Prompt — Podcast Episode Outline

>

> Transform this content into talking points for a 10-15 minute podcast episode (solo format).

>

> Structure:
>
> - Cold open (30 sec): Start with the most interesting point or a provocative question
>
> - Intro (1 min): Set context — why this topic matters right now
>
> - Main content (8-12 min): Walk through the key points conversationally. Include:
>
> - Personal anecdotes or client stories
>
> - "Here's what most people get wrong" moments
>
> - Practical examples
>
> - Transitions between sections
>
> - Summary (1 min): Recap the 3 big takeaways
>
> - CTA (30 sec): Ask listeners to do one thing

>

> Write as bullet points with key phrases (not a word-for-word script — it should sound natural when spoken). Include suggested tangents or stories to make it personal.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Format 7: Quote Graphics (3-5 images)

Best for: high shareability, Instagram stories, Pinterest

> Prompt — Quotable Excerpts

>

> From this content, extract or create 5 standalone quotes that work as image overlays. Each quote should:

>

> - Be 10-20 words maximum
> - Make sense without any context
> - Be insightful, surprising, or motivating
> - Work as a square graphic with large text

>

> For each quote, also suggest:
>
> - A background mood (e.g., "dark and bold", "light and minimal", "nature/calm")
> - A relevant emoji that could accompany it

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Implementation: Drop these into Canva templates. 2 minutes per graphic.

Format 8: Email Signature / Forum Response Snippet

Best for: passive distribution, establishing expertise in communities

> Prompt — Micro-Summary

>

> Condense this content into a 2-3 sentence summary that could be:
>
> 1. Used as a response in a relevant online forum or community discussion
> 2. Included as a "latest insight" in an email signature
> 3. Posted as a comment on someone else's related content

>

> Make it valuable on its own — not a teaser. It should demonstrate expertise and naturally make people want to learn more. Include a subtle reference to the full piece without being salesy.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Format 9: FAQ / Q&A Format

Best for: SEO, voice search optimization, knowledge base content

> Prompt — FAQ Transformation
>
> Transform this content into a Q&A / FAQ format with 5-8 questions.
>
> Each question should:
>
> - Be phrased the way a real person would ask it (natural language)
> - Start with who/what/when/where/why/how
> - Be something someone might actually type into Google
>
> Each answer should:
>
> - Be 2-4 sentences (concise but complete)
> - Include the key term/phrase from the question in the answer (for SEO)
> - Be factual and directly actionable
>
> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Format 10: Infographic Outline

Best for: Pinterest, blog enhancement, link building, presentations

> Prompt — Infographic Structure
>
> Transform this content into an infographic outline with:
>
> 1. Title (8 words or fewer, attention-grabbing)
> 2. Subtitle (one line explaining what the reader will learn)
> 3. Sections (4-6 sections, each with):
>
> - Section header (3-5 words)
> - One key statistic or data point (use a number)
> - One sentence of explanation

- Suggested icon or visual element

- Suggested icon or visual element

> 4. Footer — Key takeaway + source/credit

>

> The infographic should tell a story from top to bottom: Problem → Context → Solution → Steps → Result.

>

> Source content:
>
> [PASTE CONTENT]

Implementation: Use Canva's infographic templates or tools like Piktochart (free tier). The AI-generated outline means you're just placing elements, not designing from scratch.

Step 4: Quality Control Each Piece (20–30 minutes)

Don't publish AI output without review. For each format, check:

1. Accuracy — Does it faithfully represent the original content?
2. Platform fit — Does it follow the conventions of the target platform?
3. Brand voice — Does it sound like you/your company?
4. Value — Would someone benefit from this even without seeing the original?
5. CTA alignment — Does each piece drive toward a business goal?

> Prompt — Voice Consistency Check

>

> Compare these two texts. The first is our original content in our brand voice. The second is an adaptation for [PLATFORM].

>

> Identify any places where the adaptation sounds generic, overly formal, or inconsistent with the original voice. Suggest specific rewrites for those sections.

>

> Original: [PASTE EXCERPT FROM SOURCE]

>

> Adaptation: [PASTE THE FORMAT YOU'RE CHECKING]

Step 5: Schedule and Distribute (15 minutes)

Don't publish everything at once. Spread it out:

Week 1:

- Day 1: Publish original long-form content
- Day 2: Send newsletter
- Day 3: Post LinkedIn article
- Day 4: Share Twitter thread
- Day 5: Post first carousel

Week 2:

- Day 1-2: Post quote graphics (one per day on Stories)
- Day 3: Share short-form video
- Day 4: Post FAQ version on your website
- Day 5: Share infographic on Pinterest/LinkedIn

This gives you two full weeks of content from one original piece.

The Content Repurposing Workflow (Summary)

Step	Time	Output
Choose source content	5 min	Selected piece
Extract core elements	10 min	Analysis document
Generate 10 formats	40–60 min	10 content pieces
Quality control	20–30 min	Polished content
Schedule & distribute	15 min	2-week content calendar
Total	~2 hours	10+ pieces of content

Building a Repurposing System

Create Your Prompt Library

After your first round, save all the prompts with your brand voice notes already filled in. Create a

document called "Content Repurposing Prompts" with each prompt template ready to go. Next time, you just paste the source content — no prompt engineering needed.

Batch Processing

The most efficient approach:

1. Write/record 4 pieces of original content per month (1 per week)
2. Block 2 hours every Monday for repurposing the previous week's content
3. Schedule everything for the coming week
4. Result: 40+ pieces of content per month from 4 hours of repurposing work

Create Templates for Visual Formats

In Canva, create branded templates for:

- Carousel slides (consistent style, colors, fonts)
- Quote graphics (2-3 variations)
- Infographic layout

Once templates exist, going from AI text to finished graphic takes 2-3 minutes per piece.

Common Pitfalls

Copy-pasting the same text everywhere. Each platform has different norms. A blog post dumped on LinkedIn performs poorly. The whole point is adaptation, not duplication.

Not including platform-specific formatting. LinkedIn loves line breaks. Twitter needs conciseness. Newsletters need a personal touch. If it reads the same on every platform, you're doing it wrong.

Skipping the quality check. AI can introduce subtle errors or miss your brand voice. Always review before publishing, especially quotes and statistics.

Publishing all 10 formats on the same day. Spread your content out. Each platform's algorithm rewards consistency over bursts.

Repurposing weak source content. Garbage in, garbage out. If the original piece isn't valuable, 10 versions of it won't be either. Start with your best content.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should have:

- 10+ content pieces from every original piece you create
- Consistent presence across multiple platforms
- A repeatable weekly system that takes ~2 hours
- A growing library of prompt templates customized to your brand
- More time to create quality original content (because distribution is systematized)

The real ROI: If you value your content creation time at €50/hour and each piece of content would normally take 1 hour to create from scratch, repurposing one piece saves you €400–€500 in time. Even if you spend 2 hours on repurposing, you're still saving 8+ hours — a 4x return on your time investment.

Chapter 10

Playbook: Social Media Post Generator

What This Playbook Does

Social media is a volume game. You need to show up consistently — 3-5 times per week minimum — and every post needs to sound like you, not like a robot. Most small businesses either post sporadically (when they remember) or burn out trying to keep up.

This playbook gives you a system for generating weeks of brand-consistent social media content in a single sitting using AI. You'll create a brand voice guide, build a post generation system, and develop a workflow that produces 20+ posts per month in under 3 hours of total work.

Time to implement: 2–3 hours for initial setup (brand voice + templates), then 1–2 hours per month for ongoing content generation.

Expected time savings: 8–15 hours per month (compared to writing each post individually).

Tools needed:

- An AI assistant: ChatGPT, Claude, or any capable LLM (free tiers work)
- A spreadsheet: Google Sheets or Excel (free)
- A scheduling tool: Buffer, Hootsuite, or Later (free tiers support 3 channels)
- Canva (free tier) for any visual posts
- Optional: A social media analytics tool for measuring performance

---

Why AI-Generated Social Media Usually Fails

Before we build the system, let's address the elephant in the room: most AI-generated social media content is obvious and bad. It's generic. It uses phrases no human would say. It includes too many emojis. It sounds like every other AI-generated post on the internet.

The fix isn't better prompts — it's better input. AI needs three things to generate good social content:

1. Your actual voice — not a description of your voice, but examples of it
2. Your specific expertise — not generic industry advice, but your unique perspective
3. Platform-specific constraints — each platform has unwritten rules

This playbook gives AI all three.

Step-by-Step Process

Step 1: Build Your Brand Voice Document (45 minutes, one-time setup)

This is the most important step. It's a one-time investment that makes everything after it dramatically better.

Gather 10-15 examples of your best writing:

- Past social media posts that performed well
- Email responses you're proud of
- Blog posts or articles
- Slack/Teams messages that captured your voice
- Customer testimonials (to understand how others perceive you)

Paste them all into one document, then use this prompt:

> Prompt — Brand Voice Analysis

>

> Analyze these writing samples from [YOUR NAME/COMPANY]. All are written by the same person/brand. Extract a detailed brand voice profile:

>

> 1. Tone — Overall feeling (e.g., authoritative but approachable). Describe on 3-4 spectrums:
>
> - Formal ←→ Casual
>
> - Serious ←→ Playful
>
> - Technical ←→ Simple
>
> - Reserved ←→ Bold

>

> 2. Vocabulary patterns — Words and phrases that appear frequently. Industry-specific terms used. Any words that are deliberately avoided.

>

> 3. Sentence structure — Average length. Do they use fragments? Questions? Lists?

>

> 4. Personality markers — Humor style (if any). How they show expertise. How they connect with readers. Any recurring themes or values.

>

> 5. What they NEVER do — Based on these samples, what communication patterns are absent? (e.g., never uses corporate jargon, never uses exclamation marks, never self-promotes directly)

>

> 6. Example phrases — Generate 10 phrases that sound like this person/brand based on the patterns you've identified.

>

> Writing samples:
>
> [PASTE ALL SAMPLES]

Save the output as your Brand Voice Document. You'll reference it in every social media prompt going forward.

Step 2: Define Your Content Pillars (15 minutes)

Content pillars are the 4-6 topics you consistently post about. Having defined pillars prevents the "what should I post about?" paralysis.

> Prompt — Content Pillar Development

>

> I run a [TYPE OF BUSINESS] that helps [TARGET AUDIENCE] with [CORE SERVICE/PRODUCT].

>

> Our key differentiators are:
>
> - [DIFFERENTIATOR 1]
>
> - [DIFFERENTIATOR 2]
>
> - [DIFFERENTIATOR 3]

>

> Suggest 5 content pillars for our social media presence. Each pillar should:
>
> - Relate to our expertise and audience interests
>
> - Be broad enough to generate 20+ unique posts
>
> - Include a mix of educational, entertaining, and promotional angles

>

> For each pillar, provide:
>
> - Pillar name (2-3 words)
>
> - Description (1 sentence)
>
> - 5 example post topics

Example output:

1. Behind the Scenes — How we actually work, real examples and processes
2. Industry Myths — Calling out bad advice and misconceptions
3. Quick Tips — One actionable tip per post
4. Client Wins — Results and success stories (anonymized if needed)
5. Opinion / Hot Take — Our honest perspective on industry trends

Step 3: Create Your Post Generation Prompt (20 minutes)

This is the master prompt you'll use every month. It combines your brand voice, content pillars, and platform-specific rules:

> Prompt — Weekly Post Batch Generator

>

> You are the social media manager for [COMPANY NAME]. Your job is to write social media posts that sound authentically like the brand — not like AI.

>

> Brand Voice:
>
> [PASTE YOUR BRAND VOICE DOCUMENT FROM STEP 1]

>

> Content Pillars:
>
> [PASTE YOUR PILLARS FROM STEP 2]

>

> Platform: [CHOOSE ONE — LinkedIn / Instagram / Twitter/X / Facebook]

>

> Platform-specific rules:
>
> - [See platform guidelines below]

>

> Generate [NUMBER] posts for the next [TIME PERIOD]. For each post, include:

>

> 1. Pillar — Which content pillar it falls under
> 2. Post text — The full post, ready to copy and paste
> 3. Visual suggestion — What image/graphic to pair with it (if applicable)
> 4. Best posting time — Suggested day and time
> 5. Engagement hook — How the post encourages interaction (question, poll, CTA)

>

> Mix up the pillars — don't cluster them. Vary post length and format. At least 20% should be short (under 50 words).

>

> Important: Write like a real person. No post should start with a generic hook like "In today's fast-paced world..." or "Have you ever wondered...". Start mid-thought, with a bold claim, or with a specific detail.

Platform-Specific Rules to Include:

For LinkedIn:

```
- Max 3,000 characters, but sweet spot is 800-1,500
- First 2 lines must hook (everything after is behind "see more")
- Use line breaks between short paragraphs
- End with a question to drive comments
- 3-5 hashtags at the end
- No emojis in the first line
- Personal stories outperform generic advice
```

For Instagram (captions):

```
- Max 2,200 characters, but sweet spot is 150-300 for feed posts
- Front-load the value (first line is all most people read)
- Use line breaks for readability
- 20-30 hashtags in first comment (not in caption)
- Include a clear CTA: save, share, comment, or link in bio
- Pair every post with a visual description
```

For Twitter/X:

```
- Max 280 characters per tweet
- No hashtags in the tweet body (use 1-2 only if essential)
- Thread format for longer content (mark with )
- Bold, opinionated takes perform best
- Quote-tweet worthy content: stats, hot takes, frameworks
- Use "ratio-bait" occasionally (controversial but defensible opinions)
```

For Facebook:

```
- Sweet spot: 80-200 characters for highest engagement
- Questions and polls drive comments
- Link posts get suppressed — put links in comments
- Native content outperforms shared links
- Community-focused language works best
```

Step 4: Generate a Month's Worth of Content (30 minutes)

Run the master prompt for each platform you use. If you post on 2 platforms, 5 times per week each, that's 40 posts per month.

Efficiency tip: Generate for your primary platform first, then use this adaptation prompt for secondary platforms:

> Prompt — Platform Adaptation
>
> Here are [NUMBER] posts written for [ORIGINAL PLATFORM]. Adapt each one for [TARGET PLATFORM], following these rules:
>
> [PASTE PLATFORM-SPECIFIC RULES]
>
> Keep the core message and brand voice identical, but adjust:
>
> - Length and format for the new platform
>
> - Tone (LinkedIn is more professional, Twitter is more punchy, etc.)
>
> - CTAs appropriate to the platform
>
> - Any platform-specific conventions
>
> Original posts:
>
> [PASTE POSTS]

Step 5: Create a Content Calendar (15 minutes)

Organize your posts in a spreadsheet with these columns:

Date	Platform	Pillar	Post Text	Visual	Status
Mon 3/24	LinkedIn	Quick Tip	[post text]	Graphic: stat overlay	Scheduled
Tue 3/25	Instagram	Behind the Scenes	[post text]	Photo: workspace	Draft

Prompt — Content Calendar Optimizer

Prompt — Content Calendar Optimizer

>

> Here are my [NUMBER] posts for [MONTH]. Arrange them into an optimal posting schedule considering:

>

> - Don't post the same content pillar two days in a row
> - Alternate between long and short posts
> - Put highest-value content on Tuesday-Thursday (highest engagement days for most B2B)
> - Promotional posts should be no more than 20% of total
> - Space out similar topics by at least 3-4 days

>

> Output as a table with: Date | Day | Platform | Pillar | Post Title/First Line

>

> Posts:
>
> [PASTE ALL POSTS WITH PILLAR LABELS]

Step 6: Review, Edit, and Add Personality (30 minutes)

This is the step that separates good from great. Go through every post and:

1. Read it out loud. If it sounds weird when spoken, rewrite it. Real social media posts sound natural.
2. Add specificity. Replace any generic statements with specific examples from your business. "We helped a client improve their process" → "We helped a bakery in Cork cut their order processing time from 2 hours to 15 minutes."
3. Check for AI-isms. Remove:
   - "In today's [adjective] world..."
   - "Here's the thing..."
   - "Let me tell you..."
   - Excessive emojis
   - Lists of exactly 5 items (AI loves lists of 5)
   - The word "landscape"
   - "Game-changer" / "revolutionary"
4. Add your unique perspective. For opinion-based posts, make sure it actually reflects YOUR opinion, not a generic middle-ground take.

Prompt — AI-ism Checker

Prompt — AI-ism Checker

>

> Review these social media posts and flag any that contain:
>
> - Phrases that are obviously AI-generated (generic hooks, corporate language, clichés)
> - Information that's too vague to be valuable
> - Tone inconsistencies with this brand voice: [PASTE BRIEF VOICE DESCRIPTION]
> - Any post that you wouldn't stop scrolling for

>

> For each flagged post, suggest a specific rewrite that sounds more human and authentic.

>

> Posts:
>
> [PASTE ALL POSTS]

Step 7: Schedule and Post (15 minutes)

Load everything into your scheduling tool. Most free-tier schedulers let you upload a CSV or copy-paste individual posts.

Set aside 10 minutes per day for engagement — responding to comments, liking relevant posts, and sharing others' content. AI generates the content; you provide the human connection.

Maintaining Brand Consistency Over Time

Monthly Voice Calibration

Every month, review your top-performing posts and update your brand voice document:

> Prompt — Voice Calibration

>

> Here are my 5 best-performing social media posts from last month (based on engagement):

>

> [PASTE TOP 5 POSTS]

>

And here are the 3 worst-performing:

And here are the 3 worst-performing:

>

> [PASTE BOTTOM 3 POSTS]

>

> Analyze what makes the top performers work and why the bottom ones fell flat. Update this brand voice profile with any new patterns:

>

> [PASTE CURRENT BRAND VOICE DOCUMENT]

Trending Topic Integration

When something relevant happens in your industry:

> Prompt — Reactive Post Generator

>

> [INDUSTRY EVENT/NEWS] just happened. Generate 3 social media posts reacting to this from our brand's perspective.

>

> Our relevant expertise/angle: [YOUR UNIQUE TAKE]

>

> Brand voice: [PASTE VOICE DOCUMENT]

>

> Platform: [PLATFORM]

>

> These should be posted within 24 hours, so prioritize timeliness and a clear point of view. Don't just report the news — add value through our expertise.

Common Pitfalls

Using the same prompt without your brand voice document. This is the #1 reason AI social content sounds generic. Always include your voice document.

Never posting anything spontaneous. Your scheduled content should be the backbone, not the entirety. Leave room for real-time posts about what's actually happening in your business.

Ignoring analytics. Check what performs. Double down on what works. Retire content pillars that consistently underperform.

Generating the same types of posts. Mix formats: short text, long-form, questions, polls, stories, tips, opinions, behind-the-scenes.

Automating engagement. Schedule the posts; do the engagement yourself. People can tell when comments are automated, and it damages trust.

The Complete Monthly Workflow

Task	Time	Frequency
Update brand voice document	15 min	Monthly
Generate month's posts (all platforms)	45 min	Monthly
Review and edit posts	30 min	Monthly
Create/select visuals	30 min	Monthly
Schedule posts	15 min	Monthly
Daily engagement (comments, replies)	10 min	Daily
Total monthly setup	~2.5 hours	
Total including daily engagement	~6 hours/month	

Compare that to the 15-20 hours most businesses spend on social media content creation each month.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should have:

- A documented brand voice that ensures consistency
- 20+ posts per month per platform, scheduled in advance
- A repeatable monthly system that takes under 3 hours
- Increasing engagement as you refine what works
- More time for actual engagement and relationship building

The real ROI: Consistency is what wins on social media. Posting 4x per week, every week, for 6 months will outperform sporadic bursts of daily posting every time. This system makes consistency achievable for

a team of one.

Chapter 11

Playbook: Sales Follow-Up Sequences

What This Playbook Does

You had a great meeting. The prospect was interested. You said you'd follow up. And then... life happened. The follow-up email got pushed to tomorrow, then next week, then never. By the time you remember, the prospect has gone cold or signed with a competitor.

This playbook shows you how to build AI-powered sales follow-up sequences that are personalized enough to feel handwritten, consistent enough that no lead ever falls through the cracks, and efficient enough that one person can manage 50+ active prospects without breaking a sweat.

Time to implement: 3–4 hours for initial setup, then 15–30 minutes per prospect to personalize.

Expected time savings: 5–10 hours per week (for someone managing 20+ active prospects).

Tools needed:

- An AI assistant: ChatGPT, Claude, or any capable LLM (free tiers work)
- A CRM or spreadsheet: HubSpot Free, Pipedrive, or Google Sheets
- An email tool: Gmail, Outlook, or any email client
- Optional: An email sequence tool like Mailshake, Lemlist, or HubSpot's free sequences (up to 5 emails per sequence)

Why Generic Follow-Ups Don't Work

Everyone's inbox is full of templates. "Just checking in," "circling back," "wanted to bump this to the top of your inbox" — these phrases trigger an instant delete reflex.

The irony: personalized follow-ups work dramatically better (2-3x higher response rates), but they take dramatically more time. AI closes this gap by generating follow-ups that reference specific details from your conversations, provide genuine value in each touchpoint, and adapt based on the prospect's behavior.

Step-by-Step Process

Step 1: Map Your Sales Process (20 minutes)

Before building any sequences, you need to know your typical sales journey. Answer these questions:

1. How do prospects first contact you? (Inbound form, cold outreach, referral, event)
2. What happens in the first interaction? (Discovery call, demo, meeting)
3. What are the typical decision stages? (Interest → Evaluation → Negotiation → Decision)
4. What's the average time from first contact to close? (1 week? 3 months?)
5. Who else is involved in the decision? (Just the prospect? A committee?)
6. What are the common reasons deals stall? (Budget, timing, competing priorities)
7. What are the common objections? (Price, features, trust, "we're fine as is")

> Prompt — Sales Process Mapping

>

> Based on the following information about my sales process, create a visual map showing the stages, typical timelines, and where follow-ups should occur.

>

> Business type: [YOUR BUSINESS TYPE]
>
> How prospects find us: [CHANNELS]
>
> Typical sales cycle: [LENGTH]
>
> Key decision factors: [WHAT MATTERS TO PROSPECTS]
>
> Common objections: [LIST 3-5]
>
> Common reasons deals stall: [LIST 3-5]

>

> For each stage, suggest:
>
> - Number of follow-up touchpoints
>
> - Spacing between touchpoints
>
> - Primary goal of each touchpoint
>
> - Best channel (email, phone, LinkedIn)

Step 2: Build Your Follow-Up Sequence Templates (60 minutes)

Most B2B sales require 5-8 touchpoints. Here's a proven sequence structure with prompts for each:

Email 1: Same-Day Recap (Send within 2 hours of meeting)

> Prompt — Meeting Recap Email

>

> Write a follow-up email after a sales meeting. Tone: professional, warm, and specific.

>

> Meeting details:
>
> - Prospect name: [NAME]
>
> - Company: [COMPANY]
>
> - Their role: [TITLE]
>
> - What they need: [THEIR KEY PAIN POINTS/GOALS]
>
> - What we discussed: [2-3 KEY TOPICS]
>
> - What I proposed: [SOLUTION OVERVIEW]
>
> - Next steps we agreed on: [ACTIONS]
>
> - Personal detail mentioned: [e.g., "They mentioned their team is growing quickly" or "They're launching a new product line in Q2"]

>

> Structure:
>
> 1. Reference something specific from our conversation (NOT "It was great meeting you")
>
> 2. Briefly summarize the 2-3 key points and proposed solution
>
> 3. Restate the agreed next steps with specific dates
>
> 4. Add one piece of value (relevant article, resource, or insight related to their situation)
>
> 5. Close warmly

>

> Keep it under 200 words. No attachments — save those for the next email.

Email 2: Value Drop (Send 2-3 days after Email 1)

> Prompt — Value-Add Follow-Up

>

> Write a short follow-up email that provides genuine value without asking for anything.

>

> Context:
>
> - Prospect name: [NAME]

- Their industry: [INDUSTRY]

- Their industry: [INDUSTRY]

> - Their main challenge: [PAIN POINT]
>
> - Our previous conversation: [BRIEF SUMMARY]

>

> The email should share one of the following (choose the most relevant):
>
> - A case study of how we helped a similar company
>
> - A relevant industry insight or trend
>
> - A practical tip they can use immediately, regardless of whether they buy from us
>
> - A resource (article, tool, template) related to their challenge

>

> Tone: helpful, not salesy. This email is about building trust. No pitch, no CTA to buy.
>
> End with a low-pressure question like "Does this resonate?" or "Have you seen this trend in your business?"

>

> Max 150 words.

Email 3: Social Proof (Send 5-7 days after Email 1)

> Prompt — Social Proof Email

>

> Write a follow-up email that uses social proof relevant to this prospect.

>

> Prospect details:
>
> - Name: [NAME]
>
> - Company: [COMPANY]
>
> - Industry: [INDUSTRY]
>
> - Company size: [SIZE]
>
> - Main challenge: [PAIN POINT]

>

> Available social proof (use what's most relevant):
>
> - Client testimonials: [LIST ANY]
>
> - Case studies: [BRIEF SUMMARIES]
>
> - Results/metrics: [SPECIFIC NUMBERS]
>
> - Industry recognition: [AWARDS, PRESS, etc.]

>

> Structure:
>
> 1. Brief, natural opener referencing our ongoing conversation
>
> 2. Transition: "I was thinking about [their specific challenge] and wanted to share..."
>
> 3. One specific result from a similar client (with numbers if possible)
>
> 4. Brief quote or result that demonstrates our credibility
>
> 5. Soft CTA: "Would it help to see the full case study?" or "Want me to connect you with [client name] so you can hear it firsthand?"

>

> Max 175 words. Must feel like genuine sharing, not a pitch.

Email 4: Objection Preemption (Send 10-12 days after Email 1)

> Prompt — Objection Handling Email

>

> Write a follow-up email that proactively addresses the most likely objection for this prospect, without them having raised it.

>

> Prospect details:
>
> - Name: [NAME]
>
> - Company: [COMPANY]
>
> - Stage: They seemed interested but haven't committed
>
> - Most likely objection: [CHOOSE ONE: price / timing / internal buy-in / existing solution / complexity / trust]

>

> Handle the objection using this framework:
>
> 1. Acknowledge it's a valid concern (empathy, not defensiveness)
>
> 2. Reframe it with a different perspective
>
> 3. Provide proof that addresses it (example, data, guarantee)
>
> 4. Make it easy to take the next step

>

> Common objection templates:
>
> - Price: Focus on cost of inaction, ROI, or flexible terms
>
> - Timing: Acknowledge and offer a smaller starting point

- Internal buy-in: Offer to present to their team or provide a summary deck

- Internal buy-in: Offer to present to their team or provide a summary deck

> - Existing solution: Highlight specific gaps without badmouthing competitor

>

> Tone: understanding, confident, not desperate. Max 200 words.

Email 5: The Breakup Email (Send 20-25 days after Email 1)

> Prompt — Breakup Email

>

> Write a final follow-up email in a sequence. This prospect has received 4 previous emails with no response.

>

> Prospect name: [NAME]
>
> What we discussed: [BRIEF SUMMARY]

>

> Rules:
>
> - Be direct and honest: acknowledge they may not be interested, and that's okay
>
> - Give them an easy "out" — don't guilt-trip
>
> - Leave the door open for future conversations
>
> - Include a simple 1-click response option (e.g., "Reply with 1 if you want to revisit in 3 months, 2 if the timing is wrong, or 3 if you're all set")
>
> - Be brief — under 100 words

>

> The goal is to either get a final response or close the loop with dignity.

>

> This email often gets the highest response rate in a sequence because it removes all pressure.

Step 3: Personalize at Scale (15 minutes per prospect)

Here's where the system comes together. For each new prospect, create a "Prospect Brief":

> Prompt — Prospect Brief Generator

>

Based on the following information, create a Prospect Brief I can use to personalize my follow-up sequence.

> Based on the following information, create a Prospect Brief I can use to personalize my follow-up sequence.

>

> Information I have:
>
> - Name: [NAME]
> - Company: [COMPANY]
> - Role: [TITLE]
> - Meeting notes: [PASTE RAW NOTES OR TRANSCRIPT]
> - Their LinkedIn profile summary: [PASTE IF AVAILABLE]
> - Their company's recent news: [PASTE IF AVAILABLE]

>

> Generate:
>
> 1. Key pain points (prioritized)
> 2. Decision drivers (what matters most to them)
> 3. Likely objections (ranked by probability)
> 4. Personal connection points (interests, background, shared connections)
> 5. Relevant social proof to use (suggest which of our case studies/results would resonate most)
> 6. Recommended value-add content (what article/resource/tip would be most useful to them)
> 7. Personalization hooks for each email in the sequence

Then use the Prospect Brief to fill in the variables in each email template. The AI generates the customized version; you review and send.

Step 4: Set Up Tracking (30 minutes)

You need to know what's working. At minimum, track:

In your CRM or spreadsheet:

Prospect	Email 1 Sent	Opened	Email 2 Sent	Opened	Reply	Stage	Notes
Jane Smith	Mar 1		Mar 4		Mar 5	Meeting booked	Interested in Q2
Tom Brown	Mar 1		Mar 4		—	Pending	Try phone call

Key metrics to watch:

- Open rate per email: If below 30%, your subject lines need work
- Reply rate per email: If below 5%, your content needs work
-

Sequence completion rate: What percentage of prospects make it to Email 5 without responding?

- Conversion rate: What percentage of sequenced prospects take the next step?

Step 5: Iterate Based on Results (Ongoing)

After running the sequence for 20+ prospects, analyze what's working:

> Prompt — Sequence Performance Analysis
>
> Here are the results from my sales follow-up sequence over [TIME PERIOD]:
>
> Email 1 (Recap): [OPEN RATE]% open, [REPLY RATE]% reply
>
> Email 2 (Value): [OPEN RATE]% open, [REPLY RATE]% reply
>
> Email 3 (Social Proof): [OPEN RATE]% open, [REPLY RATE]% reply
>
> Email 4 (Objection): [OPEN RATE]% open, [REPLY RATE]% reply
>
> Email 5 (Breakup): [OPEN RATE]% open, [REPLY RATE]% reply
>
> Overall conversion (prospect → next step): [RATE]%
>
> Here are the subject lines I used:
>
> [LIST SUBJECT LINES AND THEIR OPEN RATES]
>
> Here are the 3 emails that got the most replies:
>
> [PASTE EMAILS]
>
> And the 3 that got zero replies:
>
> [PASTE EMAILS]
>
> Analyze what's working and what's not. Provide specific recommendations for:
>
> 1. Subject line improvements for low-performing emails
>
> 2. Content/structure changes for emails with low reply rates
>
> 3. Timing adjustments (should I space emails differently?)
>
> 4. Any emails that should be replaced entirely

Advanced Techniques

Multi-Channel Sequences

Don't limit yourself to email. The most effective follow-up sequences mix channels:

Day 0: Email 1 (Recap)

Day 2: LinkedIn comment on their recent post

Day 3: Email 2 (Value)

Day 7: Email 3 (Social Proof)

Day 8: LinkedIn message (brief, personal)

Day 12: Email 4 (Objection)

Day 14: Phone call

Day 21: Email 5 (Breakup)

> Prompt — LinkedIn Touchpoint

>

> Write a brief LinkedIn message (max 100 words) to send between follow-up emails.

>

> Context:
>
> - We had a meeting about [TOPIC] on [DATE]
>
> - I've sent [NUMBER] follow-up emails, [WITH/WITHOUT] response
>
> - Their recent LinkedIn activity: [PASTE ANY RECENT POSTS OR ARTICLES THEY SHARED]

>

> The message should:
>
> - Reference their recent LinkedIn activity if possible
>
> - Be conversational and human
>
> - NOT pitch or ask for a meeting
>
> - Create a reason for them to respond naturally
>
> - Feel like something a real person would send, not a sales automation

Re-Engagement Sequences

For prospects who went cold months ago:

Prompt — Re-Engagement Email

Prompt — Re-Engagement Email

>

> Write a re-engagement email to a prospect who went cold [TIMEFRAME] ago.

>

> Original context:
>
> - Name: [NAME]
>
> - Company: [COMPANY]
>
> - What we discussed: [SUMMARY]
>
> - Why they likely went cold: [YOUR GUESS: timing, budget, priorities, etc.]

>

> The email should:
>
> - Acknowledge the time gap naturally (no guilt, no "sorry to bother you")
>
> - Offer a legitimate reason for reaching out (new feature, relevant news, industry change, new case study)
>
> - Respect their intelligence — they know it's a sales email
>
> - Give them an easy way to re-engage OR a graceful way to opt out

>

> Max 120 words.

Common Pitfalls

Sending obviously templated emails. If 10 prospects received identical emails, you're doing it wrong. The Prospect Brief step exists for a reason — use it.

Following up too aggressively. 5 emails over 3 weeks is a sequence. 5 emails in 5 days is spam. Space them out.

Only following up by email. Email is one channel. A LinkedIn comment + phone call + email combination is 3x more effective than 3 emails.

Not knowing when to stop. After the breakup email, stop. If they don't respond to 5 thoughtful touchpoints, they're not interested right now. Add them to a quarterly re-engagement list and move on.

Forgetting the human element. AI writes the emails. You build the relationships. The best follow-up in the world won't save a bad product or a bad first meeting. AI amplifies what's already working.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should have:

- A 5-email follow-up sequence template customized to your business
- A system that generates personalized sequences in 15 minutes per prospect
- No leads falling through the cracks
- 2-3x higher response rates compared to generic follow-ups
- Clear data on what messaging works (so you keep getting better)

The real ROI: If your average deal is worth €5,000 and better follow-up converts just 2 more deals per quarter, that's €40,000/year in additional revenue from a system that takes 30 minutes per week to maintain. Even for smaller deal sizes, recovering lost leads through consistent follow-up is almost always the highest-ROI activity in a small business.

Chapter 12

Playbook: Expense Categorization

What This Playbook Does

Expense management is the tax that every business pays in time. Receipts pile up in wallets, email inboxes, and phone photo libraries. At the end of the month (or worse, at the end of the quarter), someone has to sort through them all, categorize each one, match it to a budget line, and get it into the accounting system.

This playbook shows you how to use AI to automatically categorize expenses from receipts, bank statements, and invoices — reducing a full-day monthly ordeal to 30 minutes of review.

Time to implement: 2–3 hours for initial setup, then 30 minutes per month for review.

Expected time savings: 4–8 hours per month (depending on volume).

Tools needed:

- An AI assistant: ChatGPT (with vision/image capability), Claude, or any LLM
- A spreadsheet: Google Sheets or Excel (free)
- A photo/scanning app: Your phone's camera, Adobe Scan (free), or Genius Scan (free)
- Optional: An OCR tool for batch processing (Google Drive's built-in OCR is free)
- Optional: An accounting tool like QuickBooks, Xero, or Wave (Wave is free)

Why This Is Perfect for AI

Expense categorization has three properties that make it ideal for automation:

1. It's repetitive. The same types of expenses recur every month.
2. It's rule-based. Most categorization follows simple rules: office supplies go in one bucket, travel in another.
3. It requires judgment on edge cases. Is that €45 at a restaurant a "meals & entertainment" expense or a "client meeting" expense? Context matters — and AI can use context.

The human bottleneck isn't the categorization itself — it's the data entry. Pulling information from receipts, typing it into a spreadsheet, and deciding which category fits. AI handles all three.

Step-by-Step Process

Step 1: Define Your Expense Categories (15 minutes)

Before AI can categorize anything, you need to tell it your categories. If you already have an accounting system, export your chart of accounts. If not, start with this prompt:

> Prompt — Category Setup
>
> I run a [TYPE OF BUSINESS] with [NUMBER] employees. Create a practical expense category structure for my business.
>
> Include:
>
> 1. Category name — clear, intuitive label
> 2. Description — what belongs in this category
> 3. Examples — 3-5 specific examples of expenses in this category
> 4. Tax relevance — note if this category has specific tax implications (e.g., deductible, partially deductible, non-deductible) [NOTE: specify your country for tax rules]
>
> Categories should be specific enough to be useful but not so granular that every purchase needs its own category. Aim for 12-20 categories.
>
> My main expense types are:
>
> [LIST YOUR COMMON EXPENSES — e.g., "office supplies, software subscriptions, client meals, travel, fuel, contractor payments, insurance"]

Save this as your Category Reference Document. You'll include it in every categorization prompt.

Step 2: Set Up Your Receipt Capture System (20 minutes)

The first step to automating categorization is getting receipts into digital format consistently.

Choose one approach:

Option A — Photo to Drive (Simplest):

1. Create a folder in Google Drive called "Receipts - [Month]"
2. When you get a receipt, photograph it with your phone
3. Upload to the folder (Google Drive app makes this one tap)
4. Google Drive automatically OCRs images, making text searchable

Option B — Dedicated Scanning App:

1. Install Adobe Scan or Genius Scan (free)
2. Scan receipts as they come in
3. App auto-crops, enhances, and extracts text
4. Export weekly as PDF or text

Option C — Email Forwarding:

1. Create a dedicated email alias: receipts@yourdomain.com
2. Forward digital receipts to this address
3. For physical receipts, photograph and email to the same address
4. Process weekly from this inbox

The golden rule: Capture receipts within 24 hours. The longer you wait, the more receipts get lost.

Step 3: Extract Data from Receipts (Batch Processing)

For Individual Receipts (with AI Vision):

If your AI tool supports image input (ChatGPT-4, Claude with vision), you can process receipts directly from photos:

> Prompt — Single Receipt Extraction

>

> Extract the following information from this receipt image:

>

> 1. Vendor/Store name
> 2. Date
> 3. Total amount (including currency)
> 4. Tax amount (if shown separately)

5. Payment method (if visible: cash, card ending in XXXX, etc.)

5. Payment method (if visible: cash, card ending in XXXX, etc.)

> 6. Items purchased (list each line item with amount if legible)
>
> 7. Suggested category based on these categories:
>
> [PASTE YOUR CATEGORY LIST]
>
> 8. Confidence level for the suggested category (high/medium/low)
>
> 9. Notes — anything unusual or worth flagging

>

> If any field is unreadable, mark it as [UNCLEAR] rather than guessing.

>

> [ATTACH RECEIPT IMAGE]

For Batch Processing (Bank Statement Method):

This is more efficient for monthly processing. Export your bank/credit card statement as CSV, then:

> Prompt — Bank Statement Categorization

>

> Here is my bank statement for [MONTH]. Categorize each transaction using the following categories:

>

> Categories:
>
> [PASTE YOUR CATEGORY LIST WITH DESCRIPTIONS]

>

> Rules:
>
> - If a vendor appears multiple times, categorize consistently
>
> - Flag any transaction over €[THRESHOLD] for manual review
>
> - Flag any transaction that could belong to multiple categories
>
> - Mark recurring subscriptions as "Subscription" sub-type
>
> - Ignore transfers between my own accounts

>

> Output as a table with columns:
>
> Date | Description | Amount | Category | Sub-category | Confidence | Flag

>

> Bank statement data:
>
> [PASTE CSV DATA]

Step 4: Build Your Vendor-Category Mapping (30 minutes, then maintained automatically)

After processing your first month, AI will have categorized 50-100 transactions. Many of the same vendors will repeat. Create a mapping file:

> Prompt — Vendor Mapping Generator
>
> Based on these categorized transactions, create a vendor-to-category mapping table for recurring vendors.
>
> Only include vendors that appear 2+ times or are clearly regular expenses (subscriptions, utilities, etc.).
>
> Format:
>
> | Vendor Name (as it appears on statements) | Category | Sub-category | Notes |
>
> Also list any vendor name variations that should be treated as the same vendor (e.g., "AMZN*" and "Amazon.com" and "AMAZON MARKETPLACE" → all "Amazon").
>
> Transactions:
>
> [PASTE ALL CATEGORIZED TRANSACTIONS]

Save this mapping. Include it in future categorization prompts so AI automatically uses your established patterns:

> Prompt Addition — Vendor Mapping (add to any categorization prompt)
>
> Before categorizing, check this vendor mapping for known vendors. Use the established category. Only categorize manually for new/unknown vendors.
>
> Known vendor mapping:
>
> [PASTE VENDOR MAPPING TABLE]

Step 5: Review and Approve (30 minutes per month)

AI categorization is 85-95% accurate for recurring expenses and 70-85% accurate for new vendors. Your job is to review, not redo.

Review process:

1. Sort the output by "Confidence" column — review "low" confidence items first
2. Check all "Flagged" items
3. Scan "high confidence" items briefly — are any obviously wrong?
4. Fix any miscategorizations
5. Update your vendor mapping with any new recurring vendors

> Prompt — Monthly Expense Summary

>

> Based on these categorized expenses for [MONTH], generate:

>

> 1. Category summary — Total spent per category, sorted by amount
>
> 2. Month-over-month comparison — If I provide last month's data, show % change per category
>
> 3. Anomalies — Any categories significantly higher or lower than usual
>
> 4. Top 10 vendors — Biggest spending by vendor
>
> 5. Subscription audit — List all recurring charges identified, with monthly cost
>
> 6. Tax-relevant summary — Group expenses by tax treatment (fully deductible, partially deductible, non-deductible)

>

> This month's data:
>
> [PASTE CATEGORIZED TRANSACTIONS]

>

> Last month's data (optional):
>
> [PASTE LAST MONTH'S DATA]

Step 6: Export to Your Accounting System (15 minutes)

Once reviewed, format the data for your accounting tool:

> Prompt — Accounting Export Formatter

>

> Format these categorized expenses for import into [QUICKBOOKS / XERO / WAVE / OTHER].

>

> Required format:

[PASTE YOUR ACCOUNTING TOOL'S IMPORT FORMAT — usually Date, Description, Amount,

Category/Account, Tax Code]

[PASTE YOUR ACCOUNTING TOOL'S IMPORT FORMAT — usually Date, Description, Amount,

Category/Account, Tax Code]

>

> Also generate a simple journal entry summary for this month, grouping by category.

>

> Data:
>
> [PASTE REVIEWED EXPENSES]

Building the Monthly Routine

Here's what expense management looks like after setup:

Daily (2 minutes):

- Photograph any physical receipts → upload to your receipt folder

Weekly (10 minutes):

- Forward any digital receipts to your receipts email/folder
- Quick scan: anything unusual this week?

Monthly (30 minutes):

1. Export bank/card statement as CSV
2. Run the batch categorization prompt (with vendor mapping)
3. Review flagged and low-confidence items
4. Generate monthly summary
5. Export to accounting system
6. Update vendor mapping if needed

Handling Edge Cases

Mixed-Purpose Expenses

Some expenses serve multiple purposes (e.g., a laptop used 70% for business, 30% personal):

Prompt — Split Expense Handler

Prompt — Split Expense Handler

>

> This expense needs to be split across categories:

>

> - Expense: [DESCRIPTION]
> - Total amount: [AMOUNT]
> - Split rationale: [e.g., "70% business use, 30% personal" or "50% marketing, 50% product development"]

>

> Generate the split entries for my expense tracking, including:
> - Separate line items for each portion
> - The business justification for the split
> - Any tax implications of the split in [YOUR COUNTRY]

Foreign Currency

> Prompt — Currency Conversion

>

> These expenses are in foreign currencies. Convert to [YOUR CURRENCY] using the exchange rate from the transaction date.

>

> Expenses:
> [DATE] [AMOUNT] [CURRENCY] — [DESCRIPTION]

>

> For each, provide:
> - Original amount and currency
> - Exchange rate (date-specific)
> - Converted amount in [YOUR CURRENCY]
> - Category assignment

Receipt OCR Failures

When a receipt is too faded, crumpled, or blurry for AI to read:

1. Try a dedicated OCR app (Adobe Scan has better image enhancement than general AI)

2. If still unreadable, enter manually with this minimum data:
   - Approximate date
   - Vendor (if you remember)
   - Amount (check your bank statement)
   - Category (your best guess)
3. Mark as "Manual entry — receipt quality poor" for audit trail

---

Common Pitfalls

Not capturing receipts immediately. The #1 reason expense tracking fails is lost receipts. Build the habit: receipt → photo → upload. Takes 30 seconds.

Over-granular categories. If you have 50 categories, you'll spend more time debating categorization than the system saves. 12-20 categories is the sweet spot.

Trusting AI blindly on tax-relevant categorization. AI doesn't know your specific tax situation. Always review the tax-relevant summary with your accountant, especially in the first few months.

Not maintaining the vendor mapping. This is your secret weapon for accuracy. Update it monthly and your accuracy rate climbs toward 95%+.

Procrastinating the monthly review. The whole point of this system is to make expense management quick and painless. If you let it pile up to quarterly, you've defeated the purpose.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should have:

- A consistent receipt capture system (daily habit, takes seconds)
- Automated categorization that's 85-95% accurate
- Monthly expense review that takes 30 minutes instead of 4-8 hours
- Clean data for your accountant (saving them time = saving you money)
- Monthly spending insights you actually look at

The real ROI: Beyond time savings, the biggest value is often what you discover. The monthly summary

prompt regularly reveals forgotten subscriptions (€15/month you stopped using 6 months ago), spending patterns you didn't notice (eating out costs 3x what you thought), and tax deductions you might have missed. One €50/month subscription you cancel pays for the time investment many times over.

Chapter 13

Playbook: Report Generator

What This Playbook Does

Every week, someone in your business exports a spreadsheet, stares at rows of numbers, and tries to figure out what they mean. Then they spend an hour or more turning those numbers into a report that a human can actually understand. Charts get made. Paragraphs get written. The same format gets recreated from scratch every time.

This playbook shows you how to feed raw data — sales figures, website analytics, project updates, financial statements, survey results — into AI and get back polished, insight-driven reports in minutes instead of hours.

Time to implement: 1–2 hours for your first report template, then 15–30 minutes per report after that.

Expected time savings: 2–5 hours per report (depending on complexity).

Tools needed:

- An AI assistant: ChatGPT, Claude, or any capable LLM (free tiers work)
- Your raw data source: spreadsheet, dashboard export, or database report
- A presentation tool (if needed): Google Slides, PowerPoint, or Canva
- Optional: Google Sheets / Excel for chart generation

Why Reports Are Perfect for AI

Traditional report writing has three bottlenecks:

1. Data interpretation — What do these numbers actually mean?
2. Narrative construction — How do I explain this to someone who hasn't seen the data?
3. Formatting — Making it look professional and consistent

AI handles all three. It can identify trends, calculate changes, flag anomalies, and write clear narratives —

all from raw numbers. Your job shifts from "creating the report" to "verifying the insights and adding strategic context."

Step-by-Step Process

Step 1: Define Your Report Template (30 minutes, one-time per report type)

Every recurring report should have a template. This ensures consistency and makes AI output predictable.

> Prompt — Report Template Builder
>
> I need to create a recurring [FREQUENCY: weekly/monthly/quarterly] report for [AUDIENCE: my team / the board / clients / investors].
>
> The report covers: [TOPIC — e.g., "sales performance," "marketing metrics," "project status," "financial overview"]
>
> Design a report template with:
>
> 1. Report title format — including dynamic elements (date range, period)
> 2. Executive summary section — 3-5 sentences that capture the most important takeaways
> 3. Key metrics dashboard — The 5-8 most important numbers to highlight, with:
> - Metric name
> - Current value
> - Comparison (vs. last period, vs. target)
> - Status indicator (↑ ↓ → or)
> 4. Detailed sections — What topics to cover in depth (3-5 sections)
> 5. Insights & recommendations — What actions should this report suggest?
> 6. Appendix — Raw data tables for reference
>
> The audience is [TECHNICAL LEVEL: executive / manager / technical team]. They care most about [WHAT THEY WANT TO KNOW]. Keep the main body under [LENGTH: 1 page / 2 pages / 5 pages].

>

> Also specify what data I need to collect to generate this report.

Step 2: Prepare Your Data (10 minutes)

AI works best with structured data. Get your numbers into a clean format:

Option A — Spreadsheet export:

Export your data as CSV or copy-paste the table. Include headers.

Option B — Dashboard screenshot:

If your data lives in a dashboard (Google Analytics, HubSpot, Stripe), export or screenshot it. For AI with vision capability, screenshots work directly. Otherwise, copy key numbers manually.

Option C — Text summary:

If data comes from multiple sources, write a quick text summary:

```
Sales this month: €42,500 (target: €50,000)
New customers: 23 (vs 31 last month)
Churn: 4 customers (vs 2 last month)
Top product: Widget Pro (€18,000, 42% of revenue)
Pipeline: €78,000 (12 deals)
```

Data preparation tips:

- Always include comparison data (previous period, target, year-ago)
- Include context for unusual numbers (e.g., "Q3 is always slow due to holidays")
- Flag any known data quality issues ("CRM wasn't updated for the first week")

Step 3: Generate the Report (15 minutes)

Use your template with the current data:

> Prompt — Report Generator (Master)

>

> Generate a [FREQUENCY] [REPORT TYPE] report for [DATE RANGE] using the template and data below.

>

> Report template:
>
> [PASTE YOUR TEMPLATE FROM STEP 1]

>

> Current period data:
>
> [PASTE DATA]

>

> Previous period data (for comparison):
>
> [PASTE DATA]

>

> Targets/goals:
>
> [PASTE TARGETS]

>

> Known context:
>
> [ANY CONTEXT — e.g., "We launched a new product mid-month" or "One sales rep was on leave for 2 weeks"]

>

> Writing guidelines:
>
> - Use specific numbers, not vague descriptions ("Revenue grew 12% to €42,500" not "Revenue saw healthy growth")
>
> - Lead with the most important finding in the executive summary
>
> - Highlight both wins and concerns — don't sugarcoat
>
> - Keep recommendations actionable and specific
>
> - Use [AUDIENCE's] language — [e.g., "no technical jargon" or "assume familiarity with SaaS metrics"]
>
> - Format with headers, bullet points, and bold key numbers for scanability

Step 4: Add Visualizations (15 minutes)

AI can describe what charts to create. You then build them in your preferred tool:

> Prompt — Chart Recommendations

>

> Based on this report data, recommend 3-5 charts/visualizations that would make the key findings clearer.

>

> For each visualization:
>
> 1. Chart type (bar, line, pie, etc.)
>
> 2. What it shows — the specific insight it communicates

3. Data to include — exact columns/rows to use

> 3. Data to include — exact columns/rows to use
>
> 4. Title — a descriptive title that conveys the insight (not just "Revenue Chart" but "Revenue Trending 12% Below Q4 Target")
>
> 5. Placement — where in the report it should go

>

> Report data:
>
> [PASTE DATA]

Quick chart creation:

- Google Sheets: Paste data → select → Insert → Chart (30 seconds per chart)
- Canva: Use their chart templates with your numbers
- AI tools like ChatGPT with Code Interpreter can generate charts directly from data

Step 5: Generate the Executive Summary Last (5 minutes)

Even though the executive summary appears first in the report, generate it last — after you've reviewed all sections:

> Prompt — Executive Summary

>

> Write a 3-5 sentence executive summary for this report. Rules:

>

> 1. First sentence: The single most important finding (good or bad)
>
> 2. Second sentence: The key supporting evidence
>
> 3. Third sentence: The primary risk or opportunity
>
> 4. Fourth sentence (if needed): Recommended immediate action

>

> The reader should be able to read ONLY this summary and understand the current situation.

>

> Full report:
>
> [PASTE COMPLETED REPORT]

Report Templates for Common SME Reports

Weekly Sales Report

> Prompt — Weekly Sales Report

>

> Generate a weekly sales report for [DATE RANGE]:

>

> Data:
>
> [PASTE: deals won, deals lost, pipeline changes, activity metrics]

>

> Include:
>
> - Revenue vs. target (weekly and MTD)
> - Win/loss analysis (why we won, why we lost)
> - Pipeline health (total value, movement, aging)
> - Rep performance (if applicable)
> - Top 3 deals to watch this week
> - One specific recommendation for next week

Monthly Financial Summary

> Prompt — Monthly Financial Summary

>

> Generate a monthly financial summary for [MONTH]:

>

> Data:
>
> [PASTE: revenue, expenses by category, cash position, accounts receivable, accounts payable]

>

> Include:
>
> - P&L summary (revenue, costs, gross margin, net profit)
> - Revenue breakdown by source/product
> - Expense breakdown by category with variance vs. budget
> - Cash flow snapshot (starting balance, in, out, ending balance)
> - Key ratios (gross margin %, burn rate, runway if applicable)
> - 3-month trend for major line items
> - Flags: any category over budget, any receivables overdue

Monthly Marketing Report

> Prompt — Monthly Marketing Report

>

> Generate a monthly marketing performance report for [MONTH]:

>

> Data:
>
> [PASTE: website traffic, lead sources, conversion rates, email metrics, social media metrics, ad spend and results]

>

> Include:
>
> - Traffic overview (total, by source, vs. last month)
> - Lead generation (total leads, cost per lead, quality assessment)
> - Channel performance (rank channels by ROI)
> - Content performance (top pages, top posts)
> - Email metrics (list growth, open rates, click rates)
> - Ad performance (spend, clicks, conversions, CPA)
> - Recommendations: what to double down on, what to cut

Quarterly Business Review

> Prompt — Quarterly Business Review

>

> Generate a quarterly business review for [QUARTER]:

>

> Data:
>
> [PASTE: quarterly financials, key metrics, project status, team updates]

>

> Include:
>
> - Quarter-over-quarter performance summary
> - Progress against annual goals (% complete, on track / at risk / behind)
> - Key wins this quarter (with specifics)
> - Key challenges and how they were addressed
> - Customer metrics (acquisition, retention, satisfaction)
> - Team/operational updates

- Strategic priorities for next quarter (max 3-5)

- Strategic priorities for next quarter (max 3-5)

> - Resource needs or budget requests

Project Status Report

> Prompt — Project Status Report

>

> Generate a project status report for [PROJECT NAME]:

>

> Data:
>
> [PASTE: milestones, tasks completed, tasks pending, timeline, budget spent, issues]

>

> Include:
>
> - Overall status: On Track / At Risk / Off Track
> - Progress vs. plan (what was supposed to happen vs. what did)
> - Completed this period
> - Planned for next period
> - Blockers and risks (with proposed mitigations)
> - Budget status (spent vs. allocated)
> - Decisions needed from stakeholders
> - Timeline impact (any changes to the completion date?)

Advanced Techniques

Automated Data Pipeline

For recurring reports, minimize manual data work:

1. Set up automatic exports: Most tools (Google Analytics, HubSpot, Stripe, QuickBooks) can email you a CSV report on a schedule
2. Create a template spreadsheet: One tab for data paste, one tab for AI-ready output with formulas that calculate period-over-period changes
3. Use a standardized data format: Always same column headers, same date format, same

currency notation

Comparative Analysis

> Prompt — Period Comparison

>

> Compare these two periods and identify the most significant changes:

>

> Period 1 ([DATE RANGE]): [PASTE DATA]
>
> Period 2 ([DATE RANGE]): [PASTE DATA]

>

> For each metric:
>
> - Calculate the absolute and percentage change
>
> - Rate the significance (major / minor / negligible)
>
> - Provide a likely explanation for major changes
>
> - Flag any metrics that changed direction (positive → negative or vice versa)

>

> Rank the findings by business impact, most important first.

Anomaly Detection

> Prompt — Anomaly Detection

>

> Review this data for anomalies — anything that deviates significantly from the pattern.

>

> Historical data (last 6 months):
>
> [PASTE HISTORICAL DATA]

>

> Current period:
>
> [PASTE CURRENT DATA]

>

> Identify:
>
> 1. Any metric more than 20% above or below its 6-month average
>
> 2. Any sudden trend reversal

3. Any metric hitting an all-time high or low

> 3. Any metric hitting an all-time high or low
> 4. Any unusual correlations between metrics

>

> For each anomaly, rate:
>
> - Severity (high / medium / low)
>
> - Likely cause
>
> - Recommended action

Building a Reporting Rhythm

Report	Frequency	Time Required	Audience
Sales update	Weekly	15 min	Sales team + management
Financial summary	Monthly	30 min	Owner + accountant
Marketing report	Monthly	25 min	Marketing + management
Project status	Biweekly	15 min	Project team + stakeholders
Business review	Quarterly	45 min	Leadership + board/investors

Total monthly reporting time: ~3 hours (vs. 15-20 hours doing it manually)

Common Pitfalls

Presenting AI output without verification. Always verify the numbers. AI can miscalculate, misinterpret, or hallucinate data points. Spot-check at least 3-4 key numbers against your source data.

Reports without recommendations. A report that says "revenue is down 15%" without saying "here's why and here's what to do about it" is only half useful. Always include the "so what?" and "now what?"

Too many metrics. Executive reports should highlight 5-8 key metrics. If you're showing 30 numbers, nothing stands out. The detailed data belongs in an appendix.

Same format for different audiences. Your board wants strategy and trends. Your team wants tactics and next steps. Use different prompts for different audiences, even from the same data.

Not building on previous reports. Reference last month's findings. "Last month we flagged rising

customer acquisition costs. This month, they've stabilized at €45/customer after implementing the referral program." This continuity makes reports dramatically more valuable.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should have:

- Report templates for your 2-3 most important recurring reports
- A data preparation workflow that takes minutes, not hours
- Consistent, professional reports that actually get read
- Time to focus on strategic interpretation rather than data formatting
- Historical reports you can compare to track trends over time

The real ROI: Reports drive decisions. A clear, insightful monthly report that highlights an underperforming product line or a growing customer segment doesn't just save reporting time — it leads to better business decisions. The difference between good and bad data presentation is often the difference between catching a problem early and discovering it too late.

Chapter 14

Playbook: Contract Review Assistant

What This Playbook Does

Contracts are dense. A 6-page vendor agreement, 12-page SaaS terms, or a 3-page NDA can hide critical obligations in passive voice or buried clauses. Lawyers are expensive. Business owners are busy. This playbook shows you a practical, repeatable way to use AI to review contracts quickly, extract the important bits, flag risks, and prepare short, negotiation-ready notes you can share with counsel or use to negotiate directly.

Time to implement: 30–90 minutes per contract (depending on complexity).

Expected time savings: 1–3 hours per contract versus starting from scratch; more if you use counsel only for high-risk items.

Tools needed:

- An AI assistant (ChatGPT, Claude, or other LLM with strong instruction-following)
- A PDF reader or text-extraction tool (Adobe Reader, or OCR for scanned PDFs)
- Optional: Annotations tool (Hypothesis, Kami, or simple PDF comments)
- Optional: Contract lifecycle management (CLM) or a shared drive for storing reviewed contracts

The Contract Review Mindset

Your goal is not to become a lawyer. Your goal is to:

1. Understand obligations, dates, and money flows
2. Identify commercial risks and non-standard terms
3. Produce a short, prioritized negotiation checklist
4. Know which items need legal input and which are business decisions

Contracts naturally contain legalese. You should extract meaning, not rewrite the law. AI helps by translating dense wording into plain language and by applying your business priorities consistently.

Step-by-Step: From Contract to Negotiation Notes

Step 1: Prepare the Contract Text (5–10 minutes)

If you have a text-based PDF, copy the full text. If the PDF is scanned or an image, run OCR (Adobe, Google Drive, or any OCR tool) and save the extracted text. Save the contract to a central folder: Contracts/Incoming/YYYY-MM.

Why this matters: AI works best with selectable text. Clean input reduces hallucination risk.

Step 2: High-Level Read & Executive Summary (10 minutes)

Open the contract and skim the structure: headings, term length, payment schedules, termination, IP clauses, warranties, limitations of liability.

Use this prompt to get a quick plain-language summary:

> Prompt — Executive Summary (Quick Read)
>
> You are a business-savvy contract reviewer, not a lawyer. Read the following contract text and provide:
>
> 1. A 5-sentence plain-language executive summary covering: what this contract is, the main deliverables/obligations, who pays whom and when, contract length and renewal terms, and how it ends.
>
> 2. The five clauses I should read more carefully (list by section heading or by quoting the clause's first line).
>
> 3. One-sentence assessment of whether this contract is low/medium/high risk for a small business like ours (explain why).
>
> Contract text:
>
> [PASTE CONTRACT TEXT]

This gives you immediate orientation before deep-diving.

Step 3: Extract Key Commercial Terms (10 minutes)

Create a consistent summary table for the commercial facts — these are the things business teams

actually care about. Use this prompt:

> Prompt — Extract Commercial Terms

>

> Extract the following commercial terms from the contract and output as a table (field: value). If a field is not present or unclear, write [MISSING] or [UNCLEAR].

>

> - Party A (full legal name) — our side
> - Party B (full legal name) — counterparty
> - Effective date
> - Term length & renewal terms (auto-renew? notice required?)
> - Termination rights (for convenience / for cause) and notice periods
> - Payment terms (amounts, schedule, late fees)
> - Minimum commitments / SLAs
> - Deliverables / scope of work
> - Ownership of deliverables / IP assignment or license
> - Confidentiality obligations and duration
> - Data protection / GDPR / security requirements
> - Indemnities (who indemnifies whom and for what)
> - Limitation of liability (caps, exclusions)
> - Insurance requirements
> - Subcontracting / assignment clauses
> - Change control / amendment requirements
> - Governing law and dispute resolution

>

> Contract text:
>
> [PASTE CONTRACT TEXT]

This outputs a business-ready snapshot you can paste into your CRM or deal file.

Step 4: Risk & Negotiation Checklist (15–30 minutes)

Now turn the contract into a prioritized, actionable negotiation list. Use this prompt to get an annotated checklist sorted by business impact:

> Prompt — Risk Assessment & Negotiation Priorities

>

> Review the contract and create a prioritized negotiation checklist for our commercial team. For each issue, include:

>

> 1. Short label (e.g., "Auto-renew—short notice")
> 2. Why it matters to the business (one sentence)
> 3. Suggested fallback position we should ask for (exact language where appropriate)
> 4. Severity: High / Medium / Low
> 5. Recommend whether to escalate to legal (Yes/No)

>

> Prioritize the items by severity and business impact. Use the contract text to justify each recommendation.

>

> Contract:
>
> [PASTE CONTRACT TEXT]

Examples of flags you might get back:

- High: Unlimited liability for all claims — ask to cap at 2x fees or exclude consequential damages
- High: Auto-renew every year with 30-day notice — ask for 60–90-day notice or opt-out clause
- Medium: Vague IP assignment — ask for clarity that pre-existing IP is excluded
- Low: Boilerplate assignment clause — usually acceptable unless you're preparing to sell the business

Step 5: Redline Suggestions (15–30 minutes)

If you plan to negotiate directly, ask AI to propose specific redline language. Provide both a short ask and a defensive alternative.

> Prompt — Proposed Contract Redlines

>

> For each negotiation item in the checklist, propose:
>
> - Concise suggested redline (one paragraph of contract text to replace the original clause)
>
> - A softer alternative phrasing if the counterparty resists
>
> - A one-sentence rationale we can use in negotiation

>

Include clause references or the original clause text for context.

Include clause references or the original clause text for context.

>

> Contract text:
>
> [PASTE CLAUSE OR CONTRACT]

Keep your redlines focused on commercial impact (money, dates, IP, liability, termination). Lawyers can polish the legal finesse later.

Step 6: Prepare a Negotiation Email / Talking Points (10–20 minutes)

Turn your checklist into a short email or talking points for the negotiation call. Use this prompt:

> Prompt — Negotiation Email Draft

>

> Write a brief, professional negotiation email to the counterparty. Tone: collaborative but firm. Include:

>

> - A one-sentence positive opening: reference the relationship or mutual benefit
>
> - Bullet list of 3–6 asks (prioritized) with one-line rationale for each
>
> - A suggested next step (phone call, redline exchange, timeline)

>

> Keep it under 250 words. Use plain language. Sign as [YOUR NAME], [TITLE].

>

> Our negotiation asks:
>
> [PASTE TOP 3-6 NEGOTIATION ITEMS FROM CHECKLIST]

This email doubles as an audit trail and a clear signal to the other side about what matters to you.

Step 7: Decide What Needs Legal Review (5–10 minutes)

Not every clause needs a lawyer. The checklist should include a column "Escalate to Legal: Yes/No". High-risk items typically include:

- Unlimited or very large liability exposure
- Complex IP assignments or joint ownership
- Large, long-term financial commitments
- Complex data protection obligations with real-world security requirements
- Unclear or onerous tax/withholding obligations

If you escalate, provide counsel with a short brief: executive summary, commercial terms table, prioritized checklist, and the redlines you suggest. This reduces lawyer time — and your bill.

Special Use Cases & Prompts

NDAs (Quick review)

NDAs are usually short. Focus on: definition of Confidential Information, exclusions (what's not confidential), duration, return/destroy obligations, and non-solicitation clauses.

> Prompt — NDA Quick Review

>

> Summarize this NDA in 6 bullet points: scope of confidential info, duration, exclusions, permitted disclosures, obligations on return, and remedies. Then flag any unusual or one-sided clauses.

>

> NDA text:
>
> [PASTE NDA TEXT]

SaaS Terms & Acceptable Use Policies (AUP)

SaaS terms often contain data and uptime commitments. Focus on data ownership, access to data, backups, uptime SLA credits, liability caps, and export of data upon termination.

> Prompt — SaaS Terms Checklist

>

> Review these SaaS terms and extract the following: data ownership, data portability on termination, SLA and uptime credits, maintenance windows, security certifications, liability cap, and backup frequency. Flag anything that is missing or unusually one-sided.

>

> Terms text:
>
> [PASTE TEXT]

Partnership & Revenue Share Agreements

Look at revenue split mechanics, reporting requirements, audit rights, termination triggers, exclusivity,

and IP rights. Money and reporting transparency are the critical elements.

> Prompt — Revenue Share Review

>

> Extract: revenue calculation formula, payment timing, reporting frequency, audit rights, clawback provisions, termination impact on revenue sharing, exclusivity, and confidentiality. Flag anything that could create ambiguity in payouts.

>

> Agreement text:
>
> [PASTE TEXT]

Practical Tips & Best Practices

1. Use consistent naming and storage: Contracts/Incoming, Contracts/Reviewed, Contracts/Executed.
2. Keep a contract register (spreadsheet) with key metadata: counterparty, effective date, renewal date, status, owner, next review.
3. Train your team: make the contract checklist part of the onboarding for sales and procurement.
4. Use version control: when you redline, keep both versions and a short negotiation log.
5. Keep negotiation asks short and commercial — cite business reasons, not legal theory.
6. Track negotiated changes: if you accept a concession, log it in the contract register and alert operations if it affects workflows.

Common Pitfalls

Ignoring the small print: A short clause about "data use" or "subcontractors" can create outsized operational risk.

Treating all contracts the same: A small NDA doesn't need deep review; a 3-year supply contract does.

Starting negotiations with a dense redline: Begin with a few prioritized asks that matter to the business. Large, exhaustive redlines kill momentum.

Not aligning internal stakeholders: If sales negotiates changes, accounting and operations must be aware of any altered payment terms or deliverables.

What Success Looks Like

After implementing this playbook, you should be able to:

- Turn a contract into a clear commercial summary in under 30 minutes
- Produce a prioritized negotiation checklist with suggested redlines
- Know what to escalate to legal and what to handle internally
- Save legal fees by focusing counsel on high-impact items
- Reduce surprises in operations by tracking exceptions and negotiated terms

The practical outcome: faster deals, fewer hidden obligations, and better risk management — without needing a lawyer for every signature.

Chapter 15

Building Your Automation Stack

How Tools Connect — And Where to Start

By now you've seen 12 different automation playbooks. Each one works on its own, but the real power comes when you connect them into a system.

This chapter shows you how to think about your automation stack — which tools to choose, how they fit together, and what order to build in.

The Three Layers of an Automation Stack

Think of your automation stack as three layers:

Layer 1: AI Tools (The Brains)

These do the thinking — drafting emails, summarizing documents, scoring leads.

Tool	Price	Best For
ChatGPT (Free)	€0	General text tasks, drafting, brainstorming
ChatGPT Plus	€20/mo	Faster responses, file uploads, advanced analysis
Claude	€0-20/mo	Long documents, nuanced writing, analysis
Google Gemini	€0-20/mo	Google Workspace integration, research
Microsoft Copilot	€30/user/mo	Office 365 integration

Start here. Pick one AI tool your team is comfortable with. Don't spread across three — consistency beats variety.

Layer 2: Automation Platforms (The Connectors)

These move data between tools automatically — "when X happens, do Y."

Tool	Price	Best For
Zapier	€0-20/mo	Beginners, widest app support (6,000+)
Make.com	€0-9/mo	Visual workflows, more complex logic
Power Automate	Included with Microsoft 365	Microsoft ecosystem
n8n	€0 (self-hosted)	Technical teams, full control
IFTTT	€0-3/mo	Simple triggers, IoT devices

Add this second. Once you have 2-3 manual AI workflows running, automate the triggers and handoffs.

Layer 3: Specialized Tools (The Specialists)

These handle specific jobs better than general AI.

Category	Free Option	Paid Option
Meeting notes	Google Docs + AI	Otter.ai (€8/mo), Fireflies.ai (€10/mo)
Social media	Buffer free tier	Buffer (€5/mo), Hootsuite (€19/mo)
Email marketing	MailerLite free	MailerLite paid (€9/mo)
Document processing	ChatGPT uploads	DocuSign, Adobe Acrobat AI
Accounting	Wave (free)	QuickBooks (€12/mo), Xero (€15/mo)
CRM	HubSpot free	HubSpot Starter (€15/mo)
Help desk	Freshdesk free	Zendesk (€19/agent/mo)

Add these last — only when the free/general approach isn't cutting it for a specific workflow.

Recommended Stacks by Budget

The €0 Stack (Pure Free Tier)

- AI: ChatGPT free or Claude free
- Automation: Zapier free (5 zaps) or Make.com free (1,000 ops)
- Email: MailerLite free
- CRM: HubSpot free
- Meetings: Google Meet + manual AI summary
- Social: Buffer free

Best for: Solo operators and micro-businesses testing the waters.

Limitations: Manual triggers, limited automation runs, slower AI responses.

The €50/month Stack (Best Value)

- AI: ChatGPT Plus (€20/mo)
- Automation: Zapier Starter (€20/mo) or Make.com Basic (€9/mo)
- Email: MailerLite Growing (€9/mo)
- Everything else: Free tiers

Best for: Small teams (2-10 people) ready to commit. This covers 80% of automation needs.

The €150/month Stack (Full Power)

- AI: ChatGPT Plus + Claude Pro (€40/mo)
- Automation: Zapier Professional (€50/mo)
- Meetings: Otter.ai Business (€17/mo)
- Social: Buffer Essentials (€5/mo)
- CRM: HubSpot Starter (€15/mo)
- Email: MailerLite Growing (€9/mo)
- Accounting: QuickBooks (€12/mo)

Best for: Teams of 10-50 with multiple departments automating simultaneously.

Integration Priorities — What to Connect First

Not all connections are equal. Here's the order that delivers the most value:

Priority 1: Email → CRM (Week 1)

When someone emails you, their details should automatically appear in your CRM. When you send a follow-up, it should be logged.

Why first: This is where leads and revenue live. Every missed follow-up is money lost.

Priority 2: Calendar → Meeting Notes (Week 2)

When a meeting ends, notes should be generated and shared automatically.

Why second: This saves time every single day and improves team accountability.

Priority 3: Forms/Website → Email Marketing (Week 3)

When someone signs up on your website, they should enter your email funnel automatically.

Why third: This is your growth engine. Manual follow-up doesn't scale.

Priority 4: Social Media → Scheduling (Week 4)

Batch-create content, schedule it, and let it run. Stop posting manually every day.

Why fourth: Time savings compound — 30 minutes saved daily is 10+ hours per month.

Priority 5: Finance → Reporting (Month 2)

Automate expense categorization, invoice processing, and monthly reports.

Why fifth: Important but not urgent. The first four priorities drive revenue and save daily time.

The Integration Map

Here's how a typical SME automation stack connects:

```
Website/Forms
↓
Email Marketing (MailerLite) ←→ CRM (HubSpot)
↓                                ↓
Lead Scoring (AI)          Sales Follow-up (AI)
↓                                ↓
Qualified Lead Alert        Email Sequence
↓
Sales Team (Slack/Email notification)

Calendar Events
↓
Meeting Recording
↓
AI Transcription + Notes
↓
Action Items → Task Manager

Content Creation (AI)
↓
Scheduling (Buffer)
```

```
↓
Social Platforms (LinkedIn, X, Facebook)

Receipts/Invoices
↓
AI Processing
↓
Accounting Software
↓
Monthly Reports (AI-generated)
```

Common Mistakes

1. Buying Too Many Tools at Once

Start with one or two automations working perfectly. Then expand. Most failed automation projects tried to do everything simultaneously.

2. Not Documenting Your Workflows

When you build an automation, write down what it does, what triggers it, and what happens if it fails. Future you (or your team) will thank you.

3. Ignoring Error Handling

Every automation will eventually fail — an API goes down, a format changes, a field is empty. Build in notifications for failures so they don't silently break.

4. Choosing Tools Your Team Won't Use

The best tool is the one people actually use. If your team lives in Google Workspace, don't force Microsoft tools. Meet them where they are.

5. Over-Automating

Not everything should be automated. If a process happens once a month and takes 10 minutes, the time to set up and maintain automation isn't worth it. Focus on daily and weekly tasks.

Your Action Plan

1. List your current tools — What does your team already use daily?
2. Pick one AI tool — Standardize on ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini
3. Start with the €0 stack — Free tiers only until you prove value
4. Build one automation per week — Using the playbooks in this guide
5. Upgrade tools only when free tiers limit you — Let usage drive spending, not excitement

---

Key Takeaway

Your automation stack should grow organically. Start simple, prove value, then invest. The companies that succeed with automation aren't the ones with the most tools — they're the ones who use fewer tools consistently well.

Next: Chapter 16 — Measuring and Improving Your Automations →

Chapter 16

Measuring & Improving

What Gets Measured Gets Improved

You've built automations. They're running. But are they actually working?

This chapter gives you a simple framework for measuring the impact of your automations, knowing when to improve them, and deciding when to move on to the next one.

The Four KPIs That Matter

You don't need a dashboard with 50 metrics. Track these four for each automation:

1. Time Saved Per Week

The most tangible metric. Before you automate, measure how long the manual process takes. After automation, measure what's left.

How to calculate:

> Manual time per occurrence × occurrences per week = weekly time cost

>

> Example: Writing customer emails manually takes 8 minutes each. You send ~30 per week.
>
> Manual: 8 min × 30 = 240 minutes = 4 hours/week
>
> With AI assistance: 2 min × 30 = 60 minutes = 1 hour/week
>
> Time saved: 3 hours/week

2. Cost Saved Per Month

Convert time saved into money. This is the number that gets leadership buy-in.

How to calculate:

> Hours saved per week × hourly labor cost × 4.33 weeks = monthly savings

>

> Example: 3 hours/week × €35/hour × 4.33 = €455/month
>
> Minus tool costs: €455 - €20 (ChatGPT Plus) = €435 net savings/month

3. Quality Score

Is the automated output as good as (or better than) manual? Rate on a simple 1-5 scale:

Score	Meaning
1	Unusable — needs complete rework
2	Poor — needs significant editing
3	Acceptable — needs minor tweaks
4	Good — ready to use with quick review
5	Excellent — better than manual output

Target: 3 or above. If you're consistently at 2 or below, the automation needs rework or the use case might not be suitable for AI.

4. Adoption Rate

What percentage of your team actually uses the automation?

How to calculate:

> Team members using it regularly ÷ team members who could use it × 100

>

> Example: 6 out of 8 team members use the email template system = 75% adoption

Target: 70% or above. Below 50% means there's a friction problem — the tool is too hard to use, people don't trust it, or they weren't trained properly.

The Measurement Cadence

Week 1-2: Baseline

Before launching an automation, document the current state:

- How long does the process take manually?
- How often does it happen?
- Who does it?
- What's the current quality level?

Week 3-4: Early Results

Two weeks after launching:

- Is anyone using it?
- What's the initial time savings?
- What complaints or issues have come up?
- What needs tweaking?

Month 2: Real Assessment

After a full month of use:

- Calculate actual time and cost savings
- Score quality
- Measure adoption
- Decide: keep, improve, or kill

Quarterly: Portfolio Review

Every 3 months, review all your automations together:

- Which ones deliver the most value?
- Which ones are underperforming?
- Where should you invest next?

The Improve-or-Move-On Decision

After measuring, you'll face a decision for each automation. Use this framework:

Keep and Scale (High Impact, High Adoption)

Signs:

- Time savings exceed expectations
- Team uses it without reminders
- Quality score is 4-5
- People ask to expand it to other areas

Action: Document it as an SOP, train new hires on it, look for ways to expand.

Improve (High Potential, Fixable Issues)

Signs:

- Good time savings but quality needs work
- Team uses it but complains about specific things
- Quality score is 2-3 but trending up
- The underlying process is clearly automatable

Action: Spend 2-4 hours refining prompts, adding templates, or improving the workflow. Set a 2-week deadline for reassessment.

Pivot (Wrong Approach, Right Problem)

Signs:

- The problem is real but your solution isn't working
- Low adoption despite training
- Quality score stuck at 2
- You keep manually overriding the automation

Action: Try a different tool or approach. Maybe the email drafting automation works better with Claude instead of ChatGPT. Maybe you need a specialized tool instead of general AI.

Kill (Low Impact or Wrong Problem)

Signs:

- Time savings are minimal (< 30 minutes/week)
- Nobody uses it even after training
- Quality score is consistently 1-2
- The process doesn't happen often enough to justify automation

Action: Turn it off. Remove the tools. Move your energy to the next opportunity. Killing a bad automation is a win — it frees up resources.

Common Measurement Mistakes

1. Not Measuring the Baseline

If you don't know how long something took manually, you can't prove automation helped. Always measure before you automate.

2. Only Measuring Time

Time saved is important, but quality and consistency matter too. An automation that saves 2 hours but produces worse output isn't a win.

3. Measuring Too Early

AI automations improve as you refine prompts and workflows. Don't judge results after 3 days. Give it at least 2 weeks of real use.

4. Ignoring Maintenance Cost

Every automation needs occasional attention — prompts need updating, tools change their APIs, new edge cases appear. Factor in 30 minutes/month per automation for maintenance.

5. Not Asking Users

The best measurement is often qualitative. Ask your team: "Does this make your job easier?" A confident "yes" is worth more than a spreadsheet.

The Continuous Improvement Loop

Automation isn't "set and forget." Use this monthly loop:

```
1. MEASURE
→ Check KPIs for each automation
→ Update your project tracker

2. IDENTIFY
→ Which automations underperform?
→ Where are people working around the automation?
→ What new processes could be automated?

3. IMPROVE
→ Refine prompts (most common improvement)
→ Update templates with real examples
→ Fix edge cases people report
→ Simplify steps that cause friction

4. EXPAND
→ Apply successful patterns to new areas
→ Train new team members
→ Increase automation depth (AI-assisted → fully automated)

5. REPEAT
→ Monthly for active automations
→ Quarterly for portfolio review
```

Your Automation Scorecard

Use this template to track all your automations at a glance:

Automation	Time Saved/Week	Monthly Value	Quality (1-5)	Adoption %	Status
Customer email drafts	3 hrs	€435	4	75%	Keep
Meeting notes	2 hrs	€290	4	90%	Keep
Social media posts	1.5 hrs	€218	3	60%	Improve
Expense categorization	1 hr	€145	3	50%	Improve
Lead scoring	0.5 hrs	€73	2	30%	Pivot

Total: 8 hours/week saved = €1,161/month in value from 5 automations.

The Compound Effect

Here's the math that makes automation transformative:

- Month 1: 1 automation → 3 hours/week saved → €435/month
- Month 2: 3 automations → 7 hours/week saved → €1,015/month
- Month 3: 5 automations → 12 hours/week saved → €1,740/month
- Month 6: 8 automations → 18 hours/week saved → €2,610/month

That's over €30,000/year in recovered time from about €50-150/month in tools.

The key: start small, measure everything, improve what works, kill what doesn't.

Final Thoughts

Automation is a practice, not a project. The businesses that get the most from AI aren't the ones with the best technology — they're the ones that systematically measure, improve, and expand.

Your first automation won't be perfect. Your fifth will be good. Your tenth will feel like magic.

Start with Chapter 3. Pick the playbook closest to your biggest pain point. Measure the baseline today. Implement this week. Measure again in two weeks.

Then do it again.

Thank you for reading the AI Automation Playbook for SMEs. For more resources, visit beornsco.github.io

Built by Beorns Co — practical AI tools for real businesses.

Bonus

Bonus: 50 Automation Prompt Templates

> Copy-paste these prompts directly into ChatGPT, Claude, or your AI tool of choice.
>
> Replace everything in [BRACKETS] with your specific details.

---

1. Customer Email Responses (Prompts 1–5)

Prompt 1 — Standard Customer Reply

```
You are a customer service agent for [COMPANY NAME], a [INDUSTRY] business.
A customer emailed about [ISSUE/TOPIC]. Draft a professional, friendly reply that:
- Acknowledges their concern
- Provides a clear resolution or next step
- Keeps the tone [WARM/FORMAL/CASUAL]
- Is under 150 words

Customer email:
[PASTE CUSTOMER EMAIL HERE]
```

Best for: Everyday customer inquiries where you need a quick, polished reply.

Prompt 2 — Complaint De-escalation

```
A customer is upset about [SPECIFIC COMPLAINT] with our [PRODUCT/SERVICE].
They've been a customer for [DURATION]. Write a de-escalation email that:
- Validates their frustration without admitting fault
- Offers [SPECIFIC REMEDY: refund/discount/replacement/escalation]
- Includes a concrete timeline for resolution
- Ends with a retention-focused closing

Their message:
[PASTE COMPLAINT HERE]
```

Best for: Angry customers where you need to save the relationship.

Prompt 3 — Order Status Update

```
Write a [SHIPPING DELAY/BACKORDER/PROCESSING] notification email for [COMPANY NAME].
Order details: [ORDER NUMBER], [PRODUCT], originally expected [DATE].
New expected date: [NEW DATE]. Reason: [BRIEF REASON].
Tone: [APOLOGETIC/MATTER-OF-FACT]. Include a [DISCOUNT CODE/GOODWILL GESTURE] if appropria
```

Best for: Proactive communication about order issues before customers complain.

Prompt 4 — Batch Email Classifier

```
I'm going to paste [NUMBER] customer emails. For each one, provide:
1. Priority: Urgent / Normal / Low
2. Category: [BILLING/TECHNICAL/SHIPPING/GENERAL/COMPLAINT]
3. Suggested response summary (1–2 sentences)
4. Estimated response time needed

Emails:
[PASTE EMAILS SEPARATED BY "---"]
```

Best for: Morning email triage — sorting a full inbox in minutes instead of hours.

Prompt 5 — Multilingual Customer Reply

```
Translate and adapt this customer service reply for a [LANGUAGE]-speaking customer.
Don't just translate — adapt the tone for [CULTURE/REGION] business norms.
Keep it professional but culturally appropriate.

Original English reply:
[PASTE YOUR ENGLISH REPLY]

Customer's original message (in [LANGUAGE]):
[PASTE THEIR MESSAGE]
```

Best for: SMEs with international customers who can't afford multilingual staff.

---

2. FAQ & Knowledge Base (Prompts 6–9)

Prompt 6 — FAQ Generator from Support History

```
Based on these [NUMBER] recent customer support conversations, identify the top 10 most co

Format each as:
**Q:** [Question as a customer would ask it]
**A:** [Answer in 2–3 sentences, plain language]
```

```
Support conversations:
[PASTE CONVERSATIONS OR SUMMARIES]
```

Best for: Building your first FAQ page from real customer data.

Prompt 7 — Knowledge Base Article

```
Write a knowledge base article for [TOPIC] aimed at [AUDIENCE: customers/employees/partner
Product/Service: [NAME AND BRIEF DESCRIPTION]
Include:
- Clear title and summary
- Step-by-step instructions (if applicable)
- Common pitfalls or mistakes
- Related articles to suggest: [LIST TOPICS]
Reading level: [BASIC/INTERMEDIATE/TECHNICAL]
```

Best for: Creating self-service docs that actually reduce support tickets.

Prompt 8 — FAQ Refresh & Gap Analysis

```
Here's our current FAQ page. Review it and:
1. Flag any answers that sound outdated or vague
2. Suggest 5 questions we're probably missing based on [INDUSTRY] norms
3. Rewrite any weak answers to be clearer
4. Add "Related:" links between connected questions

Current FAQ:
[PASTE FAQ CONTENT]

Our products/services: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION]
```

Best for: Quarterly FAQ audits to keep self-service content fresh.

Prompt 9 — Internal Wiki Entry

```
Write an internal knowledge base entry for our team about [PROCESS/TOOL/POLICY].
Context: We're a [SIZE] team in [INDUSTRY].
Include:
- When to use this process
- Step-by-step walkthrough
- Who to contact if something goes wrong: [NAME/ROLE]
- Last updated: [DATE]
Keep it scannable — bullet points over paragraphs.
```

Best for: Documenting tribal knowledge so it doesn't live in one person's head.

3. Lead Qualification (Prompts 10–13)

Prompt 10 — Lead Scoring from Form Submissions

```
Score these leads from 1–10 based on our ideal customer profile:
- Industry: [TARGET INDUSTRIES]
- Company size: [EMPLOYEE RANGE]
- Budget range: [BUDGET]
- Decision timeline: [TIMEFRAME]
- Pain points we solve: [LIST]

For each lead, provide: Score, Reasoning (1 line), Recommended next action.

Lead submissions:
[PASTE FORM DATA]
```

Best for: Prioritizing inbound leads when you can't follow up with everyone.

Prompt 11 — Discovery Call Prep

```
I have a sales call with [CONTACT NAME], [TITLE] at [COMPANY NAME].
They're in [INDUSTRY], roughly [SIZE] employees, found us via [SOURCE].
They mentioned interest in [PRODUCT/SERVICE].

Prepare:
1. 5 discovery questions tailored to their likely pain points
2. 3 potential objections and rebuttals
3. Relevant case study angles from [OUR INDUSTRY/SIMILAR CLIENTS]
4. Suggested next steps to propose
```

Best for: Walking into sales calls prepared instead of winging it.

Prompt 12 — Cold Outreach Personalization

```
Write a personalized cold email to [CONTACT NAME], [TITLE] at [COMPANY].
Research context: [PASTE LINKEDIN SUMMARY OR COMPANY INFO].
Our offer: [PRODUCT/SERVICE AND KEY BENEFIT].
Hook angle: [RECENT NEWS/PAIN POINT/INDUSTRY TREND].
Keep it under 100 words. No generic "I hope this finds you well."
CTA: [BOOK A CALL/REPLY/WATCH DEMO]
```

Best for: Personalizing outreach at scale without sounding like a template.

Prompt 13 — Lead Nurture Sequence

```
Create a 5-email nurture sequence for leads who [DOWNLOADED RESOURCE/ATTENDED WEBINAR/SIGN
Our product: [NAME AND VALUE PROP].
Target persona: [ROLE, INDUSTRY, PAIN POINTS].
Sequence timing: [DAYS BETWEEN EMAILS].
Each email should be under 150 words with one clear CTA.
Tone: [HELPFUL/AUTHORITATIVE/CASUAL].
```

Best for: Automating follow-up so warm leads don't go cold.

---

4. Meeting Notes & Action Items (Prompts 14–18)

Prompt 14 — Meeting Summary & Action Items

```
Summarize this meeting transcript into:
1. **Key Decisions** (bullet points)
2. **Action Items** (who, what, deadline)
3. **Open Questions** (unresolved issues)
4. **Next Meeting** (suggested agenda items)

Meeting context: [TEAM/CLIENT/PROJECT NAME], [DATE]
Attendees: [NAMES AND ROLES]

Transcript:
[PASTE TRANSCRIPT OR NOTES]
```

Best for: Turning rambling hour-long meetings into actionable 1-pagers.

Prompt 15 — Client Meeting Follow-Up Email

```
Based on this meeting summary, draft a follow-up email to [CLIENT NAME].
Tone: [PROFESSIONAL/FRIENDLY/FORMAL]
Include:
- Thank them for their time
- Recap the key points discussed
- List agreed-upon next steps with owners
- Propose next meeting date: [DATE/TIME OPTIONS]
- Attach reference to [DOCUMENT/PROPOSAL] if mentioned

Meeting notes:
[PASTE NOTES]
```

Best for: Sending follow-ups within 30 minutes of a call instead of 3 days.

Prompt 16 — Weekly Team Standup Summary

```
Compile these individual standup updates into a team summary.
Highlight:
- Blockers that need immediate attention
- Cross-team dependencies
- Items at risk of missing deadlines
- Wins worth celebrating

Format as a Slack/Teams-ready message under 300 words.

Individual updates:
[PASTE UPDATES FROM TEAM MEMBERS]
```

Best for: Managers who need a digest instead of reading every standup update.

Prompt 17 — Board/Investor Meeting Prep

```
Prepare a structured agenda and talking points for our [BOARD/INVESTOR/ADVISORY] meeting.
Company: [NAME], Stage: [SEED/SERIES A/GROWTH/SME]
Key metrics this period: [REVENUE, GROWTH, CHURN, etc.]
Challenges to address: [LIST]
Asks/decisions needed: [LIST]
Time allocated: [DURATION]
```

Best for: Making sure important meetings are focused and productive.

Prompt 18 — Meeting Transcript Cleanup

```
Clean up this rough meeting transcript. Fix grammar, remove filler words (um, uh, like, yo

Don't change the meaning — just make it professional and scannable.

Raw transcript:
[PASTE RAW TRANSCRIPT]
```

Best for: Making AI-generated transcripts from Otter.ai or Fireflies actually readable.

---

5. Document Processing (Prompts 19–22)

Prompt 19 — Invoice Data Extraction

```
Extract the following fields from this invoice:
- Vendor name
- Invoice number
- Date
- Due date
- Line items (description, quantity, unit price, total)
- Subtotal, tax, total
- Payment terms
- Bank/payment details

Output as a structured table. Flag anything that looks unusual or missing.

Invoice text:
[PASTE INVOICE TEXT OR OCR OUTPUT]
```

Best for: Processing vendor invoices without manual data entry.

Prompt 20 — Document Comparison

```
Compare these two versions of [DOCUMENT TYPE: contract/proposal/policy].
Highlight:
1. Added sections or clauses
2. Removed content
3. Changed wording (show old → new)
4. Potential impact of each change

Version 1:
[PASTE VERSION 1]

Version 2:
[PASTE VERSION 2]
```

Best for: Reviewing contract redlines or policy updates quickly.

Prompt 21 — Resume/CV Screening

```
Screen these [NUMBER] resumes against this job description.
For each candidate, rate fit (1–10) and provide:
- Key strengths for this role
- Potential concerns
- Interview question suggestions
- Recommendation: Advance / Maybe / Pass

Job description:
[PASTE JD]

Resumes:
[PASTE RESUMES SEPARATED BY "---"]
```

Best for: First-pass screening when you're drowning in applications.

Prompt 22 — Form/Survey Response Analysis

```
Analyze these [NUMBER] survey/form responses and provide:
1. Key themes and patterns (with frequency)
2. Sentiment breakdown (positive/neutral/negative)
3. Notable outlier responses
4. Top 3 actionable insights
5. Suggested follow-up actions

Survey topic: [TOPIC]
Responses:
[PASTE RESPONSES]
```

Best for: Making sense of customer feedback or employee surveys without a data analyst.

---

6. SOP Generator (Prompts 23–27)

Prompt 23 — SOP from Scratch

```
Create a Standard Operating Procedure for: [PROCESS NAME]
Department: [DEPARTMENT]
Performed by: [ROLE]
Frequency: [DAILY/WEEKLY/AS NEEDED]

Include:
1. Purpose and scope
2. Prerequisites/tools needed
3. Step-by-step instructions (numbered)
4. Decision points (if X, then Y)
5. Quality checks
6. Troubleshooting common issues
7. Version and last-updated date

Context about the process:
[DESCRIBE THE PROCESS IN YOUR OWN WORDS]
```

Best for: Turning "the way we've always done it" into a documented, trainable process.

Prompt 24 — SOP from Video/Walkthrough Notes

```
I recorded myself doing [TASK] and here are my rough notes/transcript.
Turn this into a clean, professional SOP that a new hire could follow independently.
Add any safety warnings or common mistakes you can infer.
Include screenshots placeholders where a visual would help: [SCREENSHOT: description].

My notes:
[PASTE ROUGH NOTES OR TRANSCRIPT]
```

Best for: Converting screen recordings or walkthroughs into written procedures.

Prompt 25 — Employee Onboarding Checklist

```
Create a [DURATION]-day onboarding checklist for a new [ROLE] at [COMPANY NAME].
Team: [TEAM/DEPARTMENT]
Tools they'll use: [LIST OF TOOLS]
Key people to meet: [NAMES AND ROLES]
Include:
- Day-by-day breakdown
- Setup tasks (accounts, equipment)
- Training milestones
- First deliverable expectations
- 30/60/90 day goals
```

Best for: Consistent onboarding that doesn't depend on who's training the new hire.

Prompt 26 — Process Optimization Review

```
Here's our current SOP for [PROCESS]. Review it and suggest:
1. Steps that could be automated (and with what tool)
2. Redundant or unnecessary steps
3. Missing steps or quality checks
4. Time estimates per step
5. Risk points where errors are most likely

Current SOP:
[PASTE SOP]

Tools available to us: [LIST YOUR CURRENT TOOLS]
```

Best for: Finding automation opportunities in existing processes.

Prompt 27 — Emergency/Incident Response Procedure

```
Create an incident response procedure for: [SCENARIO: data breach/server outage/customer d
Company: [NAME], Size: [EMPLOYEES], Industry: [INDUSTRY].
Include:
- Immediate actions (first 15 minutes)
```

```
- Escalation matrix (who to call and when)
- Communication templates (internal + external)
- Documentation requirements
- Post-incident review process
```

Best for: Being prepared for crises before they happen — not writing the playbook during one.

---

7. Content Repurposing (Prompts 28–31)

Prompt 28 — Blog Post to Multi-Format

```
Repurpose this blog post into:
1. LinkedIn post (under 1300 characters, hook + insight + CTA)
2. Twitter/X thread (5–7 tweets, each standalone)
3. Email newsletter blurb (3 paragraphs, casual tone)
4. Instagram caption (with emoji, hashtag suggestions)
5. Short-form video script (60 seconds, conversational)

Blog post:
[PASTE BLOG POST]
```

Best for: Getting 5x the mileage from every piece of content you create.

Prompt 29 — Podcast/Video to Blog Article

```
Turn this [PODCAST/VIDEO] transcript into a [WORD COUNT]-word blog article.
- Add a compelling headline and meta description
- Structure with H2/H3 headings
- Include key quotes from the conversation
- Add an introduction and conclusion not in the original
- SEO target keyword: [KEYWORD]
- Remove filler and keep only valuable insights

Transcript:
[PASTE TRANSCRIPT]
```

Best for: Turning long-form audio/video into searchable, shareable written content.

Prompt 30 — Case Study from Raw Notes

```
Write a customer case study based on these notes.
Client: [COMPANY/NAME] (get permission before publishing)
Industry: [INDUSTRY]
```

```
Challenge: [WHAT THEY STRUGGLED WITH]
Solution: [WHAT WE DID]
Results: [METRICS/OUTCOMES]

Format: Problem → Solution → Results → Quote → CTA
Length: [500–800 WORDS]
Include a suggested pull quote and headline.
```

Best for: Turning happy customer stories into sales tools.

Prompt 31 — Presentation to Document

```
Convert this slide deck content into a [FORMAT: whitepaper/blog post/executive summary/han
Add transitions, context, and detail that slides skip.
Maintain the original structure unless a better flow is obvious.

Slide content:
[PASTE SLIDE TEXT, SLIDE BY SLIDE]

Audience: [WHO WILL READ THIS]
Purpose: [WHY WE'RE CONVERTING IT]
```

Best for: When someone asks "can you send me that presentation as a document?"

---

8. Social Media (Prompts 32–36)

Prompt 32 — Weekly Social Media Calendar

```
Create a 5-day social media content calendar for [COMPANY NAME].
Platforms: [LINKEDIN/TWITTER/INSTAGRAM/FACEBOOK]
Industry: [INDUSTRY]
Brand voice: [PROFESSIONAL/PLAYFUL/AUTHORITATIVE/FRIENDLY]
This week's themes: [LIST 2–3 THEMES OR TOPICS]
Include: Post text, suggested image/graphic description, best posting time, hashtags.
Mix content types: [EDUCATIONAL/BEHIND-THE-SCENES/PROMOTIONAL/ENGAGEMENT]
```

Best for: Planning a week's content in 10 minutes instead of scrambling daily.

Prompt 33 — LinkedIn Thought Leadership Post

```
Write a LinkedIn post about [TOPIC] from the perspective of [YOUR ROLE] in [INDUSTRY].
Style: [STORYTELLING/DATA-DRIVEN/CONTRARIAN/LESSONS-LEARNED]
Include:
```

```
- A hook that stops the scroll (first line is everything)
- Personal insight or experience angle
- Actionable takeaway for the reader
- CTA: [COMMENT/SHARE/LINK]
Length: [SHORT (~500 chars) / MEDIUM (~1000 chars) / LONG (~1300 chars)]
```

Best for: Building personal brand on LinkedIn without staring at a blank screen.

Prompt 34 — Social Media Reply/Engagement

```
Draft replies to these [NUMBER] social media comments/mentions.
Brand voice: [DESCRIPTION]
Rules:
- Never be defensive
- Add value in every reply
- Use humor when appropriate
- Escalate negative comments: flag but don't engage publicly
- Keep replies under [WORD LIMIT] words

Comments:
[PASTE COMMENTS]
```

Best for: Maintaining engagement without spending all day on social media.

Prompt 35 — Hashtag & Trend Research

```
For [INDUSTRY/NICHE] on [PLATFORM], suggest:
1. 10 evergreen hashtags we should always use
2. 5 trending/timely hashtags for [THIS WEEK/MONTH]
3. 3 branded hashtag ideas for [COMPANY NAME]
4. Hashtag groupings for different content types:
- Educational posts
- Promotional posts
- Community/engagement posts
```

Best for: Optimizing discoverability without hashtag guesswork.

Prompt 36 — Social Proof / Testimonial Posts

```
Turn these raw customer testimonials into polished social media posts.
For each, create versions for: [LINKEDIN / INSTAGRAM / TWITTER].
Add context, emoji where appropriate, and a CTA.
Keep the customer's authentic voice — don't over-polish.

Raw testimonials:
[PASTE TESTIMONIALS]
```

```
Customer names/handles (if permitted): [LIST]
```

Best for: Showcasing happy customers in a way that drives engagement.

---

9. Sales Follow-Up (Prompts 37–40)

Prompt 37 — Post-Demo Follow-Up

```
Write a follow-up email after a product demo with [CONTACT NAME] at [COMPANY].
Demo covered: [FEATURES/TOPICS SHOWN]
They were most interested in: [SPECIFIC INTEREST]
Their main concern was: [OBJECTION/HESITATION]
Next step to propose: [TRIAL/PROPOSAL/SECOND MEETING]
Urgency factor: [NONE/QUARTER-END/COMPETITOR EVALUATION/BUDGET DEADLINE]
```

Best for: Striking while the iron is hot after a demo.

Prompt 38 — Proposal Follow-Up Sequence

```
Create a 4-email follow-up sequence for a proposal sent to [COMPANY] on [DATE].
Deal size: [AMOUNT]. Decision maker: [NAME, ROLE].
Proposal was for: [PRODUCT/SERVICE SUMMARY].

Email 1 (Day 2): Check-in, answer questions
Email 2 (Day 5): Add value, share relevant [CASE STUDY/ARTICLE]
Email 3 (Day 10): Create gentle urgency
Email 4 (Day 15): Break-up email (last attempt)

Each email under 100 words. Never sound desperate.
```

Best for: Systematic follow-up that doesn't feel pushy.

Prompt 39 — Win-Back Email

```
Write a re-engagement email to [CONTACT/COMPANY] who:
- Was a customer from [DATE] to [DATE]
- Left because of [REASON IF KNOWN]
- We've since [IMPROVEMENT/NEW FEATURE/PRICE CHANGE]

Tone: [HUMBLE/CONFIDENT/CASUAL]
Offer: [DISCOUNT/FREE TRIAL/CONSULTATION]
Make it feel personal, not automated.
```

Best for: Recovering churned customers who might give you a second chance.

Prompt 40 — Referral Request

```
Write a referral request email to [CUSTOMER NAME], a happy customer for [DURATION].
They recently [POSITIVE INTERACTION: left a review/renewed/expanded].
We're looking for referrals in [TARGET INDUSTRY/ROLE/COMPANY SIZE].
Incentive: [DISCOUNT/GIFT/CREDIT/NONE — just asking].
Keep it genuine and short. Max 100 words.
```

Best for: Systematically asking for referrals when the timing is right.

---

10. Expense Categorization (Prompts 41–43)

Prompt 41 — Bulk Expense Categorization

```
Categorize these expenses using these categories: [LIST YOUR CHART OF ACCOUNTS OR CATEGORI

For each expense, provide:
- Category
- Subcategory (if applicable)
- Tax-deductible: Yes/No/Partial
- Notes (if anything looks unusual)

Expenses:
[PASTE EXPENSE LIST: date, vendor, amount, description]
```

Best for: Month-end bookkeeping that takes hours done in minutes.

Prompt 42 — Receipt Data Extraction

```
Extract data from these [NUMBER] receipts and format as a table:
| Date | Vendor | Category | Items | Subtotal | Tax | Total | Payment Method |

Flag any receipts that:
- Might be personal (not business)
- Have unusual amounts
- Are missing critical information

Receipt text/OCR output:
[PASTE RECEIPT DATA]
```

Best for: Processing a pile of receipts without manual entry.

Prompt 43 — Expense Report Generator

```
Generate an expense report for [NAME], [DEPARTMENT], for the period [START DATE] to [END D
Company: [COMPANY NAME]
Approval manager: [MANAGER NAME]

Include:
- Summary table by category
- Individual line items with dates
- Total and per-category subtotals
- Policy compliance notes (flag anything over [AMOUNT] per meal, [AMOUNT] per night hotel)

Expenses:
[PASTE EXPENSE LIST]
```

Best for: Generating formatted expense reports ready for manager approval.

---

11. Report Generator (Prompts 44–47)

Prompt 44 — Weekly Business Summary

```
Based on this data, write a weekly business summary for [AUDIENCE: management/team/board].
Period: [DATE RANGE]

Include sections for:
- Key metrics vs. targets
- Highlights and wins
- Issues and risks
- Action items for next week
- One chart suggestion (describe what to visualize)

Raw data/notes:
[PASTE METRICS, NOTES, OR DATA POINTS]
```

Best for: Turning raw numbers into a narrative leadership can actually act on.

Prompt 45 — Client/Project Status Report

```
Create a [WEEKLY/MONTHLY] status report for the [PROJECT NAME] project.
Client: [CLIENT NAME]
```

```
Project manager: [NAME]

Sections needed:
- Executive summary (3 sentences)
- Milestone tracker (completed / in progress / upcoming)
- Budget: spent [AMOUNT] of [TOTAL], [ON TRACK/AT RISK]
- Risks and mitigations
- Next period goals

Raw updates:
[PASTE TEAM UPDATES OR NOTES]
```

Best for: Professional project updates that take 5 minutes instead of an hour.

Prompt 46 — Financial Summary from Raw Data

```
Create a financial summary from this data:
Period: [MONTH/QUARTER/YEAR]
Business: [COMPANY NAME]

Calculate and present:
- Revenue summary (by [PRODUCT/SERVICE/CLIENT])
- Expense breakdown by category
- Profit margins
- Month-over-month or quarter-over-quarter trends
- Cash position summary
- 3 key takeaways for the business owner

Data:
[PASTE FINANCIAL DATA: CSV, TABLE, OR RAW NUMBERS]
```

Best for: Owner-friendly financial snapshots without waiting for your accountant.

Prompt 47 — KPI Dashboard Text

```
Generate dashboard commentary for these KPIs:
[LIST KPIS WITH CURRENT VALUES AND TARGETS]

For each KPI:
- Status:  On Track /  At Risk /  Off Track
- One-line explanation of current performance
- Recommended action if not on track

End with a 3-sentence executive summary.
```

Best for: Adding context to numbers so dashboards actually drive decisions.

12. Contract Review (Prompts 48–50)

Prompt 48 — Contract Red Flag Scanner

```
Review this contract and flag potential issues. I am the [CLIENT/VENDOR/EMPLOYEE] side.
Business context: [BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DEAL]

Flag:
- Unusual or one-sided clauses
- Auto-renewal terms
- Liability and indemnification concerns
- Termination restrictions
- Non-compete or exclusivity clauses
- Missing standard protections
- Vague language that could be exploited

Rate overall risk: Low / Medium / High

Contract:
[PASTE CONTRACT TEXT]

⚠ Note: This is AI-assisted review, not legal advice. Consult a lawyer for significant co
```

Best for: Catching obvious red flags before sending a contract to (expensive) legal review.

Prompt 49 — Contract Summary for Non-Lawyers

```
Summarize this contract in plain English for a business owner. No legal jargon.

Cover:
1. What are we agreeing to? (2–3 sentences)
2. What do we owe? (money, deliverables, timelines)
3. What do they owe? (money, deliverables, timelines)
4. How long does this last?
5. How can either side get out?
6. What happens if something goes wrong?
7. Anything surprising or unusual?

Contract:
[PASTE CONTRACT TEXT]

⚠ Note: AI summary — not a substitute for legal review.
```

Best for: Understanding what you're actually signing without a law degree.

Prompt 50 — Contract Clause Generator

```
Draft a [CLAUSE TYPE] clause for a [CONTRACT TYPE: service agreement/NDA/employment contra

Context:
- We are: [YOUR COMPANY AND ROLE IN THE CONTRACT]
- The other party: [THEIR ROLE]
- Specific needs: [WHAT YOU WANT THE CLAUSE TO DO]
- Jurisdiction: [COUNTRY/STATE]
- Tone: [STANDARD/PROTECTIVE/BALANCED]

Provide 2 versions: one favoring our side, one balanced.

⚠ Note: Use as a starting point — have a lawyer review before including in final contract
```

Best for: Drafting specific clauses when you know what you need but not the legal language.

Tips for Getting the Best Results

1. Be specific with brackets — "Our SaaS product for HR teams" beats "our product"
2. Paste real data — The more context you give, the better the output
3. Iterate — First output is a draft. Say "make it more concise" or "add more detail about X"
4. Chain prompts — Use output from one prompt as input to another
5. Save your best customized versions — Build your own prompt library over time

---

Part of the AI Automation Playbook for SMEs — © Beorns Co

Bonus

Bonus: Tool Comparison Matrix

> Compare free and paid options for each automation use case.
>
> Prices as of 2025 — always verify current pricing before purchasing.

1. Customer Email Responses

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT (Free)	Free (GPT-3.5)	Drafting individual email replies	No email integration, manual copy-paste
ChatGPT Plus	$20/mo	Faster, smarter drafts with GPT-4	Still no native email integration
Claude (Free)	Free	Nuanced, longer email drafts	Rate limited on free tier
Claude Pro	$20/mo	High-volume email drafting, large pastes	No direct email integration
Freshdesk	Free (up to 10 agents)	Full helpdesk with AI suggestions	AI features limited on free plan
Zendesk	From $19/agent/mo	Enterprise-grade support automation	Expensive for small teams, complex setup
HubSpot Service Hub	Free (basic)	CRM-integrated email + ticketing	AI features require paid plans ($45+/mo)
Help Scout	From $20/user/mo	Small team email support with AI drafts	No free tier
Intercom Fin	From $0.99/resolution	AI-first customer support bot	Pay-per-resolution adds up fast

Recommendation: Start with ChatGPT/Claude free for drafting. Move to Freshdesk free for organized ticketing. Upgrade to Zendesk or HubSpot when you outgrow it.

2. FAQ & Knowledge Base

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
Notion	Free (personal)	Internal wikis and knowledge bases	Limited AI features on free plan
Notion AI	$10/user/mo add-on	AI-powered KB with auto-summarization	Add-on with multiple users
GitBook	Free (personal/OSS)	Developer-friendly public docs	Not ideal for non-technical teams
Document360	From $149/mo	Professional customer-facing KB	Pricey for small businesses
Freshdesk KB	Free (included)	KB integrated with support tickets	Basic formatting and design
Zendesk Guide	From $19/agent/mo	Polished self-service portal	Part of broader (expensive) Zendesk suite

ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Generating FAQ content from sources	Manual publishing required
Helpjuice	From $120/mo	Dedicated KB with analytics	Expensive for what it does
WordPress + plugin	Free–$50/yr	Self-hosted KB on your own site	Requires setup and maintenance

Recommendation: Use ChatGPT/Claude to generate content, Notion (free) for internal KB, Freshdesk (free) for customer-facing. Upgrade to Document360 if KB is critical to your business.

---

3. Lead Qualification

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
HubSpot CRM	Free	Basic lead tracking and scoring	Advanced scoring needs $800+/mo Marke
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Manual lead scoring from pasted data	No CRM integration, no automation
Pipedrive	From $14/user/mo	Visual sales pipeline management	AI features limited on basic plans
Salesforce	From $25/user/mo	Enterprise CRM with Einstein AI	Complex, expensive, overkill for most SMI
Apollo.io	Free (limited)	Lead enrichment + outreach	Aggressive upselling, data quality varies
Instantly.ai	From $30/mo	Cold email automation	Email deliverability requires setup
Lemlist	From $59/mo	Personalized cold outreach	Learning curve, no free tier
Zapier	Free (100 tasks/mo)	Connecting lead forms to CRM/sheets	Limited tasks on free, logic gets complex
Make.com	Free (1,000 ops/mo)	Visual workflow for lead routing	Steeper learning curve than Zapier

Recommendation: HubSpot CRM free + ChatGPT for scoring. Add Zapier/Make.com to automate lead routing. Upgrade to Pipedrive when pipeline grows.

---

4. Meeting Notes & Action Items

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
Otter.ai	Free (300 min/mo)	Real-time transcription with speaker ID	Free tier limits, English-focused
Otter.ai Pro	$16.99/user/mo	Unlimited transcription + AI summaries	Still primarily English
Fireflies.ai	Free (limited)	Meeting bot that auto-joins calls	Free tier recording limits
Fireflies.ai Pro	$18/user/mo	Unlimited recording + AI summaries	Can feel intrusive joining meetings
Fathom	Free (unlimited)	AI meeting summaries for Zoom	Zoom-only on free, limited integrations
tl;dv	Free (limited)	Meeting recording for Zoom + Google Meet	Recording limits on free
Grain	Free (limited)	Clip and share meeting highlights	Limited storage on free
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Summarizing pasted transcripts	Manual — no auto-recording
Microsoft Copilot	$30/user/mo (M365)	Native Teams meeting summaries	Requires Microsoft 365 subscription

Google Gemini	Free (in Workspace)	Google Meet transcription + notes	Limited AI features on free Workspace

Recommendation: Start with Fathom (free, unlimited for Zoom) or Otter.ai (free, 300 min/mo). Use ChatGPT/Claude to process transcripts. Upgrade to Fireflies Pro for full automation across platforms.

---

5. Document Processing

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT	Free	Extracting data from pasted text	Can't process images/PDFs directly (free)
ChatGPT Plus	$20/mo	PDF upload + data extraction	File size limits
Claude	Free	Long document analysis (100K+ tokens)	No native file processing on free
Claude Pro	$20/mo	Upload and analyze large documents	100K token context still has limits
Google Document AI	Free (1,000 pages/mo)	OCR and structured data extraction	Technical setup required (API)
Adobe Acrobat AI	$22.99/mo	PDF-specific AI assistant	Adobe ecosystem lock-in
Nanonets	Free (limited)	Invoice/receipt processing with AI	Low free tier limits
Docsumo	From $100/mo	Automated document data extraction	Pricey for low volume
Zapier + AI	From $19.99/mo	Document workflow automation	AI actions cost extra credits

Recommendation: Claude Pro is the best value for document analysis (long context). Use Google Document AI (free) for OCR. ChatGPT Plus for general document Q&A.

---

6. SOP Generator

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Generating SOPs from descriptions	Manual formatting and storage
Scribe	Free (limited)	Auto-captures SOPs from screenshots	Free limits on guides
Scribe Pro	$29/user/mo	Unlimited auto-generated process docs	Expensive per user
Tango	Free (limited)	Step-by-step guides with screenshots	Browser-only capture, free limits
Process Street	Free (limited)	Structured SOP checklists and workflows	Limited free plan, complex pricing
Notion	Free	Organizing and storing SOPs	No auto-capture, manual writing
Trainual	From $249/mo	Full SOP + training platform	Very expensive for small teams
Loom	Free (up to 25 videos)	Video SOPs and walkthroughs	Not structured text SOPs
Slite	Free (limited)	Team documentation with AI	Small free tier

Recommendation: ChatGPT/Claude to write the SOP + Scribe (free) to auto-capture browser processes +

Notion (free) to organize. This combo costs $0 and covers 90% of needs.

7. Content Repurposing

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Rewriting content for different formats	Manual copy-paste, no publishing
Descript	Free (limited)	Video/podcast to text, clip creation	Watermark on free, limited exports
Descript Pro	$24/mo	Full video/audio editing + transcription	Learning curve
Opus Clip	Free (limited)	Auto-clips from long videos	Limited free exports
Repurpose.io	From $20.75/mo	Auto-publish to multiple platforms	Doesn't create content, just distributes
Canva	Free	Graphics for repurposed content	AI features limited on free
Canva Pro	$12.99/mo	Full design suite + AI image gen	Template-heavy aesthetic
Castmagic	From $23/mo	Podcast → blog/social/newsletter	Podcast-specific only
WriteSonic	Free (limited)	AI writing for various formats	Quality inconsistent, free limits

Recommendation: ChatGPT/Claude for text repurposing (free), Descript free for video/audio, Canva free for graphics. This covers the full pipeline at $0.

8. Social Media Management

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
Buffer	Free (3 channels)	Simple scheduling for small teams	Limited analytics, 3 channels only
Buffer Essentials	$6/channel/mo	More channels + analytics	Costs grow with channels
Hootsuite	From $99/mo	Enterprise social management	Very expensive, overkill for SMEs
Later	Free (limited)	Visual planning, Instagram-focused	Limited posts on free
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Generating post content	No scheduling or publishing
Canva	Free	Creating social media graphics	Limited templates on free
Metricool	Free (limited)	Analytics + scheduling in one	Small free tier
SocialBee	From $29/mo	Category-based scheduling + AI	No free tier
Publer	Free (limited)	Multi-platform scheduling	Limited on free
Taplio	From $49/mo	LinkedIn-specific growth tool	LinkedIn only, expensive

Recommendation: Buffer free (scheduling) + ChatGPT/Claude (content creation) + Canva free (graphics). Upgrade to Buffer paid when you need more channels.

9. Sales Follow-Up

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
HubSpot CRM	Free	Email tracking + sequences (limited)	Advanced sequences need Sales Hub ($45
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Writing follow-up email copy	No send/track capability
Pipedrive	From $14/user/mo	Pipeline + email integration	Email automation on higher tiers
Instantly.ai	From $30/mo	Cold email sequences at scale	Deliverability needs warm-up
Mailshake	From $58/user/mo	Sales email automation	Expensive per user
Mixmax	Free (limited)	Gmail sequences and tracking	Limited free tier
Apollo.io	Free (limited)	Combined prospecting + follow-up	Data quality varies
Streak	Free (limited)	CRM built into Gmail	Limited on free, Gmail only
Close.com	From $49/user/mo	All-in-one sales CRM	No free tier

Recommendation: HubSpot CRM free (tracking) + ChatGPT/Claude (writing) for starters. Add Streak free for Gmail-native CRM. Upgrade to Pipedrive or Instantly when volume justifies it.

---

10. Expense Categorization

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Categorizing pasted expense lists	Manual, no bank connection
QuickBooks Simple Start	From $30/mo	Full accounting with auto-categorization	Monthly cost, learning curve
QuickBooks Self-Employed	From $15/mo	Freelancers and solopreneurs	Limited features vs. full QuickBooks
Xero Starter	From $15/mo	Clean accounting with bank feeds	Limited invoices on starter
Wave	Free	Full accounting for small businesses	US/Canada focused, no payroll in EU
FreshBooks	From $17/mo	Invoice-first accounting	Weaker expense tracking than QBO/Xero
Zoho Books	Free (under $50K rev)	Full accounting for micro-businesses	Free tier revenue cap
Fyle	From $6.99/user/mo	Real-time expense management	Adds up with team size
Expensify	Free (limited)	Receipt scanning + categorization	Free tier very limited

Recommendation: Wave (free) or Zoho Books (free for <$50K) for full accounting. Use ChatGPT/Claude to batch-categorize when needed. Upgrade to QuickBooks or Xero when complexity demands it.

---

11. Report Generator

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT/Claude	Free	Writing narrative reports from data	No live data connections
Google Sheets + AI	Free	Basic reporting with Gemini AI	AI features still rolling out
Notion	Free	Report templates and databases	No advanced analytics
Google Looker Studio	Free	Visual dashboards and reports	Learning curve, needs data sources
Microsoft Power BI	Free (desktop)	Advanced data visualization	Complex, needs structured data
Databox	Free (3 data sources)	KPI dashboards pulling from tools	Limited sources on free
Geckoboard	From $39/mo	TV-ready KPI dashboards	Expensive for what it does
Supermetrics	From $29/mo	Pull marketing data into sheets	Marketing-specific
Chartbrew	Free (self-hosted)	Open-source dashboard builder	Requires technical setup

Recommendation: ChatGPT/Claude for narrative reports + Google Looker Studio (free) for dashboards. This covers 90% of SME reporting needs at $0.

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12. Contract Review

Tool	Price	Best For	Limitations
ChatGPT Plus	$20/mo	Upload and review contracts	Not legal advice, misses nuance
Claude Pro	$20/mo	Long contract analysis (100K context)	Not legal advice
Gemini Advanced	$20/mo	Google's AI for document review	Newer, less tested for legal
Juro	From $50/mo	Contract creation and management	Pricey, more for creation than review
Ironclad	Custom pricing	Enterprise contract lifecycle	Way too expensive for SMEs
DocuSign CLM	Custom pricing	Contract lifecycle management	Enterprise pricing
Spellbook	From $49/mo	AI built specifically for legal review	Designed for lawyers, not laypeople
LawGeex	Custom pricing	Automated contract review	Enterprise only
DocuSign (e-sign)	From $10/mo	Signing, not reviewing	No AI review capability
PandaDoc	Free (e-sign only)	Document creation + e-signatures	No AI contract review on free

Recommendation: Claude Pro (best for long documents) or ChatGPT Plus for AI-assisted review. Always get a real lawyer for important contracts. Use DocuSign or PandaDoc for signing.

Best Value Stack for SMEs (Starting at $0)

Need	Free Pick	Best Paid Upgrade
AI Writing & Analysis	ChatGPT / Claude free	ChatGPT Plus or Claude Pro ($20/mo)

Customer Support	Freshdesk free	Zendesk ($19/agent/mo)
CRM & Sales	HubSpot CRM free	Pipedrive ($14/user/mo)
Meeting Notes	Fathom free	Fireflies Pro ($18/user/mo)
Social Media	Buffer free	Buffer Essentials ($6/channel/mo)
Accounting	Wave / Zoho Books free	QuickBooks ($30/mo)
Knowledge Base	Notion free	Document360 ($149/mo)
SOP Capture	Scribe free	Scribe Pro ($29/user/mo)
Automation Glue	Zapier free / Make.com free	Zapier Starter ($19.99/mo)
Design	Canva free	Canva Pro ($12.99/mo)
E-signatures	PandaDoc free	DocuSign ($10/mo)
Dashboards	Google Looker Studio free	Databox ($0–$72/mo)

Total cost to start: $0. Scale up tool by tool as revenue justifies it.

Part of the AI Automation Playbook for SMEs — © Beorns Co

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Visit beornsco.github.io for more resources
and our complete AI toolkit for SMEs.

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